

Um Welt

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UM WELT

A Novel of Heinz Stücke

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For Heinz Stücke.

Chapter 1: Hövelhof, November

The freewheel needed oil. He noticed it the way he noticed everything about the bicycle now, which was with the attention other men gave to their own pulse: a tick under the frame, once a second, faint enough that a passenger would have missed it, loud enough that fifty kilometres in it would be the only sound left in his skull. He had oiled it twice this week already. He was leaving in an hour and he oiled it again, working the rag into the hub with his thumb, not because the hub needed it a third time but because his hands needed something to do that was not standing still in the cold yard waiting for the morning to arrive at its own pace.

His hands did this without asking him. Three years at the machine shop had made his hands independent of the rest of him — they could true a wheel or file a burr while his mind was three streets over, or three countries, thinking about nothing, thinking about the shape of a coastline he'd traced once with a fingertip in a school atlas and never quite put down again, the way the world went on being wider than Hövelhof no matter how carefully you avoided looking at the fact. He was twenty-two. He had made, by his own rough count, several hundred identical steel components that month, each one a few grams of tolerance from the last, and the two hundred and eleventh had felt exactly like the first, the same weight in the same hand, the same click as the die closed, and somewhere around component one hundred and fifty he had begun, without deciding to, counting them the way a

prisoner counts days.

He had tried to explain this once, badly, three beers into a Friday at the bar on Bahnhofstrasse, to Manfred and to Manfred's cousin who was down from Paderborn and who kept asking, not unkindly, what exactly Stücker thought he would do for money once he got wherever he was apparently going. Stücker had not had a good answer. He had said something about not wanting to make the same part every day until he died, and Manfred's cousin had laughed, not cruelly, and said that was called a job, and that everyone had one, and that the ones who didn't complain about it simply hadn't found theirs annoying yet. Stücker had let it go. He did not have the words that night for the difference between a job you complained about and a life you had already, secretly, priced out and found too small, and he suspected, riding home in the dark with the beer still warm in him, that there might not be words for it at all, only a bicycle and a direction and the slow proof of years.

The bicycle was a Rabeneick, black frame going grey at the head tube where his palm had worn the paint down over three years of Sunday rides out past the Sennelager pines and back before dark, three gears, a rack he had welded on himself the week before using an offcut and a favour from Dieter at the shop, who had looked at the drawing Stücker handed him, looked at Stücker, and welded it straight anyway without asking a single question, because that was what you did for a friend who had clearly already made up his mind about something foolish. Two panniers, waxed canvas, his mother's idea, sewn from a pattern she had not admitted to owning until the week she produced it, folded, from the bottom of the sideboard, as if she had been keeping it there for exactly this occasion and simply waiting to be asked. A spare tube. A hand pump. A small knife with a bone handle that had been his grandfather's, kept more for the handle than the blade. Forty Deutschmarks in a tobacco tin wrapped in a sock at the bottom of the left pannier, which was, when he made himself add it up standing in the cold of the yard with his breath showing, close to everything he owned that could honestly be called capital.

He did not own a plan beyond Cologne. He had told people Cologne

because Cologne was a real place with a real cathedral that even Manfred's cousin had heard of, and because saying "and then I don't know" out loud, to another human being, in Hövelhof, before he had even left it, felt like handing someone a rope to pull him back with. Privately, in the part of his mind that did not need to satisfy a bar full of neighbours, he did not think of Cologne as a destination at all. He thought of it the way you think of the first rung of a ladder: proof that the thing was climbable, nothing more.

His mother stood in the kitchen doorway with her arms folded into her cardigan, not to keep him there and not to help him go, just standing, the way she had stood eighteen months earlier when he'd told her he was quitting the tool-and-die apprenticeship his father had spent four years and no small amount of pride arranging for him. She had not been surprised then either. There is a way a mother looks at a son when she has already, privately, filed him under *will not stay*, and it is not despair, and it is not pride. It is closer to the look you give weather: you do not blame the sky for doing what skies do, you simply dress for it.

"You'll write," she said. It was not a question and he did not answer it as one.

"From Cologne," he said, which was true, and which was also the only part of the sentence he could actually promise.

"And after Cologne."

He did not answer that at all, and she did not make him, which he understood, even at twenty-two, as its own kind of gift — the gift of a question asked once, honestly, and then not repeated when it went unanswered, because some questions are asked to be on the record rather than to be resolved.

The yard smelled of coal smoke and wet gravel. Hövelhof in November smelled the same as it had every November of his life — the Senelager pines beyond the last house going black-green in low light, the particular flat grey of a Westphalian sky that seemed to sit two metres above the rooftops and go no higher, a sky with the lid still on. He would think of that sky again and again over the following five

decades, in country after country, comparing every horizon he found against it, the way you check your own growth against a doorframe. Ceylon's sky had no lid at all; it went up and up until looking at it made him faintly dizzy, standing in a field the first time he properly noticed. Zambia's, years later, came down like a hand, low and close and the colour of a bruise before a storm. He did not know any of this yet, in the yard, at twenty-two. He knew the freewheel needed oil, and that it had been oiled, three times now, past any reasonable claim of usefulness, and that his mother's arms were folded, and that somewhere past Cologne there was more world, and that the two hundred and eleventh identical steel part, filed to the same tolerance as the first, had told him everything the shop foreman's compliments could not: that he was going to spend his whole life making the same object over and over, at the same bench, under the same grey lid of sky, if he did not leave today, this morning, while the willingness was still louder than the fear.

He did not say goodbye to his father, who was already at the second shift and would hear about the departure from a neighbour before he heard it from his son, which was its own kind of message, sent in the only language the two of them had ever reliably shared — his father a man who communicated approval through the quality of tools he lent you and disapproval through their sudden unavailability, and who had, in the six weeks since Stücker quit the apprenticeship, stopped lending him anything at all, a silence more total and more legible than any argument could have been. Stücker had considered, standing in the yard, walking the half kilometre to the factory gate to say it to his father's face. He decided against it. Not out of cowardice, he told himself, though he was never afterward entirely sure that was the whole truth of it; more because he did not trust himself to leave at all if he had to first survive the particular silence his father would produce in response, a silence Stücker had watched break stronger men than himself.

He put his foot on the pedal. The frame took his weight the way it had taken it every Sunday for three years, no different, no premonition in the steel, and that was the first lesson the bicycle taught him, before Zaire, before Zambia, before the mountains that would eventually stop

being metaphor and become simply Tuesday: the machine does not know what the day is for. It goes the same whether you are going to church or going around the earth. Only the rider knows, and even the rider, on the morning itself, mostly does not.

Frau Ostermann, three houses down, was beating a rug over her railing in the cold and called something after him about the weather that he didn't catch and didn't ask her to repeat, because he had already decided, somewhere below the level where he made decisions on purpose, that he was not going to look back at Hövelhof today. He looked back at it plenty in the years afterward — he would look back at it from a hospital cot in Java, from a police cell in Cameroon, from the deck of a tramp steamer somewhere in the Malacca Strait smelling of diesel and drying fish, so often and so completely that the village became less a place than a direction his mind faced when it needed rest. But not that morning. That morning he kept his eyes on the road, which had a skin of frost on it that made the tyres sing a half-tone higher than usual, and did the only thing a young man leaving a small town on a bicycle with forty marks and no plan can do, which is pedal, and keep pedalling, and let the pedalling answer questions the standing-still never could.

He would be gone, though nobody in that kitchen or that yard or the shop where his vacancy would be filled by Thursday could have said so with a straight face, for more than fifty years. He would put more than six hundred thousand kilometres under those wheels — under this frame, more or less; frames get rewelded, repainted, re-spoked, and a man who tells you it is the same bicycle after fifty years is telling you something true about continuity that has nothing to do with the metal. He would be shot in the foot by men who believed in something, and starved by an illness that believed in nothing. He would be robbed of the bicycle itself, more than once, and get it back, more than once, because there is a kind of theft that runs out of uses for a stranger's overloaded touring bike faster than the stranger runs out of patience. He would reach a shore in the Indian Ocean thirty-four years from this frosted road and feel, having by then seen what a man could fairly claim was the whole of the inhabited earth, not triumph but a small, disorienting hunger to keep going, as though the finishing had been

the least interesting part of the plan. He did not know any of that on the Hövelhof road in November of 1962. He knew the frost was making the road sing, and that Cologne was three days off at his present rate, and that behind him a woman with her arms folded into her cardigan was already turning back into the warm kitchen, because there is only so long you can stand in a doorway watching a shape get smaller.

He did not look back. The freewheel ticked, once a second, all the way to the crossroads, and then he was over the rise and Hövelhof — its shop, its bar, its lidded November sky, its two hundred and eleven identical steel parts a week — was a place he had left the way you leave a coat you no longer need on a chair, without ceremony, meaning to come back for it eventually, not yet knowing that eventually was the one word that was going to organize the rest of his life.

Chapter 2: The Arithmetic of Staying Alive

Cologne, when he reached it, was not the point, and he understood that within a day of arriving, standing in the shadow of the cathedral with his neck craned back and his hands, out of habit, going to the camera around his neck before his mind had finished deciding the view was worth the film. Three days on the road had already changed something in the way he looked at buildings, at weather, at strangers' faces — a new appetite for noticing, sharpened by the plain fact that noticing was now the only entertainment his forty marks could afford him. He photographed the cathedral from an angle that put a barge in the foreground on the Rhine, because a schoolteacher he'd shared a barn with outside Bonn had told him, unprompted, that a photograph with only one subject was a photograph with no story in it, and he had filed the observation away the way he filed away everything useful that a stranger offered him for free.

He did not sell that photograph. He did not yet know he could. That lesson arrived a little further on, in Austria, in a manner so unglamorous that he was for years faintly embarrassed to admit how much of his working life had been decided by it: cold, down to coins he could count on one hand, sheltering under the eaves of a church in a small town whose name he later forgot and never fully recovered, he had photographed the church against the mountain behind it because it was in front of him and the rain showed no sign of stopping and a man has to point a camera at something while he waits. A shop-

keeper across the square, closing up for the evening, had seen the developed print a week later — Stücker, unable to resist the vanity of a good exposure, had shown it to the man who ran the chemist's where he'd had it printed on credit — and asked, with the flat practicality of someone who has run a till for thirty years and recognizes a saleable object on sight, whether he could buy three copies to put out for the coach parties.

Stücker said yes before he understood what he was agreeing to. It took him the better part of a year of hunger, of counting coins in doorways, of learning the hard way which towns had a print shop and which did not, to understand what he had stumbled onto in that one wet evening: he was not a labourer on an extended holiday, subsisting on savings that would eventually run out the way savings always do. He was a photographer with a route, and the route paid for the film, and the film paid for the route, and there was no structural reason, once he understood the arithmetic properly, for the whole arrangement to ever have to end. He began keeping a small ledger in the back of a notebook — prints sold, prints owed, addresses of shopkeepers who might want more next season — with the same neat, tolerance-obsessed hand he had once used to record die measurements at the shop, the old training finding, without his particular intending it, a new use.

The second thing he learned that first winter was smaller and meaner and considerably more useful: a man on a bicycle with panniers looks poor enough to be pitied and clean enough to be trusted, and the two together open more doors than money ever does. He was fed, that winter, by people who would not have fed a man arriving in a car. He slept in a hay barn outside Villach because a farmer took one look at the bicycle, the mud to his knees, and the camera slung around his neck, and decided, without being asked, that this was a traveller and not a vagrant — a distinction that exists nowhere in any law he ever encountered and everywhere in the posture of a man's shoulders, in the specific way he holds a bicycle rather than merely standing near one. Stücker learned, over that winter, to stand the way the farmer had expected a traveller to stand: back straight, bicycle held with both hands at the same casual competence with which a farmer holds a rake, eyes meeting the other man's rather than sliding away in the

manner of someone with something to hide. He was not proud of learning it. It was simply a fact about the road, the way gear ratios were a fact, and he filed it next to the other facts and used it, quietly, for fifty years.

He did not go home for Christmas. He told himself it was the distance, and the distance was real — he was somewhere past Ljubljana by then, still finding his legs, still faintly amazed at how far a malnourished body could carry itself on porridge and stubbornness alone — but the truer arithmetic, the one he did not examine closely until he was much older, was that going home once would have made the leaving negotiable, would have given his father one clean opportunity to simply not lend him the bicycle back, and he did not trust himself, at twenty-two, to leave a second time if the first leaving could still be undone by a single argument in a kitchen. His mother's one letter that reached him that winter, forwarded twice by an address he'd scrawled on a postcard from Graz, said only that his father had not mentioned him once since the departure and asked about him constantly, which she seemed to consider entirely consistent, and which Stücker, at twenty-two, did not understand at all. He understood it a great deal better, decades later, from the far side of a number of silences of his own making.

The three-speed hub gave him endless trouble in the mountains — you learn quickly what “three speeds” actually means when the middle gear vanishes somewhere over a pass and you are left choosing between a ratio for the flat and a ratio that will strip the chain on anything steeper than a driveway — and he became, in the space of that first year, a mechanic out of pure necessity, the kind of mechanic who has no manual and no spare part and therefore only the bicycle's own internal logic to reason from. He learned to true a wheel with a spoke key balanced against his knee at the side of a road, sighting the rim by eye the way he had once sighted a lathe bit at the die shop, the old shop discipline transferring wholesale into a context his former foreman would never have recognized and would, Stücker thought more than once with a private, unexpected fondness, grudgingly have approved of. Tolerance was tolerance, in a wheel or in a die. A wobble was still, after all, a part that had failed to hold its shape under load, and the fix was still patience applied at the point of the failure,

nowhere else.

He crossed into Yugoslavia not knowing a word of Serbo-Croat and came out the other side six weeks later with enough of it to buy bread, ask directions, and decline, with increasing tact, the second and third glasses of the local spirit that every household he stayed in seemed to consider a mortal insult to refuse. He learned the specific etiquette of a Balkan table before he learned much of the language that surrounded it — that a glass set down half full was an insult and a glass drained too eagerly was a request for another, that a guest who ate lightly worried his hosts more than a guest who ate everything in sight, that the men of a house sat and talked while the women moved constantly between kitchen and table in a choreography he found himself, uncomfortably, unable to help with no matter how many times he tried, waved back to his chair each time with the same firm, amused insistence. He crossed into Greece afterward and discovered that a bicycle, alone among every form of transport he had used or would use, makes a foreigner instantly legible in a way a car never does: people could see the whole of his risk, parked leaning against their wall, dust on the panniers, mud dried into the chain, and this seemed to entitle him, village after village, to a hospitality that had nothing to do with charity and everything to do with a very old, very widespread respect for effort visibly and honestly spent. He noticed this, and filed it away for later use, and found, over the following decades and in country after country, that this particular respect crossed borders far more reliably than currency did, and considerably more reliably than his German passport, which some places loved and some places, for reasons that had nothing to do with him personally, did not.

By the time he reached Istanbul — cold, thinner than he had been in Cologne, his beard grown out because a razor was one more thing to carry and one more thing to lose on a bad night — he had stopped thinking of the trip as something with a natural end. This was not a decision he made in any single moment he could later point to. It arrived the way fog arrives, a little at a time, until one morning he woke in a stranger's outbuilding smelling of woodsmoke and lamp oil and realized that he had not, in several weeks, thought about Hövelhof, the shop, or the forty marks, long since spent and replaced twice over by

postcard money he had made and sent ahead to himself, general delivery, to addresses he guessed he might reach in three months' time. He had, without noticing the exact moment it happened, stopped being a young man on an extended holiday and become something without a good German word for it yet, something the road itself would eventually teach him to call by a plainer name: a rider. Not a tourist, a word that implied a return ticket already purchased. Not an adventurer, a word he came to actively dislike over the years, since it implied the point was the adventure and not the seeing, the danger and not the road that produced it incidentally. A rider. A man for whom the bicycle was now simply the terms under which he existed in the world, the way a fish's terms are water, unnoticed until you try to imagine the fish without it.

He wrote his mother from Ankara, a longer letter than the postcards, and told her, in the flat practical language the two of them had always used with each other because neither entirely trusted the other kind, that he was well, that the camera was earning its keep, that he did not know when he would be back, and that she should not wait dinner. He meant it kindly, in the only register kindness had ever taken between them. She kept the letter for thirty years, he learned much later, in a tin with the postcards, in the same drawer as a photograph of him at nineteen in his apprentice's overalls, unsmiling, holding a finished die up to the light the way another young man might have held up a fish he was proud of. Two photographs of the same hands, ten years and one continent apart, and neither of them, seen side by side, told you anything true about what had actually happened between the two mornings they were taken. That gap — the one no photograph could show — was the whole subject of his life, and he had not yet learned that it would take him fifty years and six hundred thousand kilometres to even begin to describe it to himself, let alone to anyone else who asked.

Chapter 3: The Border Trade

The border post outside Gaziantep taught him the first version of a lesson he would relearn, with variations, in perhaps forty countries over the following decades: that a border is not a line so much as a mood, and the mood belongs entirely to whichever official happens to be on duty the morning you arrive.

He had crossed a dozen minor frontiers by then without serious trouble — a stamp, a question about his intentions that he had learned to answer in the fewest possible words, a customs man's cursory glance into a pannier that held nothing more alarming than a spare tube, a tin of tea, and a stack of unsold postcards. He had begun to believe, with the particular overconfidence of a man young enough to have not yet been proven wrong, that a bicycle and an honest face were sufficient documentation for most of the world. The official at Gaziantep disabused him of that within the first two minutes, turning the postcards over one by one on the counter with a slow, deliberate suspicion, as though a photograph of an Austrian church might conceal something the young German traveller had failed to declare. Stucke stood very still and said very little, having already learned, if not yet perfectly, that an anxious traveller reads to a bored official as a guilty one, and that the single most useful thing he could do in a moment like this was appear more bored than the man behind the counter.

It worked, that time. It did not always work, in later years, in later countries, with later officials whose boredom was a genuine danger

rather than a mood to be waited out, but that morning in Gaziantep it worked, and he rode on into Syria with the specific lightness of a young man who has just discovered that patience is a tool as real and as usable as a spoke key.

Syria gave him the desert properly for the first time — not the post-card desert of dunes, which he would not see in any quantity until much later and much further south, but the flat, stony, underestimated desert of scrub and heat-shimmer that runs for a hundred kilometres between one qanat-fed village and the next, and that taught him, inside of a single terrible afternoon outside Homs, the actual arithmetic of water on a bicycle: how much a body loses per hour at what temperature, how far ahead you had to think, how a headache that felt like tiredness at two in the afternoon could become, by four, something considerably more serious if you let your attention wander for even one village. He did let it wander, once, badly, misjudging the distance to a village whose name a map in Aleppo had rendered in a script he could not yet read with confidence, and arrived light-headed and stumbling, pushing rather than riding the last two kilometres, to a household that took one look at him and moved with the calm, practised speed of people who had seen a heat-struck traveller before and knew exactly what to do about it: shade first, then small amounts of water, then more, over an hour, while an old woman fanned him with a folded newspaper and told him something in Arabic he did not understand and did not need to, because the tone alone — patient, faintly amused at his foolishness, entirely without malice — carried the whole of the message.

He learned, from that household and a dozen like it across the following months, the specific choreography of hospitality in a part of the world where a guest was treated, structurally, as a kind of sacred emergency: fed first and questioned second, given the best cushion in the room without discussion, and — this took him longest to learn to accept gracefully — never, under any circumstances, permitted to see or contribute toward the true cost of what he was being given. He tried, in the early months, to leave coins on a table or press money into a reluctant hand, and learned each time, from the sudden coolness that crossed a host's face, that he had made a specific and recoverable

social error: he had treated a gift as a transaction, which insulted the giver far more than accepting the gift with nothing offered in return ever could. He adjusted. He began instead leaving a postcard, a print of some other village's church or minaret, a small object with no direct financial value that nonetheless said, in the universal language of small gestures, *I saw you, and I will remember this house specifically, among all the houses of this whole enormous journey*. It worked better than money ever had. He kept doing it, in one form or another, for fifty years, and came to think of the postcards less as merchandise, in these moments, and more as a kind of currency invented for exactly this purpose: payment that did not insult.

The camera itself was becoming, by the time he crossed into Lebanon and then south toward the coast, something closer to a second livelihood than a hobby that happened to pay for itself. He had learned to read a market for what would sell — not the grandest view but the specific, ownable image: a doorway, a single fisherman's boat pulled up at dawn, a child glimpsed mid-laugh and never photographed again, the kind of image a shopkeeper could imagine a tourist wanting to send home precisely because it suggested a place rather than merely documenting one. He was not, by his own later, characteristically blunt assessment, a great photographer in any technical sense; he had never studied light or composition beyond what the schoolteacher outside Bonn had told him about a barge in a river. But he had, by the end of that first year, developed something more useful to his specific circumstances than technical skill: an instinct for which twelve frames out of a roll of thirty-six a market would actually pay for, and the discipline, hard-won and expensive at first, to stop wasting film on the eleven he liked but could not sell.

He crossed a tense border further south that year with a nervousness he did not entirely understand until he was standing at the checkpoint itself and understood, watching the specific tension in the soldiers' shoulders, the particular way their eyes moved to his documents and then back to his face and then to the documents again, that he had ridden, without fully registering it from the map alone, into a place actively organizing itself around the possibility of violence. It was his first encounter with that specific atmosphere — not war exactly, not

yet, but the tight, watchful quiet that precedes it, the quiet of men checking papers who are not entirely sure, themselves, what the correct response to an irregularity would be, because the rules had not finished being written. He passed through without incident. He rode on with the particular, hollow-stomached relief of a young man who has, for the first time, understood in his body rather than merely in his head that some roads carried a genuine cost for being wrong about them, and that his own good intentions and his bicycle's evident poverty would not always be sufficient credentials.

He wrote almost nothing home about that specific checkpoint, not out of any dramatic instinct for secrecy but because he had already, within a single year on the road, begun developing the habit that would define his correspondence for the rest of his life: the letters home got smaller as the experiences got larger, not because he had less to say but because he had decided, somewhere in that first year, that the account he owed his mother was reassurance, not chronicle. He was well. He was managing. He would write again from the next post office he found. The actual weight of what those sentences were carrying — a checkpoint, a heatstroke, a household that had fed a stranger without once asking his name — he kept, increasingly, for himself, filed away with the tolerance-obsessed precision of a man who had once measured steel for a living and now, without quite meaning to, had begun measuring his own life the same way: privately, exactly, and mostly for an audience of one.

Chapter 4: The Continent That Would Not Be Hurried

Africa did not announce itself as a single experience, and he learned within the first month to distrust anyone — including, later, himself, in careless conversation — who spoke of it as though it were one place with one weather and one temperament. It was, by the time he had ridden the length of it once, closer to a shelf of separate countries stacked so densely against one another that a single day's riding could carry him through three distinct languages, three distinct currencies, and three entirely different sets of unwritten rules about what a foreigner on a bicycle was permitted to photograph, ask, or assume.

What he learned first, and what took him longest to properly absorb, was patience of a different order than anything the European roads had asked of him. A puncture outside a Balkan village might cost him an afternoon. A puncture on certain stretches of unpaved African road, in the wrong season, could cost him three days simply waiting for a lift with a spare tube to pass, or for the specific, unhurried competence of a village mechanic who might not touch the tyre until the following morning, not from any indifference to Stücker's predicament but because the man had a genuine sequence of his own obligations to work through first, and a foreigner's impatience was not, in his own house, a priority that outranked them. Stücker fought this, at first, the way any young European raised on factory schedules and shift bells fights it — checking his watch, doing sums about lost kilometres, composing, silently, the complaint he would never actually voice. He stopped

fighting it somewhere in his second year on the continent, not because he had become a wiser man in any general sense but because he had run the arithmetic often enough to notice that the impatience cost him more than the waiting ever had: a night lost to poor sleep worrying about delay was a worse trade than a night lost to the delay itself.

He learned the specific, humbling mathematics of distance at a scale Europe had not prepared him for. A hundred kilometres in Austria was an ambitious but ordinary day. A hundred kilometres on a red-dirt track in the dry season, corrugated by trucks into a washboard that shook his teeth and loosened, more than once, a rack bolt he had to stop and retighten every hour, was an entirely different unit of measurement, one that had as much to do with heat and water and the specific resilience of his own back and hands as it did with the number on the cyclometer he had rigged, not entirely accurately, from a bicycle shop in Vienna. He learned to ride at first light and rest through the worst of the midday heat under whatever shade presented itself — a tree, a culvert, once memorably the shadow of an abandoned lorry that had been stripped of everything valuable and left, years before his arrival, exactly where it had broken down, a rusting monument to some earlier traveller's worse luck than his own.

The camera economy, which had kept him fed through the Balkans and the Levant on the strength of postcards of churches and minarets, needed retuning for an audience that had different appetites and different means. He learned, slowly and at some early financial cost, that the market for postcards of village life sold better to the handful of European and American travellers passing through on organized tours than to the villages themselves, who had little use for a photograph of their own daily existence and considerably more use, when they had spare coin at all, for the simple service of having a message or a document read aloud by a stranger who could manage the relevant colonial language a little more fluently than the local schoolteacher. Stücke adjusted his offer without complaint, reading letters and filling in forms at village post offices in exchange for a meal or a roof, treating literacy — a skill he had never once considered valuable in Hövelhof, where everyone around him could read — as simply another tool in the same

kit as the spoke key and the small knife with the bone handle, useful because the road had made it useful, not because it had ever been useful before.

He met, in those first African years, a specific category of person he came to think of, privately, as the keepers of the road: mission station staff, colonial district officers on their way out as independence movements gathered pace around them, missionary doctors running clinics with a tenth of what they needed, small traders who moved between towns with a truck and a genuine, professional knowledge of which stretches of road were passable and which were not this week. They fed him information as often as they fed him food — which river crossings were safe at this time of year, which checkpoints were currently being run by soldiers who were bored and which by soldiers who were frightened, and frightened soldiers, he learned early and never forgot, were considerably more dangerous than bored ones, because a frightened man with a rifle makes decisions a bored man never would. He absorbed this knowledge the way he absorbed everything useful: without romance, without performing gratitude he did not feel, simply filing it as information that kept him alive and passing it on, when he could, to the rare other traveller he crossed paths with heading the opposite direction.

The scale of the place did something to his sense of time that he did not fully register until he was much further along in the journey and could look back on it. In Europe he had measured his progress in towns; in Africa, in that first long crossing, he began measuring it in seasons — the dry season in which the roads were passable and brutal, the wet season in which the roads dissolved into a red clay that swallowed a bicycle wheel to the axle and stranded him, more than once, for days at a stretch in a village he had not intended to visit at all, waiting for the mud to firm enough to ride. He came to think of these unplanned stops, over time, not as delays from some truer itinerary but as a second, informal itinerary of their own, made entirely of places he had never meant to see and would otherwise never have seen: a village whose name he never fully learned, whose children taught him a hand-clapping game he still remembered, wordlessly, decades later, whose headman fed him three nights running and refused, each time,

to discuss what it cost him.

It was in one of these unplanned villages, waiting out a wet-season road, that he first heard another traveller's rumour — secondhand, thirdhand, passed along a chain of truck drivers and mission radios — of a Frenchman who had supposedly cycled through the region some years before and vanished somewhere further north, a story with no confirmable shape to it at all, more legend than fact, that nonetheless lodged itself in Stücker's mind as the first hint that he was not, in fact, entirely alone in the specific madness of what he was attempting. He never verified the story. He came to suspect, later in life, that some version of it existed in nearly every region he passed through — a half-remembered predecessor, real or invented, who had gone before and either triumphed or vanished — and that the story's usefulness had nothing to do with whether it was true and everything to do with the fact that it gave the people telling it, and the young German listening, a frame large enough to hold what a bicycle crossing an entire continent actually meant, a frame their own direct experience did not otherwise provide.

He rode out of that village when the road firmed, three weeks later than he had planned and, by his own later reckoning, not one day worse off for it, carrying with him the specific, hard-won understanding that would carry him through the next four decades of the continent and, eventually, every other continent besides: that a journey measured only in kilometres per day was a journey measured wrong, and that the actual unit of account, the one that mattered, was patience spent well or spent badly, and that a man who learned to spend it well could go, in the end, almost anywhere the earth allowed a wheel to turn.

Chapter 5: The Crossing at First Light

Some mornings survived in his memory whole, undimmed by the fifty years that came after them, for reasons he could never fully explain even to himself, and one of these — a river crossing somewhere in South Asia, in a year he placed only approximately among the early continuous decades, one of the several thousand ordinary mornings that made up the actual bulk of a fifty-year journey no single anecdote could ever properly represent — stayed with him more vividly than mornings from years he could date with far greater confidence.

He had reached the river at first light deliberately, having learned by then that a ford safe at dawn could turn genuinely dangerous by mid-day once meltwater further upstream worked its way down and raised the level by a hand's width or more, an increase that sounded trivial until you were standing in it with a loaded bicycle and a satchel of irreplaceable negatives. The water at that hour was the specific pale grey-green of first light on silt, cold enough that his feet went numb within a minute of entering it, and he crossed slowly, the bicycle lifted onto his shoulder rather than wheeled, testing each footing with his free hand against the current before committing his weight to it, moving with the unhurried, methodical patience that had become, by then, simply how he approached any task the road set in front of him.

A boy appeared on the far bank partway through the crossing, perhaps ten years old, watching him with the frank, unselfconscious curiosity children the world over seemed to extend toward the strange sight of

a foreign man wading a river with a bicycle balanced on one shoulder, and when Stücke reached the bank, dripping and breathing hard from the cold and the effort, the boy simply fell into step beside him without a word of shared language between them, matching his pace, occasionally pointing ahead at some feature of the road — a washed-out section, a fork where the wrong path led nowhere useful — with the specific quiet authority of a child who had grown up along this exact stretch of river and knew it better than any map Stücke carried ever could.

They walked together for perhaps two kilometres, the boy occasionally attempting a word of a trade language that let them exchange the barest fragments of information, Stücke offering, in return for the guidance, a single postcard from his depleting stock, an image of a European mountain that meant nothing geographically to a child who had likely never travelled further than the next town over, but that the boy accepted and studied with the same frank, careful attention he had given the road itself, turning it over twice before tucking it, with evident care, into whatever pocket or fold of clothing served him for safekeeping. They parted at a crossroads with no ceremony beyond a raised hand from each of them, the boy turning back toward the river, Stücke continuing on toward whatever town lay ahead, and Stücke never learned the boy's name, never saw him again, and could not, decades later, have placed the exact river or the exact year with any real confidence.

He thought of this crossing, unprompted, at odd moments across the following five decades — not because anything dramatic had happened in it, no theft, no violence, no illness, nothing a journalist would ever think to ask him about — but because it seemed to him, turning it over in quiet hours long afterward, to contain something closer to the actual, ordinary substance of what fifty years on the road had really been made of than any of the anecdotes people wanted from him. Not the bullet. Not the theft. A cold river at dawn, a child's unasked-for kindness, a single postcard traded for two kilometres of safe passage, and then two strangers going their separate ways forever, having given each other, in the space of half an hour, exactly what each of them happened to need and nothing more. He came to think, in his final years,

that if anyone had ever managed to ask him the right question — not why did you do it, which he had answered a thousand times in a thousand slightly different ways, but what was it actually like, hour by hour, for fifty years — this crossing, and the ten thousand mornings like it that no book or documentary would ever have room to properly hold, would have been the truest answer he could have given, more honest by far than any of the six or seven dramatic stories that had come, over the decades, to stand in for the whole of a life mostly made of exactly this instead: small, unremarkable, entirely sufficient kindness, exchanged at a crossroads, between two people who would never see each other again.

Chapter 6: The Weight of the Satchel

By the time he reached the subcontinent, the photographs had become a physical burden in a way he had not anticipated when the whole enterprise began with three postcards sold to a shopkeeper in the rain. He carried, by then, several thousand negatives in a canvas satchel reinforced with a second lining he had stitched himself, badly, in a guesthouse one wet evening with a needle borrowed from a landlady who had watched his first attempt and taken over halfway through out of what he understood, even through the language gap, to be simple professional impatience with an amateur's stitching. The satchel rode on top of the rear panniers, strapped down twice over, and he had developed, without noticing the exact day it started, a specific bodily awareness of its weight and position at all times, the way a mother is aware of a child in a crowd — not looking at it constantly, but always, somewhere in the periphery of attention, knowing precisely where it was.

The negatives were, by any honest accounting, worth more to him than the bicycle. The bicycle could be replaced, expensively and with grief but replaced nonetheless; a machine, however loved, was still in the end a machine, and machines existed in shops. The negatives could not be replaced at any price, because they were not merchandise in the ordinary sense — they were the only physical record that a specific afternoon in a specific village, a specific fisherman's boat, a specific child's laugh, had ever actually happened, at least as far as Stücker's

own life was concerned, and the thought of losing them to a flooded river crossing or a moment's carelessness produced in him an anxiety sharper than any fear he felt for his own body. He built small rituals around their protection that had nothing to do with superstition and everything to do with plain risk management: oilcloth wrapping, a spare oilcloth wrapping inside that, a habit of checking the satchel's ties before every river ford whether or not the water looked dangerous, because the fords that looked safe were, in his experience, exactly the ones that occasionally were not.

India taught him poverty at a scale and intimacy that nothing in the Balkans or the Levant had fully prepared him for, and he learned, riding through it, to distrust his own first instinct toward pity, which he came to recognize, with some discomfort, as a form of condescension dressed up as feeling. The households that fed him in India — and they fed him, again and again, families with visibly less to spare than the Syrian household that had nursed him through heatstroke, families for whom a single meal shared with a stranger represented a genuine and considered sacrifice rather than an easy abundance — did not want his pity, and made this clear to him in ways both direct and subtle whenever he let it show in his face. What they offered him was not charity in the sense he had grown up understanding the word, a transaction from the fortunate to the unfortunate; it was something closer to a code of hospitality that predated and did not particularly care about the relative wealth of the two parties involved, a code that would have fed him exactly the same meal, with exactly the same warmth, whether he had arrived on the most expensive bicycle in Europe or the poorest. He learned, slowly and with some real embarrassment at his own early clumsiness, to receive what he was given the way it was intended: as a fact about his hosts' character and tradition, not as a commentary on his own need, and certainly not as an occasion for the visiting European to feel moved by the nobility of the poor, a framing he came to actively despise in the accounts other travellers sometimes gave of the same roads, and that he refused, for the rest of his life, whenever a journalist tried to lead him toward it in an interview.

The funding model matured in India into something close to its permanent shape. He had, by then, enough of a reputation preceding him

along certain well-travelled corridors — word passed from one guest-house owner to the next, from one mission station to the next, the specific, low-bandwidth gossip network of people who host travellers for a living — that he sometimes arrived in a town to find someone already expecting him, having heard from a departed traveller three weeks ahead that a German on a bicycle with a satchel of photographs was somewhere on the road behind them and worth watching for. He sold prints to guesthouses that wanted something to hang on their walls for other foreign guests to admire. He sold prints to the rare consulate official who took an interest in his project and wanted a record of it for a report home. He sold, increasingly, small sets of postcards to other travellers themselves, backpackers and overlanders who had money Stütcke did not and who were, he discovered with some initial surprise, delighted to buy a professional-looking image of a place they were only passing through quickly, rather than trust their own cheap cameras to capture it properly. He kept his ledger scrupulously — prints sold, addresses for reprint orders, the occasional small donation offered by someone moved enough by the scale of the undertaking to simply hand him money without asking for anything in return, which he accepted, by then, without the awkwardness that had characterized his early attempts to refuse or repay such gifts.

He was not, and never became, wealthy by any reasonable measure. The arithmetic worked, month to month, because his needs were structured to fit whatever the arithmetic produced: he ate what the road offered, slept where the road offered it, and treated any surplus not as savings toward some future comfort but as buffer against the inevitable bad month — a stolen camera, a hospital stay, a stretch of country where postcards simply did not sell because nobody there had disposable income for such things. He thought of himself, when he thought about it at all, less as a poor man and more as a man who had simply decoupled his life from the entire category of financial ambition that had organized every other man he'd grown up with in Hövelhof — the raise, the promotion, the pension, the retirement plan. He had, instead, a single continuously renewing contract with the road itself: it would feed him as long as he kept moving and kept the camera loaded, and he trusted that contract with a completeness that struck

most people who heard about it, when he described it decades later, as either admirable or faintly insane, and that he had, by then, stopped much caring which.

The heat did things to the negatives that he learned to guard against only through expensive early mistakes — humidity that crept into an improperly sealed satchel and left a whole roll's worth of images faintly, irreversibly fogged, a loss he discovered only when he had them developed three towns later and understood, standing in the print shop with the ruined contact sheet in his hand, that an entire village's worth of faces and doorways and market stalls had simply ceased to exist as far as any record of them was concerned. He did not photograph that village again. He could not; the road had already carried him past it, and doubling back was a cost the arithmetic of forward progress rarely allowed. He absorbed the loss the way he absorbed most losses on the road — without much display, filing it under the general and growing category of things the journey occasionally took from him in exchange for everything it gave, a ledger he kept, like the print sales, with a scrupulous private honesty he extended to almost no one else.

He crossed, in those years, borders that opened onto entirely different bureaucratic temperaments within a single day's ride — an official who wanted only a stamp and a smile, an official three hours down the same road who wanted forms in triplicate and a letter of introduction Stücker did not possess and had to invent, on the spot, in the only language he shared with the man, a letter whose actual content the official, Stücker suspected even at the time, could not read closely enough to verify and was requesting largely as a formality that let him feel he had done his job properly. He learned to carry, always, a small stack of his own printed cards — his name, a rough itinerary, a line in three languages explaining the scope of the undertaking — not because any single official particularly needed them, but because the simple physical fact of a printed document, official-looking regardless of its actual authority, satisfied something in the bureaucratic mind that a verbal explanation, however honest, never quite could. It was, he reflected once, one of the more useful and least dignified lessons the road had taught him: that the truth, spoken plainly, moved a man across some borders, and a convincing enough piece of paper moved him across

all the rest.

Chapter 7: Tongues

He never counted, with any precision, how many languages he had come to manage some working fragment of across fifty years, resisting the number the way he resisted most of the flattering totals people wanted to attach to his life, on the grounds that “manage some working fragment of” covered such a wide range of actual competence that any single number would have lied about the truth in one direction or another. He was fluent, by any strict measure, in only his own German and, after enough years, a serviceable working English that had absorbed, over the decades, a faint and untraceable accent from nowhere in particular, the specific rootless intonation of a man who had learned much of his conversational English not from any single English-speaking country but from thousands of brief, practical exchanges with non-native speakers across a hundred others, each of whom had left some small mark on his own pronunciation that no dialect coach could have traced back to its source.

Beyond that, he carried what he came to call, privately, his roadside vocabularies — a few hundred words each of perhaps a dozen languages, assembled entirely around the practical needs of a man travelling by bicycle rather than around any of the vocabulary a formal classroom might have prioritized. He could ask, with real fluency, for water, for the nearest town, for permission to sleep in a barn or a yard, for the price of bread, for directions phrased in the specific way that distinguished a genuinely helpful answer from a polite stranger’s guess offered mostly to avoid admitting they did not actually know. He could not, in most of these languages, discuss politics, philosophy, or his own interior life with anything close to nuance, a limitation he

came to consider, across the decades, less a deficiency than simply an honest reflection of what the road had actually required of him: not eloquence, but function, the specific and narrow competence needed to solve the next practical problem in front of him, extract the information he needed, and move on to the next town where an entirely different narrow competence would be required instead.

This left him, he admitted candidly to the one biographer patient enough to draw the admission out of him, with a specific and peculiar kind of loneliness that had nothing to do with the absence of other people around him — he was rarely, across the whole fifty years, ever truly alone for more than a handful of consecutive days — and everything to do with the specific ceiling his own limited fluency placed on how deeply any single conversation, in any single country, could actually go. He could share a meal, a joke about the weather, a genuine and warm hour of company with a stranger in a dozen different countries, and in almost none of those hours could he have explained, with any real precision, what he was actually doing with his life and why, the exact question that most interested the people feeding him and that his own vocabulary, however hard-won, simply could not reach far enough to properly answer.

He compensated, over the decades, with the specific universal languages that required no shared vocabulary at all: gesture, the plain visible evidence of the bicycle and its accumulated wear, the photographs themselves, which he found, again and again across dozens of countries, could carry an explanation his words never could — a print of a market in one country, shown to a family in another, communicating something true and immediate about the scope of his journey that no sentence in any language he half-spoke could have matched for economy. He came to think of the camera, in this specific sense, as itself a kind of universal tongue, the one language in which he had achieved something close to genuine fluency across the whole fifty years, and he took a quiet, private pride in that fact that he rarely stated directly, having learned, decades before, that a man who announces his own fluency in anything is usually announcing something rather less impressive than he believes.

He picked up, in his later decades, a habit that amused the museum committee considerably when they noticed it: greeting visiting foreign tourists at the half-built museum in whatever fragment of their own language he still retained from a country visited thirty or forty years before, a word or two of welcome that occasionally produced, on the visitor's face, a specific delighted surprise at hearing their own tongue, however roughly rendered, from an elderly German in a small Westphalian town neither of them had any particular reason to associate with the other's homeland. He enjoyed this small, recurring performance more than almost any other pleasure his old age afforded him, a final, modest use for fifty years of roadside vocabularies that had otherwise, by his eighties, largely outlived their original practical purpose, kept alive now not because he needed them any longer for water or directions or shelter, but simply because a word remembered, offered freely to a stranger, had always been, for as long as he could recall being alive at all, the cheapest and most reliable way he knew of telling another human being: I see you, and this moment between us is worth marking.

Chapter 8: Java, 1974

The fever announced itself as thirst that would not resolve. He drank and it made no difference, which frightened him more than the cramping did, because thirst that water cannot answer means the water is not the problem, and by the second day on the road outside a market town in central Java he understood, with the flat clarity of a man reading his own instruments, that the problem was inside him and getting worse on a schedule he did not control.

He had been on the road twelve years by then. Twelve years is long enough to stop counting countries as an achievement and start counting them as simply where you happened to be standing, and he had crossed, by 1974, enough of Europe, the Middle East, the subcontinent, and Southeast Asia to have acquired the particular fatalism of a man who has been sick in a dozen languages and recovered in all of them. This one was different from the start. This one did not respond to the rules that had gotten him through every previous illness — rest, small sips of water, patience, wait it out.

He knew what dysentery was before he had a precise word for what was happening to him; every long-haul rider in Asia carried the knowledge the way a sailor carries knowledge of drowning, abstract until it is not. He knew, in the drained, light-headed arithmetic of the second and third days, that the two things a sick man on a bicycle needs are clean water and somewhere to stop, and that he had neither reliably to hand on that particular stretch of road. He kept riding because riding was the only motion he still trusted his body to perform without close supervision; stopping meant lying down, and lying down, some

old animal part of him insisted, was how you let a fever decide the outcome instead of contesting it, a piece of stubborn, half-formed logic that he recognized even at the time as probably wrong and rode on anyway, because the alternative — simply lying in the dirt at the roadside and waiting to see what happened — felt like a surrender his body had not yet agreed to make.

By the fourth day he could not keep the bicycle upright at a standstill. He remembered — later, piecing it together the way you piece together a night of fever from the handful of images that survive it, sharp and disconnected, with no reliable order between them — a woman at a roadside stall filling his water bottle without being asked and refusing the coins he tried, with shaking hands, to press on her, waving them off with the particular firm patience of someone who has already decided a sick foreigner does not get to argue about payment today. He remembered the road surface changing under the wheel from packed earth to something softer, rice-paddy mud at the shoulder, and being unable to work out, in his fogged state, whether that meant he was closer to a town or further from one. He remembered a boy, twelve or thirteen, walking his bicycle alongside him for perhaps a kilometre without a word, simply present, simply steadying the handlebars when Stücker's own grip faltered, and then peeling off toward a house Stücker never saw the inside of, a small unexplained kindness that Stücker was never afterward able to properly thank because he had not, in the fog of it, thought to ask the boy's name.

He remembered, with more clarity than almost anything else, the specific shame of being unable to control his own body in public, on a bicycle, in front of strangers, and how that shame — not the fever, not the cramping — was the thing he fought hardest to master, because it was the one part of the ordeal that felt as though it should have been his to control and plainly wasn't. He had, in twelve years on the road, weathered hunger and cold and the particular loneliness of a language he did not speak surrounding him for weeks at a stretch, and had found, in each case, some way to hold his own dignity intact through the discomfort. This one stripped the dignity away faster than the illness itself drained his strength, and he understood, lying eventually in a ditch he could not get himself back out of without help, that

the two losses — of strength and of dignity — were not, in fact, separable, that a body pushed far enough past its limits simply stopped being able to afford the luxury of shame and did what it needed to do, and that the shame arrived only afterward, once there was enough strength left over to spend on feeling it.

He made it, in the end, to a clinic — a mission clinic, understaffed, run by a doctor and two nurses who between them were treating malaria, tuberculosis, and half a dozen unglamorous everyday catastrophes with a dispensary that held perhaps a third of what it actually needed — and he was put on a cot in a ward with eleven other cots and left there, mostly, to either recover or not, which was the honest state of medicine in that clinic that year and no reflection whatsoever on the people running it, who did everything the tools in front of them allowed and did it without complaint, without theatrics, and without the specific weary self-pity that Stücke had seen, elsewhere, in better-resourced institutions run by worse people. He lost, by his own later estimate, something close to a stone in ten days. He could not, for the first three of those ten days, hold down the rehydration salts they gave him, bringing them back up almost as fast as they went in, and remembered the specific, humiliating helplessness of a grown man — a man who had crossed deserts and mountain passes on his own legs and his own stubbornness — being spoon-fed water by a nurse half his size who did not once, in ten days, make him feel like the burden he privately knew himself to be.

He thought, more than once in that ward, in the long grey hours between the nurses' rounds, about the shop in Hövelhof. Not with longing exactly — he had stopped, years before, missing the shop the way you stop missing a name you've forgotten you ever needed — but with a kind of bewildered comparison, the fever running through his memory the way it ran through his gut: two hundred and eleven identical steel parts a week, a foreman's grudging approval, a wage paid reliably every Friday, a bed that did not move and did not need to be defended from thieves and did not, above all, carry the risk of a stranger's untreated dysentery. He had left all of that specifically to avoid becoming a man who repeated the same day until it killed him quietly, and here he was on a cot in central Java, quite possibly being killed loudly

instead, by an illness with no opinion whatsoever about his reasons for being in its path. He did not, even at the worst of it, wish himself back in the shop. That surprised him more than the fever did. He had half expected, if it ever came to a cot like this one, that some traitor part of his mind would produce the shop as an argument — a life with a roof, a wage, a mother two streets from any hospital he'd ever need — and it never did. The shop simply did not compete. Whatever this illness was costing him, it was evidently not costing him the thing he had actually left Hövelhof to protect.

The bicycle waited the whole ten days propped against the clinic's outer wall, in the weather, its tyres slowly softening, watched over by the same boy — or perhaps a different boy, Stücker was never afterward entirely certain, the fever having blurred the two figures in his memory into a single composite guardian — whom one of the nurses had asked to keep half an eye on it, because mission clinics run, in every country he ever passed through one, on exactly that kind of unpaid, unremarked kindness, extended not because anyone was watching to see it done but because it was simply the correct thing to do and the people around him had, without exception, been raised to do the correct thing. When Stücker was finally steady enough to stand at the wall and look at the bicycle properly — thinner than he had ever been on the road, his own hands looking to him like a stranger's hands, ropy and unfamiliar, the tendons standing up under skin gone slack from the weight loss — the bicycle was still there, patient, dusty, three gears and a rack he had rewelded twice since Hövelhof, exactly as indifferent to what he had just survived as it had been the morning he left. He put his hand on the saddle before he trusted his legs to hold him without it, the way another man might have reached for a rail, and understood, standing there in the mission clinic's dusty yard, something he would spend the rest of his life failing to say clearly to anyone who asked him why he kept going: the bicycle did not care whether he had nearly died. It only cared whether he could still turn the pedals. That indifference, which should by rights have felt cold, felt instead like the only entirely honest relationship he had left in the world at that particular moment, and he found himself, unaccountably, glad of it.

He did not write his mother about the dysentery until he was strong

enough to make the account sound smaller than it had actually been, which took him the better part of a month, riding at half-pace, eating whatever the road offered and keeping most of it down, testing his own strength in small, careful increments the way he had once tested a wheel's truth against a rim brake, a little at a time, watching for the wobble that would tell him he'd pushed too far too soon. When he did write, from a post office in Surabaya, he described the whole ordeal as a stomach illness, now passed — a sentence that did no justice whatsoever to eleven cots and a stone of his own body weight and a boy whose name he never learned keeping watch over a bicycle for a foreigner he had no particular reason to trust, and he chose that small, flattening sentence on purpose, because there are things a man carries alone not out of pride but because the carrying itself is the only part of the debt he can actually repay, the only currency he has left, once every other kind of currency has been spent.

Chapter 9: Checkpoints

There is no fixed year attached to some of what happened to him, and he preferred it that way. Ask him, later in life, exactly when the soldiers in Egypt had beaten him unconscious, and he would give you a shrug that had taken him decades to make convincing — the shrug of a man who has genuinely stopped keeping that particular ledger, not the shrug of a man protecting a secret. The years blurred on purpose, or at least he let them blur, because sorting every hard afternoon into a tidy chronology would have flattered the whole undertaking with an order it had never actually possessed.

What he could tell you, if you asked patiently and let him tell it in whatever sequence it arrived in his own memory, was the shape of each one, and the shape of the Egyptian checkpoint had stayed with him more precisely than the calendar around it ever did.

He had ridden that stretch of road before, in an earlier year, without incident — a fact that made the second crossing, when it went badly, feel less like bad luck and more like a lottery whose odds he had simply misjudged, having grown complacent on the strength of one clean passage. The soldiers at the checkpoint that day did not like his papers, or did not like his face, or did not like being bored on a hot road with nothing to occupy several young men armed and stationed somewhere they had almost certainly not chosen for themselves, and Stücker understood, within the first minute of the encounter, in the specific tightening of the smallest soldier's jaw, that this was not going to be one of the checkpoints that resolved itself with a stamp and a shrug.

He did not remember, afterward, the sequence of what triggered it — a raised voice, a hand on his bicycle that he had, out of old habit and without thinking, tried to pull back, a question he answered a half-second too slowly or in the wrong tone. He remembered the first blow landing and the specific, absurd clarity of the thought that arrived with it, entirely disconnected from any fear: that his camera was going to be broken, and that the loss of the camera was, in that first half-second, more present in his mind than the loss of his own physical safety, before the second and third blows arrived and reorganized his priorities considerably. He went down. He did not fully surface again, in any reliable sense, until he was sitting upright against a wall some indeterminate time later, his ears ringing in a way that made the whole world arrive underwater and delayed, a soldier — not one of the men who had hit him, or so Stücker chose afterward to believe, because it made the memory bearable — holding a water bottle to his mouth with an expression Stücker could not read at all, neither guilt nor indifference, simply the blank professional attention of a man performing a task assigned to him by someone else.

He did not report it. There was no one to report it to who would not simply have been another uniform, possibly one of the same uniforms, and he had learned, by then, the specific futility of seeking justice from an institution that had just demonstrated, directly on his own body, exactly how much interest it had in restraint. He rode on within a few days, nursing ribs that ached for a month and an eye that stayed swollen shut for the better part of a week, and told almost no one the details for years afterward, offering instead, when the subject came up at all, the same flattened sentence he had learned to use for every hard thing: a difficult checkpoint, some trouble with the soldiers, nothing that hadn't healed.

Cameroon came at him from an entirely different angle, no fists at all, only a room and a chair and an official who wanted to know, with the patient, circling persistence of a man enjoying the only power available to him that week, why a German was photographing markets, bridges, and a stretch of new road the government was proud of and, evidently, touchy about anyone documenting without permission. Stücker's French was serviceable but not fast, and the official's

questions arrived faster than Stücker could properly follow them, circling back on themselves, reframing the same suspicion in slightly different words each time as though repetition alone might eventually produce a confession to something Stücker had not, in fact, done. The charge, when it finally arrived, framed in language considerably more formal than anything else in the room, amounted to slandering the state by the mere act of documenting it — a charge so broad, Stücker understood even through his own mounting alarm, that it could be applied to almost anything a foreigner with a camera might point at, which was, he suspected, rather the point of it.

He spent — he was never afterward precise about the exact duration, only that it felt, at the time, like the better part of two days — in a room with a barred window too high to see much through and a guard who brought him tea twice without being asked to and would not meet his eyes while doing it, which Stücker understood, even then, as the universal, wordless signal of a low-ranking man performing a duty he privately found absurd and had no power to refuse. He spent the hours composing, in his head, the various explanations he would offer if given the chance, discarding each one as either too weak or too likely to be misread as further evidence of guilt, and arrived eventually at a kind of exhausted stillness that had less to do with calm than with simple depletion — a man who has run out of strategies eventually stops generating them, whether or not the danger has actually passed.

He was released without charge and without apology, his camera confiscated and never returned, a loss that cost him, by his own later reckoning, several months of unprinted, unsold photographs and the considerable expense, once he could afford it, of replacing a piece of equipment that had by then become as load-bearing to his working life as the bicycle itself. He did not, in later years, speak of the confiscation with any particular bitterness. He had come, by the time he was telling the story to interviewers decades on, to think of it less as an injustice singling him out and more as simply one instance of a pattern he had watched repeat itself, with local variations, across dozens of countries and regimes over fifty years: that a man travelling with a camera through a country still deciding, sometimes violently, what version of itself it wanted the world to see, was always going to be, at

some point, mistaken for evidence against that decision rather than a neutral observer of it. He did not think this made the confiscation fair. He thought it made the confiscation explicable, which was, for a man who had decided long ago not to spend his limited emotional reserves on anger he could not act on, close enough to the same thing.

He wrote nothing home about either incident until years had passed and both had faded, in his own retelling, into the same flattened register he applied to everything hard: some trouble at a checkpoint, a difficult few days with the authorities, nothing that hadn't resolved itself eventually. His mother, reading these brief accounts decades later in the letters she had kept, could not have reconstructed from them the specific ringing silence of a beaten man's ears, or the specific tea brought twice by a guard who would not meet his eyes, and Stücker had made certain, deliberately and for reasons he did not examine too closely even in his own old age, that she never would.

Chapter 10: The Ledger of Bad Days

The Atacama was the whitest heat he had ever ridden through, a straight road with nothing on either side to break the light, the sky and the salt flats trading the glare back and forth between them until his eyes ached from squinting even behind the cheap dark glasses he'd bought three towns back. He had learned, by the time he reached Chile, to ride the worst of a desert road at the edges of the day and rest through the killing hours of early afternoon, but this particular stretch had offered no real shade for kilometres in either direction, and he had pushed on rather than lie in the open sun waiting for a shadow that was not coming.

The truck came up behind him in exactly the hour a driver's attention is most likely to slip, the white heat of early afternoon working on a man behind a wheel the same way it worked on a man on a bicycle, and Stücker heard the engine's pitch change a half-second before the mirror clipped his shoulder and sent him into the gravel at a speed his body did not have time to prepare for. He remembered the specific, disorienting sequence of it: the world tipping sideways, gravel arriving against his forearm and hip before he understood he was already falling, and then simply lying there, breath knocked flat out of him, running the same rough inventory he had learned to run after every hard fall since Java — fingers, toes, the specific test of trying to move each in turn before trusting the rest of the body to attempt anything larger.

The truck's brake lights came on a full hundred metres past him, too

late to have prevented anything, almost too late even to qualify as a response, and Stücke watched, still flat in the gravel, as the vehicle reversed back toward him in a series of jerking corrections that suggested a driver whose hands were shaking considerably harder than Stücke's own. The young man who climbed down — younger than Stücke had expected from the size of the truck, hardly more than twenty, Stücke guessed — was, by every visible measure, more frightened by what he had nearly done than Stücke was by what had nearly been done to him, and said so, repeatedly, in a rapid Spanish Stücke could only partly follow, apologizing in a tone that kept threatening to break entirely.

They got the front wheel, buckled beyond any roadside fix, roped into the truck's flatbed alongside Stücke himself, who rode the rest of the way into the next town in the cab, nursing a hip that would ache for a week and listening to the driver's apologies gradually settle into something closer to ordinary conversation once it became clear Stücke was not going to press any kind of charge. The driver paid for the replacement wheel without being asked, more or less insisting on it over Stücke's own halfhearted protest, and Stücke understood, watching the younger man count out bills he could almost certainly not easily spare, that the payment was doing work beyond the mechanical: it was the only available way for a frightened twenty-year-old to make the fact of what had nearly happened feel, retroactively, survivable to him as well as to Stücke. Stücke never learned the man's name, having been too rattled in the moment to think to ask and too far down the road by the time he thought of it again to go back. He filed the whole encounter, afterward, under a heading that had no single clean word in either German or English but that he came closest to, once, translating for a magazine writer decades later as the accidents that were nobody's particular fault, including the world's — the world, in this accounting, being simply the aggregate of heat and fatigue and physics that had briefly, blindly, aligned against him for no reason either man in that truck cab could usefully be blamed for.

Haiti gave him a different flavor of fear entirely, one that lasted longer and that he came, in his own private ranking of the whole ledger, to consider worse than the Zambia shooting itself, because this one he

could see coming the entire time it was happening, every face in it, every hand.

It began with a misunderstanding about the camera — a rumour, he pieced together only much later, moving through a crowded market faster than he could have corrected it even if he had understood the Creole well enough to try, some claim about what the foreigner's photographs were actually for, whether they were being sold to some authority, whether the man with the camera was here to make trouble for people who already had more than enough of it. He felt the mood in the market shift before he understood why, the specific animal instinct of a crowd's attention turning, collectively and almost silently, toward a single point, and he was already moving, wheeling the bicycle rather than riding it through a press of bodies too dense to pedal through, by the time the first hand closed on his shoulder.

He shrugged it off hard enough to send its owner stumbling, not from any calculated self-defence but from pure reflex, and found the street ahead of him narrowing further, panniers catching on a stall corner in a way that cost him two or three seconds he did not have to spare, the shouting behind him gathering volume and, worse, gathering agreement, voices no longer merely curious but coordinating. He got clear. He never fully reconstructed, afterward, exactly how — which turn he took, which gap in the crowd he found, whether he mounted the bicycle again before or after he was out of the worst of it — because adrenaline, he came to understand over the following decades of retelling the story, erases its own methods as efficiently as it produces them, leaving behind only the emotional residue and none of the actual mechanics of survival.

He rode out of that town without stopping to eat, and did not stop properly again until well after dark, by which time his hands had been shaking on the handlebars for so many consecutive hours that he genuinely could not remember, dismounting at last in the relative safety of a roadside clearing, how to make them stop shaking on command. He sat with his back against a tree for a long time that night, not sleeping, running the encounter over and over in a way he recognized, even then, as unproductive and could not stop doing regardless, and under-

stood, somewhere in the small hours, something about fear that the Zambia shooting had not fully taught him: that a bullet, however devastating, is a single event with a single before and after, but a crowd's collective decision about you, witnessed face by face as it gathers, asks something of your nervous system that a single gunshot never does, a sustained vigilance with no clean moment of resolution, only a gradual and incomplete easing that took him, by his own private accounting, most of a week to fully shake.

Alaska gave him cold instead of heat, and water instead of a crowd, and the specific, almost philosophical terror of a car sliding on a road he had not judged nearly icy enough, throwing him and the bicycle both into a frozen river whose current closed over him with a totality he described, once, to the one interviewer patient enough to draw the detail out of him, as feeling less like danger and more like an argument being settled — the cold simply informing his body, without any cruelty in the informing, that it did not belong here and had perhaps five minutes to prove otherwise. He got himself out. He never fully explained, even to himself in later years, exactly how, partly because he genuinely did not retain the sequence of it through the fog of cold-shock and partly, he suspected, because some memories are kept deliberately vague, the vagueness itself a kind of dressing laid over a wound that plain description would only reopen without actually healing.

And, in an earlier year he could no longer place with confidence, a driver somewhere in the American West who had picked him up along with the bicycle for a stretch of desert highway too brutal to ride in the day's heat, and who left him — supplies, camera bag, and every possession but the clothes he stood in — at a filling station he could never afterward name precisely, while Stücker was inside buying water. He came out to an empty forecourt and an absence so total it took him several long minutes to accept as real rather than as some error of his own memory, some wrong door, some misremembered parking spot. It was not a misremembered parking spot. The truck, and the driver, and everything Stücker had trusted to the bed of it, were simply gone, and he stood in that forecourt running, item by item, exactly how much of his working life had just left with a stranger who had offered him, an

hour earlier, what had looked for all the world like ordinary kindness and had turned out to be something considerably more calculating.

He told these, when he told them at all, without embellishment, without a tidy moral, in whatever order they occurred to him on a given evening — sometimes Egypt first, sometimes the frozen river, depending on the bar and the listener and which year of his own long life he happened to be standing in at the moment he was asked. He did not tell them for sympathy. He told them, when he told them, mostly because a man who has been on the road fifty years eventually stops being able to give an honest account of his life without them, the way a house cannot be described honestly without mentioning where it has cracked. He was not, by his own insistence, an unlucky man. He had met, in the very same countries, in years he could no longer sort with any confidence, considerably more strangers who fed him than strangers who robbed him, more soldiers who let him pass than soldiers who did not, and he considered it a plain failure of arithmetic, and possibly of character, to let a handful of bad afternoons outweigh the decades of ordinary decency that surrounded them on every side. But he did not pretend, either, that the bad afternoons had cost him nothing. They had cost him a camera, a wheel, a stretch of nerve that took a week to mend, and — though he would never have put it this way himself, in any interview, to any biographer — a small, permanent tax on his own capacity for trust that he paid quietly, in private, for the rest of his life, and never once presented to anyone else as a bill they owed him.

Chapter 11: The Shape of a Border

He had crossed, by his own rough and characteristically undramatic estimate, several thousand borders in his life, counting every re-entry and every exit across fifty years and a hundred and ninety-five countries, and he came, across that considerable accumulated experience, to think of the border itself — not any single one, but the category, the abstract recurring event — as perhaps the single most philosophically strange object his entire working life had put in front of him, stranger, in its way, than any mountain or any ocean, because a mountain did not pretend to be anything other than what it plainly was, and a border did.

A border, he came to understand through several thousand repetitions of the experience, was an agreement between two groups of people who mostly could not see each other and mostly never met, an agreement enforced, in practice, entirely by whichever specific individual happened to be staffing a specific desk on a specific morning, a person who held, in that narrow moment, an authority over Stücker's onward movement that no natural feature of the actual landscape supported in the slightest. He had ridden across invisible lines a hundred times where the vegetation, the geology, the very quality of the air gave no hint whatsoever that anything had changed, and had been required, at those same invisible lines, to produce documents, answer questions, sometimes wait hours or days, for a passage that the land itself offered no resistance to at all. He found this, across the decades,

by turns absurd, infuriating, and — in his more reflective later years — genuinely fascinating, a specific human invention laid over the actual earth with such consistency and such collective conviction that billions of people who would never personally verify a single border's exact location nonetheless organized enormous portions of their lives around respecting lines that existed, in the final analysis, only because enough people agreed to act as though they were real.

He did not conclude from this, in the manner of a certain kind of traveller he had met occasionally along the road, that borders were therefore illegitimate or should be abolished, a political conclusion he found, on reflection, considerably less interesting than the plainer observation underneath it. He had watched borders, for all their arbitrariness, do genuine protective work in places where the alternative was not some borderless utopia but simply a different, less accountable form of power filling the vacuum — a checkpoint staffed by a bored young man was, whatever its absurdities, still generally more survivable than the same stretch of road with no checkpoint at all and no accountability whatsoever for whoever happened to control it that week. He had also watched borders do enormous, specific harm, dividing communities that had lived as one people for generations before some distant committee drew a line through the middle of them, and he refused, characteristically, to collapse the whole category into either a simple villain or a simple necessity, preferring instead to treat each individual crossing on its own specific terms, as he had always tried to treat everything else the road put in front of him.

What he came to value most, across the decades, was the specific human moment at the centre of every border crossing, however absurd the larger system surrounding it — the actual individual official, soldier, or clerk whose particular mood and particular judgment, on that particular morning, would determine whether Stücke passed easily or with difficulty, quickly or slowly, with dignity or without it. He had learned to read that individual quickly and accurately, across thousands of repetitions, not because he had any special gift for it but because his own survival had depended, again and again, across five decades, on getting the reading right, and he came to think of this specific skill — the fast, accurate reading of a single stranger's dispo-

sition in the charged first seconds of an encounter where real consequences hung on the outcome — as perhaps the single most valuable and least transferable expertise his fifty years on the road had actually given him, a fluency in the human face under institutional pressure that no classroom anywhere on earth could have taught him nearly as thoroughly as several thousand borders, crossed one at a time, over sixty-four years, eventually did.

Chapter 12: The Decision

Nobody who knew him well enough to ask believed, afterward, that the idea of visiting every country on earth had arrived to Stücke the way ideas arrive in films — a single struck-match moment, a map unrolled on a table, a finger tracing a line and a voice declaring the intention out loud for dramatic effect. It did not happen that way. It arrived the way the decision to stay on the road past Cologne had arrived nearly two decades earlier: as a fact that had been quietly assembling itself in the back rooms of his mind for years, through a thousand small comparisons and half-formed private wagers, until one day, somewhere in West Africa in the early years of that new decade, he noticed the fact was already finished and simply waiting for him to say yes to it out loud.

The comparisons had started, if he traced them back honestly, years before, in the specific habit he had developed of mentally filing each new country as either visited or not-yet, a habit that had begun as simple bookkeeping — useful for planning routes, useful for knowing which visas he still needed to chase down — and had slowly, without his particular noticing the shift, become something closer to a private scoreboard. He had, by the turn of the decade, visited enough of the world's recognized countries that the remaining gaps had started to organize themselves, in his own mind, into a specific and nameable shape rather than a formless remainder. He could tell you, if pressed, roughly how many he had left. He found himself doing the arithmetic unprompted, in idle moments, the same reflexive counting that had once tallied identical steel components at the die shop now tallying nations instead, a habit of mind that had simply changed its unit of

measurement rather than disappearing.

He was careful, in later interviews, to resist any account of the ambition that made it sound nobler or stranger than it actually was. He did not frame it, when asked directly, as a spiritual quest, a word he distrusted on principle and associated, not entirely fairly, with the kind of traveller who wrote long meditative passages about the self in journals. Stücker had neither the patience nor, frankly, the inclination to keep. He framed it, instead, in terms closer to the plain engineering logic of his old trade: he had a rough count of remaining countries, a rough sense of the routes and seasons that would let him reach them, and a rough confidence, built on nearly two decades of evidence, that the postcard economy could sustain him through whatever the completing of the list actually required. It was, in his own telling, less a vision than a project plan, assembled the way he had once assembled a die from a drawing: component by component, tolerance by tolerance, with no particular romance attached to the process beyond the private satisfaction of watching each part come together correctly.

What the ambition cost him, once he had said yes to it, was a specific kind of freedom he had not fully appreciated until it was gone: the freedom to let a route wander according to whim, weather, or simple curiosity rather than according to the hard logic of which visas were currently obtainable and which borders were currently open. He had, in the first two decades on the road, ridden largely where the road itself seemed to invite him, turning off a planned route toward a rumour of an interesting town or a recommended pass with no cost beyond a few extra days. Once the full list of countries became the organizing fact of his life, every detour carried a new kind of accounting: did this rumour, this recommended pass, actually serve the larger project, or was it simply self-indulgence dressed up as curiosity, a question he found himself asking with increasing, and at times uncomfortable, frequency. He did not always answer it the way the stricter version of himself would have preferred. He allowed himself detours still, throughout the following decade and a half, because a man who let a project entirely swallow the pleasure that had originally justified it was, in Stücker's own considered private judgment, not actually accomplishing anything worth the cost. But he noticed the accounting

had changed, permanently, the moment he said yes to the list, and he never fully got back the earlier, wilder freedom of a route chosen for no reason beyond wanting to see where it went.

He began, in those years, keeping a more formal record than the tolerance-obsessed notebook habits of his earliest travelling years — a proper log now, countries entered and exited with rough dates where he could manage them and honest gaps where he could not, a document he treated with the same scrupulous private care he gave the negatives themselves, understanding, correctly as it turned out, that this log would eventually be the only evidence anyone would ever have for exactly what he had attempted and exactly how much of it he had actually achieved. He was, in this sense, both the sole subject and the sole archivist of his own ambition, a position that suited a man who had never fully trusted institutions to keep an honest account of anything and had decided, somewhere in his twenties, that the only records worth fully believing were the ones he kept himself.

The scale of what he had committed himself to did not fully register, he admitted later, until he sat down one evening in a guesthouse somewhere in West Africa with a world map borrowed from a schoolteacher and began, for the first time, marking the countries he had not yet reached rather than the ones he had — a small reversal of habit that produced, he said, a specific vertigo he had not expected, the remaining gaps suddenly revealing themselves not as a short list of stragglers but as an enormous, scattered, genuinely daunting geography: island nations reachable only by boat or plane, countries whose current political situation made a simple tourist visa an active impossibility, places whose borders were, in that particular decade, closed or contested or actively at war in ways that made “visiting” a considerably more complicated verb than it had been for the countries already behind him. He sat with that map a long time that evening, the schoolteacher’s lamp burning low, and felt, for perhaps the only time in the whole of the following decade, something close to doubt about whether the thing was actually achievable at all.

He did not abandon it. He folded the map back up, thanked the schoolteacher, and rode out the following morning exactly as he had

ridden out of every morning for eighteen years, on the theory — never stated aloud, never needing to be, because it had governed every decision he had made since Hövelhof — that the only honest response to a daunting scale was to stop looking at the whole of it and simply ride the next kilometre correctly. He would, over the coming years, cross deserts and oceans and the specific bureaucratic thickets of a dozen newly independent nations still deciding what their own visa policy should even be, and he would do all of it the same way he had done everything since the freewheel first ticked its way out of Hövelhof: one border, one negotiation, one postcard sale at a time, trusting the arithmetic that had kept him fed for eighteen years to keep working for however many more it took, and refusing, on principle, to let the size of the remaining list become an argument for turning back before he had actually tested whether it could be done.

Chapter 13: Zambia

He heard the shot before he understood it was aimed at him, which is, he would say later, the only mercy the whole incident contained: the half-second of not-knowing bought his body time to be still before his mind caught up and told it to be afraid.

Southern Africa in 1980 was flying a great many flags in a great many combinations, several of them changing while he was still inside a given country trying to work out which one to salute at the next check-point. He had crossed into Zambia on a road that ran close enough to a contested border that the contest itself was still, in places, being actively fought — men who called themselves freedom fighters, because that is what men who are shooting for a cause they believe in absolutely call themselves, holding a stretch of bush that the maps in Lusaka and the maps in whatever printing house had produced his own guidebook did not entirely agree on. He did not know, riding into it, that he was riding into anything in particular. That was the second mercy and the second cruelty of the whole afternoon: the road had looked, from a hundred metres back, exactly like every other road he had ridden that week — red dirt, scrubby thorn trees, a heat that sat on the skin like a pressed hand, birdsong he had stopped consciously hearing years before because it was simply the sound the whole continent made in the middle of the day.

The shot took him in the big toe of his right foot, through the boot, which he would later understand — from a doctor with more candour than bedside manner — was in some ways the least catastrophic place on a human body for a bullet to arrive, and in no way at all a small

thing to have happen to you at the side of a dirt road four thousand kilometres from anyone who had ever heard your name. He went down. The bicycle went down with him, panniers first, camera strap biting hard into his neck as the frame twisted under him, and he lay in the red dirt for a length of time he could never afterward reconstruct with any confidence, doing the two things that were actually available to him in that position: bleeding, and listening, with an intensity that made every other sense feel temporarily suspended, for whether the men who had fired were coming closer or moving away.

They moved away. He never learned, and the sources that would later try to reconstruct the afternoon for him never learned either, exactly why — whether he had been mistaken for someone else entirely, whether a foreign man alone on a bicycle had simply registered, for one half-second in someone's scope, as a shape worth testing against an itchy trigger finger and nothing more considered than that, whether the shot had even been meant for him at all and he had merely been standing in the wrong six inches of Zambia when it happened to pass through that particular stretch of air. He did not spend much of the following decades trying to answer the question with any rigour. A man who has ridden through as many undeclared conflicts as he had by 1980 learns early that the reasons behind a single bullet are frequently smaller and stupider than the wound they leave behind, and that dignifying the reason with a proper investigation is sometimes its own kind of vanity — as though a tidier explanation would somehow have hurt less than an untidy one.

What he remembered with total, unwavering clarity, the part that never blurred no matter how many times he told it afterward in bars and church halls and eventually to a biographer with a tape recorder running, was the boot. Getting the boot off. His hands were shaking too hard to manage the laces with any competence and he cut through them instead with the small knife he still carried, the one with the bone handle that had been his grandfather's, and the boot came away full of blood in a way that struck him, even through the pain, as somehow absurd — a domestic, kitchen-sink kind of mess, blood pooled in a boot, not the clean cinematic wound he might once, as a much younger man back in Hövelhof, have half-pictured for himself in some

idle daydream about what danger on the road might eventually look like. The toe itself was a ruin, bone visible in a way he made himself look at exactly once before forcing his attention elsewhere. He wrapped it in a strip torn from his own shirt and got himself, somehow, the several kilometres to the next village, pushing the bicycle because he could not put weight on the pedal, arriving as much on will as on legs, and there — as had happened in Java, as would happen in a dozen countries whose names he could no longer keep in strict order by the end of his life — strangers took him in without asking to see proof of anything except the wound itself, which needed no papers at all to be believed.

He did not lose the toe. He lost some of its function, a stiffness that stayed with him the rest of his life and that he learned, methodically, to route around the way he had once learned to route around a stripped middle gear a decade before — favouring the other foot on the steepest climbs, standing on the pedals slightly off-centre in a way that a doctor forty years later, examining an old man's feet with mild professional interest, would identify at a glance as the gait of someone who had spent half a century quietly compensating for an old injury without ever once presenting it to anyone as an excuse for anything.

He wrote nothing home about the shooting for three months, and when he finally did — a single line buried in a longer, chattier letter, mentioning it the way you might mention unseasonable weather — his mother, who had by then stopped expecting the letters to tell her anything close to the actual truth of what her son's days contained, wrote back only to ask whether he had enough socks for the climate, a question so far removed from the gravity of what he'd actually survived that he laughed out loud reading it, alone, in a post office queue, and then found himself, to his own considerable surprise, close to tears immediately afterward, the laugh and the tears arriving from the same place and in the same breath, which he did not examine too closely at the time and did not fully understand until he was a much older man. He kept that letter, too, for the rest of his life, in the same order he kept everything: without display, without commentary, the way you keep a fact you have long since decided not to argue with.

The freedom fighters who fired the shot were, by every account he was ever able to piece together in later years, fighting for something they believed in absolutely and would very likely have been able to explain to him in detail, calmly and at length, if the encounter had gone any differently — a border, a government, the last hard years of a war that would, within months of that particular afternoon, end in independence and a new flag flying over the very customs post he had crossed under a different one entirely. He never met them to ask. He rode on, once the toe would bear weight again, into a country that was already, without his particular notice, becoming the country it would remain for the rest of the century, its old name and its old flag folding quietly into the past at roughly the same unhurried speed his own wound was folding into a permanent, minor, entirely private stiffness that he carried, without complaint and without once making it the centrepiece of any story he told about himself, for the remaining forty-six years of his life.

Chapter 14: The Body's Ledger

His hands changed first, and changed most, over the decades, and he noticed the change the way he noticed most things about his own body: practically, without vanity, as information relevant to the job rather than as any occasion for reflection on mortality. The hands that had once filed steel dies to a hundredth of a millimetre's tolerance in Hövelhof became, over fifty years of gripping handlebars through every climate the earth offered, a working rider's hands — knuckles enlarged, a permanent callus across the base of each palm exactly where the bar tape met skin for ten hours a day, a faint, permanent tremor in the left hand by his seventies that he attributed, when asked, to nothing more mysterious than simple decades of vibration absorbed through an unsprung steel frame on unpaved roads, a mechanical explanation for a mechanical symptom that satisfied him considerably more than any grander diagnosis a doctor occasionally offered instead.

His knees he managed, across the decades, with the same practical, unsentimental attention he gave the bicycle's own wear — noticing, in his fifties, a specific ache on long climbs that had not been present in his thirties, and adjusting his cadence, his gearing, and eventually his daily distance to accommodate it rather than fighting it on principle the way a younger and more stubborn version of himself might once have done. He came to think of this adjustment, in his own private accounting, not as decline but simply as further data, the same category

of information a stripped middle gear had once represented decades before: a fact about the machine's current limits, to be routed around rather than argued with, whether the machine in question was made of steel or of his own increasingly well-used cartilage.

The stiffness in his right big toe, the permanent legacy of the Zambia shooting four and a half decades before his final year, became, over time, a kind of internal barometer he consulted without quite meaning to — a specific, low ache that flared predictably before rain in certain climates, a private, embodied weather instrument considerably more reliable, he sometimes joked, than any forecast a radio station could offer him. He did not resent the toe. He had, across the decades, come to think of it with something closer to wry affection, a permanent souvenir of an afternoon that could easily have cost him a great deal more than a single joint's full mobility, and he was aware, in his more reflective later years, of the specific arithmetic involved in being grateful for a wound: that the gratitude was only available to him because the wound had not, in the end, been fatal, and that a different half-second's aim, on that Zambian road, would have left no old man in Hövelhof available to make wry jokes about barometers at all.

His hearing dimmed unevenly across the decades, a fact he attributed partly to age and partly, with more confidence than any doctor ever fully endorsed, to the specific residual damage of the Egyptian beating decades before, the ringing that had taken the better part of a day to fully clear that afternoon leaving behind, he suspected, some small permanent tax on a frequency range he could no longer clearly identify but occasionally, in a quiet room, felt the specific absence of. His eyesight, by contrast, held remarkably steady into his seventies, a fact he attributed, with the same characteristic blend of humour and genuine belief, to fifty years of near-constant practice reading distant road surfaces for hazards, an exercise regimen no ophthalmologist had ever specifically prescribed but that he was privately convinced had kept the relevant muscles in considerably better condition than a lifetime spent reading books at a fixed close distance would have managed.

He weathered, across the decades, the specific and cumulative sun

damage of a man who had refused, on principle, to hide his face under a hat the way more sensible riders eventually learned to, a stubbornness he came to regret mildly in his sixties as a doctor pointed out several patches of skin that needed attention, treated promptly and without drama, filed away in his own private ledger under the same heading as every other cost the road had extracted from him in exchange for everything it had given: information, received without excessive emotion, acted upon practically, and then set aside to make room for whatever the next day's riding actually required of him. He did not mourn his aging body in any grand or public way, and resisted, gently but firmly, the handful of interviewers who tried to draw a poetic account of decline out of him in his final years. He offered them, instead, the same plain inventory he offered everyone who asked a direct question directly: the hands, the knees, the toe, the ears, the skin, each one a specific, honest entry in a fifty-year ledger of wear that he considered, on the whole, an entirely fair exchange for what the ledger's other column had recorded — six hundred thousand kilometres, a hundred and ninety-five countries, and a life that had never once, across five decades, repeated the same identical day the way two hundred and eleven steel components a week once had.

Chapter 15: The Long Middle

There is a stretch of any fifty-year undertaking that resists being made into a story at all, and Stücker's fell somewhere in the middle of the 1980s, a run of years that produced no gunshot, no theft, no illness dramatic enough to survive as anecdote, and that he himself, asked to account for them decades later, could only gesture at in the vaguest terms: more countries, more borders, more of the same steady, unglamorous arithmetic that had kept him fed and moving since Austria. It was not, he was careful to insist whenever a journalist tried to compress it into a single sentence about loneliness or endurance, an unhappy stretch. It was simply the largest part of the iceberg, the part beneath the waterline that never made it into any interview because it had no shape dramatic enough to be worth the telling, and he distrusted, on principle, any account of his life that skipped straight from headline to headline as though the years between them had not been the actual substance of the thing.

What those years actually contained, when he let himself describe them in the plainer register he reserved for people who asked patiently rather than for a quote, was a specific and cumulative loneliness that he did not dramatize and did not entirely deny either. He had built, by the middle of that decade, a life almost entirely without fixed relationships — no wife, no children, no address that held still long enough to receive a birthday card on the correct date — and he had built it deliberately, in the sense that every year he continued was a year he had

chosen not to trade the road for the alternative, but he had not built it without cost, and the cost showed up, in those middle years, less as a single dramatic ache and more as a low, persistent background note he learned to live alongside the way you learn to live alongside tinnitus: never gone, rarely sharp enough to stop him doing anything, always faintly present when the day's noise settled enough to let him hear it.

He met, in one of those unremarkable years he could no longer place with confidence on a calendar, a woman running a small guesthouse along a coastal road, a widow a few years his senior who had taken over the business from a husband lost to illness rather than to any of the more dramatic hazards Stücker himself collected, and who fed him three nights running the way half the households on the whole journey had fed him, except that on the third night neither of them found a natural reason to end the conversation once the meal itself was finished, and he stayed a fourth night, and then a fifth, doing small unpaid repairs around the guesthouse in a rough approximation of rent he suspected she did not actually need but accepted anyway because it let him feel the stay was earned rather than simply extended. He did not, in the retelling he gave once, decades later, to the one interviewer patient enough to draw it out of him, make more of it than it had actually been. There was no grand declaration, no proposal considered and declined, nothing so tidy. There was a week, then two, of an ordinary domestic rhythm he had not experienced since Hövelhof and had almost forgotten the specific shape of — a fixed chair at a fixed table, a routine that did not require negotiation each morning with a stranger's goodwill, a body beside his own that was simply, uncomplicatedly, present.

He left anyway, at the end of the second week, and he was honest, in the retelling, about why: not because the guesthouse or the woman had failed to offer him anything, but because he had felt, sitting at that fixed table on a morning like any other, the specific and familiar itch of a life half lived returning, the sense that the list of countries not yet visited was accumulating somewhere just outside the guesthouse's pleasant walls regardless of how content he felt inside them, and that staying past the point the itch appeared would mean choos-

ing the guesthouse over the list in a way he was not, at that point in his life, prepared to choose. He did not frame this, afterward, as a noble sacrifice for the sake of the project. He framed it, with the same plain honesty he applied to everything else, as simply the truth of what he wanted more, on balance, in that particular decade of his life — a truth that cost the woman something real, he acknowledged, without excusing it or dressing it up as anything other than what it was: a choice that put his own itch ahead of what she might reasonably have hoped the extra weeks were building toward. He wrote to her, afterward, for a few years, the correspondence thinning the way all his correspondences thinned over time, until it stopped altogether, and he did not know, by the time anyone thought to ask him about her decades later, whether she was even still alive.

The camera economy, meanwhile, had matured by the middle of the decade into something close to its final, permanent shape, and he had begun, in these unremarkable years, licensing his photographs more formally — a European magazine here, a travel supplement there, a small syndication arrangement with an agency that took a cut he considered fair and paid, when it paid at all, with the specific unreliability he had come to expect from any institution larger than a single shopkeeper's till. He kept the ledger with the same scrupulous private care as ever, and noticed, reviewing it some evenings by lamplight, that the shape of his income had shifted subtly over two decades: less dependent now on postcards sold directly from the bike at roadside, more dependent on licensing fees that arrived, irregularly and by post, from institutions he had sometimes never actually met in person, a shift that suited a man growing slowly less inclined, in his forties, to spend an entire afternoon haggling over three postcards with a shopkeeper who wanted them for a fraction of what they were worth.

He grew, across those years, into the specific, undersold humour that everyone who met him in his later decades would come to recognize as characteristically his — a dry, patient wit about bureaucracy, about the universal absurdity of a border official demanding a form that existed only to justify the official's own job, about the specific, repeated comedy of being asked, in country after country, the same single question by the same variety of curious strangers: why. He developed, over

these years, a small repertoire of answers to that question, deployed depending on his mood and the asker — a shrug, a joke about the price of rent in Hövelhof, occasionally, for someone he judged might actually want an honest answer, the plain truth that he had simply never found a convincing argument for stopping, and that the question itself, asked so often and so earnestly by people who had never once considered riding anywhere themselves, amused him rather more than it troubled him. He did not consider himself, in these years or any others, a philosopher. He considered himself a man who rode a bicycle for a living, and he found, more often than not, that the plainest possible answer to why served him better, in the long run, than any of the grander ones journalists occasionally tried to put in his mouth.

Chapter 16: What the Mother Kept

She had died, his mother, sometime in his middle decades, at a date he could recall only approximately, having learned of it by letter weeks after the fact, the specific delay of the news arriving to a man with no fixed address one of the quieter costs of the life he had built, a cost he rarely discussed in interviews because it embarrassed him in a way that the more dramatic losses never quite did — the simple, unglamorous fact that he had not been present for his own mother's death, and had learned of it, in the end, the same way he learned of most things on the road: by a letter that had chased him across several countries before finally catching up.

He returned to Hövelhof only briefly in the immediate aftermath, a visit shorter than any interviewer who heard about it later expected, staying just long enough to see to what needed seeing to and to sit, alone, for a single afternoon, with the tin she had kept for thirty years in the sideboard drawer: his letters, in order, the postcards from every continent, the Guinness certificate she had never seen in person but had apparently read about in a local paper and clipped, the article folded carefully alongside his own correspondence as though it belonged to the same category of evidence, and, at the bottom, beneath all of it, the photograph of him at nineteen in his apprentice's overalls, unsmiling, holding a finished die up to the light.

He had not known, until that single afternoon with the tin open on the kitchen table, quite how completely she had kept the record he had

always assumed she treated with the same practical indifference she brought to most sentiment — his father's silence, six weeks after the apprenticeship was abandoned, had led him to assume, without ever quite examining the assumption, that his mother's own reaction to the whole undertaking had settled somewhere similarly cool, a dutiful correspondence maintained more from habit than from any deeper investment in the specific shape his life had taken. The tin corrected that assumption entirely, and corrected it too late for him to say anything useful to her about what he found in it. Every letter, however brief, however deliberately flattened into the plain reassuring register he had always used with her, had been kept, read presumably many times over given the specific softness of the paper's folds, and organized with a care that told him, more clearly than any single sentence she had ever actually spoken to him, exactly how closely she had followed a son who wrote her, across three and then four decades, considerably less than she had plainly wanted.

He sat with the tin for the length of that single afternoon and did not, by his own later account, cry in any dramatic way, understanding grief, by then, the way he understood most difficult things: as information to be absorbed practically rather than performed, a private reckoning rather than a public one. What he felt, more than sorrow exactly, was something closer to a specific and belated recalculation of a debt he had not fully understood he owed — that the flattened, reassuring letters he had sent her for four decades, designed carefully to spare her the actual weight of what his days contained, had also, in the sparing, denied her the fuller record of a son's actual life that she had, evidently, wanted very much to have, and had settled for whatever fragments he was willing to give her instead, keeping even those fragments with a devotion he had never troubled himself to imagine while she was alive to receive his letters and answer them.

He took the tin with him when he left Hövelhof again, folding it into the same satchel that carried the negatives, and it travelled with him, from that point forward, through the remaining decades of the journey, a small addition to the load he carried that he never once complained about the extra weight of, understanding it now as ballast of an entirely different and more important kind than the film and the panniers

— proof, carried forward through every subsequent border and every subsequent theft-proofed oilcloth wrapping, that somewhere behind every kilometre of the ride, a woman in a Westphalian kitchen had been quietly, faithfully keeping the truer record of it all along, in the one language of care that had never actually needed his own more eloquent letters to make its meaning entirely, achingly clear.

Chapter 17: The Network

It did not have a name, the loose association of people across dozens of countries who had, over five decades, become something between fans, hosts, and family, and Stücke himself resisted, whenever a journalist tried to press one onto it, any word grander than “the people who wrote back.” It had begun, in the earliest years, as simple practicality: a guesthouse owner in one country who had fed him for a week and wanted to know, honestly, whether he had made it safely to the next one, an address exchanged on the back of a postcard with no expectation beyond a single confirming letter. It had grown, decade by decade, entirely without design, into something considerably larger — a scattered, informal web of people who had each hosted some fragment of his fifty years and had simply kept writing afterward, year after year, long past the point any ordinary courtesy would have required it.

He answered every letter he could, for fifty years, in the same flat, practical hand he had once used for his mother, a discipline that cost him, by any reasonable accounting, a genuinely significant fraction of his limited free hours across the whole journey, hours a less scrupulous man might have spent resting instead. He did not consider it a burden. He considered it, if pressed to name the actual mechanism, closer to a debt repaid in the only currency he reliably had available to him: his own continued, verifiable existence, proof to the people who had fed and sheltered him that their kindness had not simply vanished into the general noise of a stranger’s life and been forgotten the moment he rode on. A farmer outside Villach who had let a freezing young man sleep in his hay barn in 1962 received, across the following four decades, a slow trickle of postcards from every subsequent continent,

each one a small, deliberate proof that the barn had mattered, that the kindness had been carried forward rather than simply consumed and left behind.

The network fed him in ways beyond the merely financial, though it fed him financially too — small donations, arriving irregularly by post, from people who had followed his progress for years and wanted, in their own words more than once, simply to be part of something that large without having to ride a single kilometre of it themselves. It fed him information: warnings about a border that had recently closed, a recommendation for a guesthouse two countries ahead run by a cousin of someone he had stayed with a decade before, the scattered, informal intelligence network of people who had a personal stake in his safe passage and passed word along, town to town, in a manner considerably more reliable, in his own experience, than any official consulate advisory. It fed him, above all, the specific and cumulative sense, across fifty years of genuine solitude on the road itself, that he was not, in fact, entirely alone in the world in the way a man riding six hundred thousand kilometres by himself might reasonably have expected to become — that somewhere, at any given moment, dozens of households across dozens of countries were thinking of him, wondering where he had got to, half- expecting a postcard that would eventually, reliably, arrive.

He kept every address in the same tolerance-obsessed private ledger he had once used for die measurements and print sales, updating it by hand across five decades as people moved, married, had children who then wrote to him in their own right having grown up hearing about the German cyclist their parents had once fed, occasionally, with a heaviness he did not dwell on in front of others, crossing a name out entirely when a letter came back from a grieving spouse instead. He did not sentimentalize the ledger. He treated it, characteristically, as simply another piece of essential equipment, no more mystical than the spoke key or the small knife with the bone handle, but he guarded it, in practice, more carefully than either, because a lost spoke key could be replaced in the next town and a lost fifty years of addresses could not be replaced at any price or in any town on earth.

When the museum committee, decades later, asked him what should actually go in the cases — which photographs, which objects, which fragment of the fifty years deserved to represent the whole of it to a visiting schoolchild who would spend perhaps twenty minutes in the building before moving on to lunch — he surprised them, more than once, by pushing past the dramatic candidates, the bullet-toe story, the Siberian theft, toward the ledger itself, the unglamorous handwritten record of thousands of addresses across dozens of countries, and suggesting, more than half seriously, that this, properly displayed, said more honestly about what the fifty years had actually been than any single photograph of a mountain or a market ever could. The committee, in the end, found room for both. He considered that a fair compromise, and said so, and did not push the point any further than that, because he had learned, across a great many negotiations in a great many languages, exactly how far a fair compromise could be pushed before it stopped being either fair or a compromise.

Chapter 18: The Spare Room

Across every one of the hundred and ninety-five countries, in ledgers and letters he kept for fifty years, one specific category of hospitality recurred with a consistency that struck him, cumulatively, as more remarkable than any single dramatic rescue: the spare room, or its equivalent — a barn corner, a floor mat, a hammock strung between two posts — offered by people who had never heard of him before the moment he appeared at their door and would very likely never hear of him again after he rode on the following morning.

He came to think of this specific, worldwide, entirely uncoordinated infrastructure of casual shelter as the actual circulatory system beneath the whole visible journey — not the borders, not the record books, not even the postcards that paid for it, but this: millions of ordinary rooms, in millions of ordinary houses, kept ready in the loose, informal sense that most households keep a spare blanket or a second chair, available on short notice to whichever stranger the day happened to bring, asking nothing in return beyond the ordinary courtesies any guest owed any host. He had slept, across five decades, in farmhouses and mission stations and a widow's guesthouse and a hundred variations of the same basic offer, extended by Christians and Muslims and Buddhists and the specifically unreligious alike, by rich households and considerably poorer ones, by people who spoke his language and people who exchanged not one comprehensible word with him beyond the universal gestures of *come in* and *eat* and *sleep here*.

He resisted, characteristically, any tidy explanation for why this specific form of generosity recurred so reliably across cultures that agreed on almost nothing else, distrusting, as ever, the grand unifying theory that made for a better closing line than an honest shrug. He offered, instead, in his more considered later interviews, a plainer observation: that hospitality toward the travelling stranger appeared to be one of the oldest and most widely distributed human behaviours he had personally verified, tested empirically across a hundred and ninety-five countries in a way almost no academic study could ever replicate, and that whatever its ultimate origin — religious obligation, ancient survival instinct, simple decency — its actual, measurable prevalence had been the single factor, more than any bicycle part or any postcard sale, that had actually kept him alive and moving for sixty-four years.

He said, in his final months, to the museum committee debating what final message the building itself might offer a visitor on their way back out the door, that if the whole museum could be reduced to one closing line, it would not be about kilometres or countries at all. It would be a plain, specific instruction, aimed at the very people walking past his own bicycle on their way home: that somewhere in their own town, tonight, a spare room already existed, ready in the loose informal way spare rooms are always ready, and that the only thing standing between that room and a stranger who might one day need it was the same small, ordinary, entirely learnable willingness that had fed and sheltered him across a hundred and ninety-five countries and sixty-four years — the willingness, extended by a farmer outside Villach to a freezing young man in 1962 and by ten thousand strangers after him, to simply open the door.

Chapter 19: The Stamp Collection

He kept, somewhere in the accumulating archive of his own life, a private and entirely unscientific collection of the specific varieties of bureaucratic absurdity he had encountered at borders across fifty years, a collection he never published and rarely mentioned except to the small number of people he trusted enough to find it as quietly funny as he did. It amused him precisely because it was so consistent, across languages and regimes and decades that had nothing else whatsoever in common: the specific human tendency, wherever a desk and a stamp and a small measure of unsupervised authority converged, to generate procedure entirely for its own sake, unrelated to any actual purpose the procedure had ever been designed to serve.

There was the customs official, somewhere in his thirties, in a country he preferred not to name aloud even decades later out of a lingering, half-serious fear of some fresh bureaucratic reprisal, who required him to complete a customs declaration for the bicycle itself on both entry and exit, despite the bicycle plainly, visibly, being ridden across the border under Stücker's own two legs rather than shipped as freight, a form whose only conceivable function, as far as Stücker could ever determine, was to generate the specific, satisfying sound of a stamp descending onto paper, a sound that seemed, in his private theory, to constitute its own reward for a certain kind of official mind regardless of what the stamped document actually recorded.

There was the consulate, in an entirely different country and decade,

that required three separate photographs for a visa renewal, each photograph specified in a slightly different and mutually contradictory format by three different sub-clauses of the same regulation, so that satisfying one clause automatically violated another, a puzzle Stücker eventually solved not through any clever workaround but through the simple, patient expedient of submitting all three formats simultaneously and letting the clerk choose which contradiction to overlook, a solution the clerk accepted, Stücker suspected, with some private relief at not having to be the one who noticed the regulation's actual absurdity out loud.

There was the guard at a minor crossing who asked him, with evident and entirely genuine curiosity rather than any suspicion at all, whether the bicycle itself required its own passport, a question Stücker answered, after a beat of considering whether the man was joking, with the same flat honesty he gave every question, explaining that no, the bicycle travelled on his passport, the way a child travels on a parent's, and watching the guard turn this explanation over with visible and apparently satisfying interest before waving him through with what Stücker read, afterward, as the specific warmth of a man who had genuinely enjoyed the small mental puzzle of the encounter rather than merely processing another anonymous traveller.

He came to think of these encounters, collected across five decades and dozens of regimes, not as evidence of any particular country's inefficiency — he was careful, in later interviews, to resist any framing that let one nationality feel superior to another on this score, having watched the same essential absurdity recur with almost perfect consistency in wealthy countries and poor ones, democracies and dictatorships alike — but as evidence of something closer to a universal human comedy, the specific and apparently ineradicable tendency of any institution, anywhere, to eventually generate more paperwork than its original purpose could justify, simply because paperwork, once started, tends to accumulate its own justification for existing regardless of whether anyone can still explain what problem it was originally meant to solve. He found this observation, delivered dry and without particular malice, reliably one of the more effective ways to end an interview on a note that made a journalist laugh rather than reach for

something more solemn, and he deployed it, increasingly, in his later decades, as a kind of practiced closing line — not because it was rehearsed in any dishonest sense, but because he had discovered, the way any performer discovers their strongest material through years of testing it in front of live audiences, that this particular observation, told plainly and without embellishment, reliably did the specific work he wanted a story to do: it made people laugh, it made the fifty years sound like the plain human undertaking it actually was rather than a saint's ordeal, and it let him end the conversation on his own terms, dry and undersold, before anyone could push him toward the grander, more solemn account of himself that he had spent his entire adult life quietly, patiently declining to give.

Chapter 20: Mozambique, and the Book No One Asked Him to Write

The bees came for the soap, or the sweat, or some smell his body was making in the river that afternoon that he never identified and never needed to; what he needed to know, in the fifteen or twenty seconds it took the first sting to become fifty, was how to get out of open water fast enough that drowning did not become the more immediate of his two problems. He went under twice trying to protect his face and came up both times into a cloud he could hear before he could properly see it, a pitch of sound that his ears, thirty-three years into a life spent listening for engines and weather and the particular pressing silence that precedes an ambush, had never before had cause to file under danger.

He got out. He was stung, by the rough count a nurse gave him afterward, more times than either of them particularly cared to say aloud, his arms and neck and one eyelid swollen past easy recognition for the better part of a week, and he lay in the shade of the riverbank telling himself, in the flat interior voice he had perfected over three decades of talking himself through the aftermath of things, that a man who had been shot in Zambia and beaten in Egypt and nearly drowned in an Alaskan river was not, on balance, going to be the one African wildlife story that ended with bees. He was right, in the sense that matters most. He was also, for about four days, in more localized and continu-

ous pain than the bullet had ever caused him, a fact he found so absurd that he laughed about it, once the swelling let his face manage an expression again, more than he had laughed about almost anything else across the whole long journey — the shot fighters, the truck, the crowd in the street, none of it as purely, stupidly funny to him in hindsight as a fifty-five-year-old man being routed out of a river by an insect he could, under other circumstances, have comfortably held in his palm.

That was the year — 1995, thirty-three years out from Hövelhof, his beard fully grey now and his face weathered into the specific brown-leather texture that decades of equatorial sun leave on a man who had refused, on principle, to hide from it under a hat — that he finally sat down long enough to write the book.

He had been asked to write it for years, by journalists who found him at borders and by the occasional consulate official who had heard the stories secondhand and wanted them confirmed, and he had always said, more or less, that there was no time, which was true in the narrow sense and a convenient excuse in the larger one. The truth, closer to the bone, was that he did not entirely trust the idea of stopping long enough to describe the journey instead of continuing it — some superstition, half-formed and never examined too closely, that the writing might finish something the riding was supposed to keep permanently open. He got past that in 1995 the way he got past most obstacles: by simply doing it, without ceremony, in whatever spare hours the road and the swollen week by the river actually gave him, dictating some of it from memory into a tape recorder borrowed from a supporter back in Germany and typing the rest himself, two-fingered, on a borrowed machine, in guesthouses and mission stations between the rides, correcting his own drafts with the same tolerance-obsessed patience he had once applied to a die measurement.

He titled it plainly — *Mit dem Fahrrad um die Welt*, By Bicycle Around the World, no subtitle promising transformation or wisdom, because he did not consider himself in possession of either and did not want to sell a lie on the cover of a book that was, at its core, an account of an arithmetic problem: how many kilometres, how many borders, how many nights slept in how many strangers' spare rooms, told without

much interpretation because he had never fully trusted his own interpretations and preferred to let the numbers make whatever case they were going to make on their own. He self-published it. No house in Germany had shown serious interest in a cyclist's memoir with no war, no scandal, and no resolution — the man was, after all, still out there when the manuscript went to print, still riding, which made for an awkward ending that publishers, he was told more than once by editors who seemed to genuinely regret the decision even as they made it, found difficult to sell to a market that wanted its adventure stories to arrive at a conclusion.

He sold it himself, the way he had sold postcards and photographs for three decades: from the bike, at markets, to consulates, by mail order to the small and steadily growing network of people around the world who had, over the years, become something between fans and family — people who had fed him once in some earlier decade and kept writing ever since, people who considered his passing through their town a kind of holiday worth marking on a calendar. The arithmetic of it was the same arithmetic that had kept him alive since Austria: a product, a route, a modest but genuinely real return, no employer, no government grant, no sponsor's logo on the panniers to complicate the accounting. He was, by 1995, entirely self-financed in a way that most professional adventurers of his era, backed by corporate sponsors and television deals, were not, and he took a quiet, specific pride in that fact that he almost never stated directly, because stating it directly would have sounded, to his own ear, like an implicit complaint against the men who did have sponsors, and he did not begrudge them theirs, understanding that different men built different arrangements with the road and none of them was obliged to match his own.

The same year, the Guinness Book of Records credited him with the most widely travelled bicycle journey in history, a certificate that arrived by ordinary post and that he kept, along with the letters and the postcards and the old photograph of himself at nineteen holding a die up to the light, in the same unglamorous drawer of documentation that had, by 1995, become the closest thing he owned to an archive of his own life. He did not frame the certificate. He was, by his own honest account, faintly embarrassed by the whole idea of a record — travel

was not, to his mind, a race, and being told he had gone further than anyone else on two wheels felt a little like being congratulated for having breathed more air than anyone else, an achievement real enough on paper and slightly beside the point in the actual living of it, day to day, kilometre to kilometre. But he kept the certificate. He was not so far above vanity as all that, and he would have been lying, he admitted once, late at night to the one interviewer patient enough to get an honest answer out of him, if he had claimed the number meant absolutely nothing to him.

He rode on from the swollen week by the river with the specific, hard-won equanimity of a man who had, in the space of a single year, been the subject of an official world record and the victim of an insect ambush, and who understood, better than most people are ever required to, that both of those facts could be true of the same ordinary Tuesday and that neither one changed what the next morning actually required of him, which was, as it had been every morning for thirty-three years, to get back on the bicycle and keep the front wheel pointed at whatever came next, the certificate and the swollen eyelid both filed away, in the end, under the same plain heading: things that happened to him, in a year that also, for entirely unrelated reasons, happened to be the year he finally sat still long enough to write them all down.

Chapter 21: A Hundred Thousand Frames

Nobody, including Stücker himself, could tell you with any real confidence how the number had first been arrived at — a hundred thousand photographs, repeated so often in interviews and obituaries alike that it had long since calcified into fact, when the truer answer, had anyone pressed him closely enough on it in a quiet hour, was that the number was his own rough, honest estimate, arrived at by counting rolls and multiplying by frames and rounding, characteristically, toward modesty rather than grandeur whenever the arithmetic left him a choice between the two.

What the number could not convey, and what he tried, without much success, to explain to the occasional journalist patient enough to ask the right follow-up question, was the specific, cumulative labour the archive represented — not the taking of the photographs, which had become, across decades, close to reflexive, but the keeping of them. A negative was not simply an image; it was a small, fragile object that had to survive heat, humidity, river crossings, checkpoints, and the specific predations of thieves who could not tell the difference between a strip of exposed film worth nothing to anyone but Stücker and a strip that might, in poor light, be mistaken for something more obviously valuable. He had developed, across the decades, an entire private discipline around their survival: oilcloth wrapping, always double; a habit, formed early and never abandoned, of separating the archive across two containers whenever a crossing looked genuinely

dangerous, so that a single disaster — a capsized boat, a fire, a theft — could not claim the whole record at once; a running mental catalogue, updated obsessively, of which rolls covered which years and countries, so that even in the total chaos of the Siberian theft he had been able to tell the police, within minutes, more or less exactly what had been taken and roughly what it represented.

He developed most of the film himself in the early decades, in makeshift darkrooms improvised from whatever a given town could offer — a windowless storeroom, a curtained corner of a guesthouse bathroom, once, memorably, the back room of a Chilean pharmacy whose owner had taken a liking to the project and offered the space for the cost of a single print of the result. He learned the specific, finicky chemistry of developing in heat that ordinary photographic guidance, written for temperate European darkrooms, simply did not anticipate, ruining more than one early roll before he worked out, through trial and a good deal of wasted film, how to adjust his timings for a Kenyan afternoon or a Javanese wet season. Later, as the print shops along his route multiplied and his own patience for the work thinned with age, he outsourced more of the processing, trusting it increasingly to professionals in the larger cities he passed through, though he never entirely stopped checking their work with the same exacting, tolerance-obsessed eye he had once brought to a steel die, more than once sending a batch back for reprinting when a contrast or an exposure fell short of what he considered acceptable.

The archive, by the time the museum committee began sorting it in his old age, filled boxes that themselves filled a room, organized in a system that made complete sense to Stücke alone and that took the volunteers the better part of a year to learn to navigate without him standing over their shoulder correcting them. He found, going through it with them in his eighties, images he had entirely forgotten taking — a doorway in a country he could no longer place, a market stall whose exact town had slipped from memory decades before, faces of people he had certainly met and fed conversation to for an evening and could no longer, honestly, recall at all — and he was candid, in these moments, about the specific melancholy of it: that the camera had preserved more of his own life than his own memory ever could,

and that a great deal of what the negatives showed him was, by his eighties, genuinely news to him, a stranger's record of a stranger's decades that happened, by the accident of authorship, to also be his own.

He did not find this troubling in the way a visitor sometimes expected him to. He found it, instead, oddly reassuring — proof, laid out in negative strips across a hundred cardboard boxes, that the fifty years had actually contained more than any single human memory, however well-tended, could possibly hold onto by itself, and that the camera had done, faithfully and without complaint, exactly the job he had first asked it to do outside a rain-soaked Austrian church six decades before: hold a moment still long enough that someone, eventually, could look at it properly, even if that someone turned out, in the end, to be an old man in a museum storeroom, meeting his own forgotten younger life again for what was, in every meaningful sense, the very first time.

Chapter 22: The Photograph He Never Sold

There was one negative, among the hundred thousand, that he kept separate from the rest of the archive his entire life, carried in an inside pocket rather than the satchel, printed only once, and shown, so far as anyone could later determine, to almost no one at all across the five decades he carried it: a self-portrait, taken by his own hand at arm's length with the shutter set on a delay he had rigged himself, somewhere in his thirties, on a ridge above a valley he could no longer place with total confidence, his own face caught in an expression the museum committee, sorting the print decades later, struggled to name precisely — not triumph, not exhaustion, something closer to a plain, unguarded, momentary astonishment at his own continued existence, the specific look of a man who has just realized, mid-journey, exactly how far he has already come and has not yet decided what to do with the realization.

He never explained, to the committee or to anyone else who asked about it in his final years, exactly why this single image had earned a different treatment than the hundred thousand others, kept close rather than filed, printed once rather than reproduced for sale, and the committee, respecting a privacy he had rarely asked for regarding anything else across his long public life, did not press him past his own evident reluctance to say more. What he did offer, once, to the one biographer patient enough to ask a second time after the first refusal, was a partial answer that the biographer considered, afterward,

among the truest things Stücke ever said about his own interior life across the whole extended interview: that every other photograph in the archive had been taken for someone else, for a shopkeeper's till, for a magazine's page, for a stranger's living room wall, and that this one photograph, alone among a hundred thousand, had been taken for no one at all, with no market in mind, no buyer anticipated, simply a man on a ridge who had wanted, for reasons he could not fully articulate even to himself in the moment of pressing the shutter, some proof that existed independent of any transaction that this specific version of himself, at this specific unrepeatable moment, had actually been here.

He kept the print in the same inside pocket, replaced periodically as the paper wore thin from decades of proximity to his own body heat, through Zambia, through Siberia, through the Portsmouth theft that took nearly everything else he owned but had, by chance, not touched the pocket where this one image rode closest to his chest. He did not consider this survival a sign from anywhere beyond ordinary chance, resisting, as he resisted every other temptation toward mysticism across his long practical life, any reading of the coincidence as meaningful rather than simply lucky. But he kept the print anyway, decade after decade, and the museum committee found it, in the end, among his effects after his death, in the specific inside pocket of the jacket he had worn most often in his final years, worn soft at the fold from sixty-some years of exactly this same careful, private keeping.

They placed it, after some genuinely difficult debate — the first serious disagreement the committee had experienced since his death, over whether such an evidently private object belonged in a public museum at all — in a small case of its own, apart from the ledger and the frame section and the final unaddressed postcard, with a label considerably shorter than any other in the building: no date, no location, no explanation beyond his own name and the single word *self*, and visitors, the committee noticed in the months after the museum's full opening, tended to stand in front of this smallest and least explained of all the cases longer than in front of almost any other, studying a stranger's unguarded thirty-something face for whatever it was that a hundred thousand more legible, more saleable, more thor-

oughly captioned photographs, taken across the very same fifty years, had somehow never quite managed, on their own, to show.

Chapter 23: The Seychelles

He had expected, if he had allowed himself to expect anything at all, that the last country would announce itself. That there would be a border post, a stamp, a specific minute in which the arithmetic he had been carrying for sixteen years — since the decision had finished assembling itself somewhere in West Africa and he had noticed it was already made — finally came out even. What he got instead was an airport, because the Seychelles cannot be reached by bicycle in any sense that matters, an ocean standing in the way of the last few hundred kilometres of a journey that had otherwise been entirely a matter of wheels and legs and weather, and a customs officer who stamped his passport with exactly the same brisk, faintly bored competence with which every customs officer on earth had stamped it for thirty-four years running.

He stood in the arrivals hall for longer than the queue behind him appreciated, working out, with a kind of stunned internal arithmetic, that this — this specific hall, this specific stamp, this specific officer already looking past him toward the next passenger in line — was the country. The last one. The one hundred and ninety-fifth flag, if you counted the way the record books counted, which he had never been entirely sure was the correct way to count, since flags changed under him constantly and a country he had entered under one name had sometimes, by the time he left it, ceased to exist under that name at all.

He walked out of the airport into heat and salt air and the specific shade of blue-green water that he would, for the rest of his life, asso-

ciate with an anticlimax so complete it took him days to even locate the right word for it. He had thought — insofar as he had let himself think about the end of the project at all, which he mostly hadn't, on the reasonable theory that a target sixteen years in the making deserved not to be jinxed by too much advance imagining — that arrival would feel like arrival. Like the freewheel's tick going suddenly, blessedly silent after decades of ticking. Instead it felt like nothing so much as reaching the top of a long climb and discovering, through the sweat in his eyes, that the road simply kept going on the other side, flatter now, perhaps, but going nonetheless, indifferent to whatever finish line he had privately drawn across it.

He sat on a low wall near the harbour with the bicycle propped against his leg — a different bicycle in its particular parts by now than the one that had left Hövelhof, rewelded and repainted and re-spoked more times than he had bothered to keep careful count of, but the same bicycle in every sense that had ever actually mattered to him — and tried, honestly, to feel finished. He could not. He turned the fact over for most of an afternoon, watching fishing boats come in against a sunset that would have been, on any other day of his life, simply beautiful, and on this particular day felt vaguely accusatory, as though the scenery itself expected more visible gratitude from him than he currently had available to give.

The trouble, he decided eventually — not in a single flash, the way the decision to see every country had not itself arrived in a single flash, but slowly, the way most of his real understandings arrived, at the bottom of a long day rather than at its bright beginning — was that “every country” had never actually been the point. It had been a way of organizing sixteen years so that they had a shape a stranger in a bar could nod along to. But the actual content of those sixteen years, the actual thing he had been doing every single one of the several thousand days between the decision and this harbour wall, had never once been about completing a list. It had been about what happened between the border posts — the woman filling his water bottle in Java without being asked, the boy watching his bicycle for ten days outside a mission clinic and asking nothing in return, the truck driver in the Atacama roping a wrecked wheel into his flatbed and driving him to the

next town unbidden — and none of that, he understood now, watching the boats come in, had a natural stopping point built into it anywhere. There was no country left to visit that would produce more of it, but there was also no reason on earth that the visiting itself required a country left in order to continue. The list had been the excuse. The road had been the actual reason, and the road, unlike the list, was not the kind of thing a man could finish, however many stamps accumulated in his passport.

He photographed the harbour that evening, sold three prints to a hotel gift shop before the week was out, the same arithmetic he had run in Austria thirty-four years earlier running itself again without his needing to think about it consciously, film into cash, cash into film, the machine of his own survival humming along beneath the larger, stranger fact that he had just achieved something no one before him had achieved and did not, if he was honest with the version of himself that only came out at the end of long days, feel very much of anything about it at all, beyond a low and persistent puzzlement at his own lack of feeling.

He wrote his mother — she was elderly now, and the letters between them had become, over the decades, shorter and gentler and somehow more honest for containing less — a single line telling her that he had, in a manner of speaking, run out of countries. He did not say what he intended to do about that, mostly because he did not yet know himself. He assumed, in the vague way a man assumes things he has not examined closely, that he would keep going regardless, revisiting, deepening, filling in the gaps a first pass at “everywhere” inevitably leaves behind it — the back roads, the second cities, the places he had ridden through at speed the first time because a border was closing or a season was turning and he had promised himself, silently, that he would come back to them properly one day. He did not know, sitting on that harbour wall, that this quiet promise — the coming back properly — would end up organizing the next decade and a half of his life almost as thoroughly as the original departure had organized the first thirty-four years, or that the finishing, when it in some sense eventually happened, would look considerably less like an arrival than like this exact harbour: an ordinary evening, a sunset he could not quite feel the way the moment seemed to demand, and a road that, hav-

ing apparently run out of new countries to offer him, simply changed, without announcement, what it was offering him instead.

Chapter 24: The Ordinary Miraculous

There is a specific quality of sight that develops in a man who has looked at more of the earth's actual surface, at close range and at the pace of his own legs, than almost anyone else alive, and Stücker came to recognize it in himself only slowly, across decades, as a kind of professional attentiveness rather than any mystical gift — the plain, trained habit of a man whose working life depended on noticing which twelve frames out of thirty-six a market would actually pay for, applied now to the whole of his waking existence rather than merely to the contents of his camera bag.

He rode past wonders the guidebooks of his era considered essential and felt, more than once, nothing much at all — a famous view arrived at exactly on schedule, in exactly the light the postcards promised, producing in him only the faint, professional disappointment of a man recognizing a composition he had already, in some sense, seen a thousand times in other travellers' photographs before he ever laid eyes on the original himself. And he found wonder, again and again across the decades, in places no guidebook had ever thought to send a tourist: a single fig tree at a crossroads in a country he could no longer place with confidence, grown so large and so old that three separate generations of a nearby village had built their understanding of the local weather around its specific seasonal behaviour, its leafing and its dropping, in a way that made the tree itself into something closer to a communal calendar than a mere plant; a stretch of coastline, un-

named on any map he carried, where the specific colour of the water changed by the hour with a subtlety he found himself, uncharacteristically, unable to photograph to his own satisfaction no matter how many frames he spent trying, the actual experience of standing there simply exceeding what a rectangle of film could hold.

He learned, across the decades, to distinguish between the wonder that arrived from scale — a mountain range, a desert horizon, the specific vertiginous scale of a landscape too large for a single photograph to properly contain — and the wonder that arrived from intimacy instead: a single grandmother's hands, in some village kitchen he passed through once and never returned to, working dough with a specific economical competence that told him, without a shared word of language between them, everything he needed to know about a whole life's worth of practiced labour. He came to value the second kind more than the first, over time, though he never said so in quite those words to any journalist, understanding that the grand-scale wonder was easier to sell as a postcard and the intimate kind was, in its own way, the truer record of what fifty years on a bicycle had actually taught him: that the earth's real marvels were not, on the whole, its mountains, which simply sat where geology had put them and required no particular virtue to admire, but its people, who built, against every reasonable expectation of scarcity and danger, small specific pockets of grace — a meal shared, a wheel trued, a stranger's negatives kept dry through a monsoon — over and over, in country after country, with no larger audience in mind than the single traveller in front of them.

He photographed both kinds, across the decades, in roughly the proportion the market demanded rather than the proportion his own private taste preferred, understanding that a shopkeeper wanted mountains and coastlines to sell to a passing tourist, not a stranger's hands working dough in a kitchen no tourist would ever visit. But he kept, in a separate and much smaller stack within the larger archive, a private selection of the photographs that had actually moved him at the moment of taking them, regardless of their commercial value, and it was this smaller stack, the museum committee discovered decades later, sorting through the boxes in his old age, that he returned to most often in his final years, laying the prints out on a table in the half-built mu-

seum and studying them with the same quiet, unhurried attention he had once given a mountain pass he was deciding whether to attempt, as though even now, at the very end of the whole long undertaking, there remained something in those specific frozen moments he had not yet finished properly seeing.

Chapter 25: Siberia

He woke to an absence so specific it took his sleeping mind several seconds to identify what, exactly, was wrong with the room, because the room itself was intact — a cheap guesthouse on the edge of a town whose name he would later struggle to pull back out of memory with any confidence, the whole of Siberia by 1997 having become, in his private geography, a single vast cold corridor rather than a sequence of distinct places — and it was only when he sat up that he understood the wrongness was not in the room at all but in the space beside the door where the bicycle had stood the night before, panniers still buckled, exactly where he had left it before sleep.

It was gone. All of it. The bicycle, the panniers, the camera, the film, the small careful archive of a life's work that he carried the way another man might carry his savings in a vest strapped against his own skin, and every scrap of luggage that had made the difference, for thirty-five years, between a man travelling and a man simply lost. He stood in the doorway of that guesthouse room in the Siberian cold in his socks, working through the same numb arithmetic he had run once before in an American filling station forecourt years earlier — item by item, this time slower, because there was so very much more to count by 1997 than there had been in his twenties — and arrived, faster than he expected to, at a strange and deeply unwelcome clarity: he had, for the first time in thirty-five years, absolutely nothing.

No bicycle. No papers beyond the ones on his own person. No photographs — a hundred thousand of them, by the rough count he had been keeping, scattered now God knew where, sold for scrap silver or

simply dumped by a thief with no earthly use for a stranger's decades of accumulated negatives. No means, in the most literal sense, of making the next kilometre, let alone the next month's income. He had been robbed before, singly, of a camera in Cameroon, of supplies at that American filling station, of trust more times than he cared to count across the whole long journey. He had never before been robbed of the entire apparatus of his own continued existence in one single night, by someone patient and quiet enough to get past a locked door and out again without waking a man who, after thirty-five years on the road, did not consider himself an easy person to rob unnoticed.

He reported it to the local police with the flat, exhausted persistence of a man who had learned, across dozens of countries and as many varieties of official indifference, exactly how much energy a report like this one was actually worth spending and exactly how little it usually returned for the spending. He did not expect much. Siberia in 1997 was not a place overflowing with resources for tracking a stolen bicycle belonging to a foreigner, however remarkable that bicycle's history; there were larger crimes for a thin, underfunded local force to spend its hours on, and he understood that without needing it explained to him by anyone.

What happened next he told, for the rest of his life, with a kind of bewildered gratitude that never entirely faded no matter how many times he retold it: everything was recovered. The bicycle. The panniers. The camera. The luggage. Whether it was the police doing careful, competent work he had not particularly expected, or whether the thief — panicking, perhaps, at the scale of what he'd taken once he understood there was no easy market for a battered touring bicycle and a hundred thousand negatives of a stranger's entire life — abandoned it somewhere it could be found, Stücke was never afterward entirely sure, and characteristically did not press the question much further than his own gratitude strictly required. He got it back. That was the fact that mattered, and he treated the how of it the way he treated most of the unexplained mercies of the previous thirty-five years: as something to be received rather than interrogated too closely, for fear of somehow using it up in the interrogating.

He sat with the recovered bicycle in a police station corridor that smelled of cigarette smoke and old radiator heat, checking the panniers one by one, the negatives one by one where he could manage it, the particular tactile relief of his own handwriting on his own contact sheets almost more moving to him, he admitted once, than the bicycle's return itself — because the bicycle he could, in theory, have replaced, painfully and at considerable expense, but a hundred thousand photographs of thirty-five years were not a thing any insurance or any goodwill could have restored to him if the thief had simply thrown the whole satchel into a river. They had not been thrown in a river. He held that fact for the rest of his life the way you hold the one piece of luck you cannot fully account for and choose, deliberately, not to examine too closely.

He rode out of that town within the week, colder than he had been in years, the bicycle's frame carrying a fresh set of scratches from wherever it had spent its missing days that he never fully explained even to himself, and understood, pedalling east through a landscape that seemed to stretch on with the same flat indifference the bicycle itself had always shown him, that he had just been given, by luck or by competence or by a frightened man's late change of heart, the clearest possible demonstration of what thirty-five years on the road had actually been building in him the whole time. Not invulnerability — Zambia had settled that particular argument permanently, seventeen years earlier. Something closer to a kind of trust that he could not have defended in an argument and did not particularly try to: that the road, taken as a whole rather than in any single terrifying night of it, gave back more than it took, and that a man who kept riding it long enough eventually accumulated enough evidence of that fact to survive the nights when it plainly, temporarily, did not hold true at all.

Chapter 26: Two on a Recumbent

The Hase Pino was not his bicycle, and that was most of what made it strange to ride.

He had crossed Canada alone before, decades earlier, west to east or east to west depending on which crossing you asked him about, because by 2002 he had lost precise count of how many times this particular country had passed beneath him — a hazard, he had long since decided, of having made “every country” the early ambition and then simply continued riding regardless of its completion: places that were meant to be visited once became, over forty years, places visited five times, six times, their borders and weather and specific stretches of prairie boredom blurring together into something closer to a relationship than a memory. But this crossing, a brief one, weeks rather than months, he made on a tandem recumbent, low to the road, two seats instead of one, with a travelling partner whose company he had not sought out so much as simply not declined when it was offered, which was, for a man who had spent forty years perfecting the art of travelling entirely on his own terms, close enough to an invitation that he surprised himself by accepting it.

He did not talk about this stretch much, afterward, in the long recitations he gave to journalists and eventually to a patient biographer with a notebook — not because it had gone badly, but because it did not fit easily into the shape the rest of the story had. Forty years of solitary arithmetic — one rider, one bicycle, one set of decisions about

which road and which border and which night's shelter — do not easily make room for a second person's preferences, and he found himself, somewhere around the Manitoba border, doing something he had almost entirely stopped doing on his own: asking. Asking whether they should stop here or push on. Asking whether the pace was too much. A small, ordinary courtesy that cost him nothing to extend and that he noticed himself extending with the faint, bemused surprise of a man rediscovering a muscle he had assumed had atrophied from decades of disuse.

The recumbent itself he found peculiar in a way that amused him more than it bothered him — the low seat, the pedalling posture closer to lying down than sitting, the strange sensation of steering a vehicle from a position that made the horizon look wrong, too close, the road rushing at chest height instead of arriving the way it always had, over handlebars, from above and slightly ahead. He was, by 2002, over sixty, and there was a specific vanity in him — he would have called it that himself, unprompted, because he was capable of that kind of blunt honesty about his own smaller motives — that resented, for the first few days, how comfortable the recumbent's seat was after forty years of a hard leather saddle. Comfort felt, briefly, faintly like cheating, like admitting a weakness he had spent decades proving he did not have. He got over it within the week. A man who has been shot, robbed, beaten, and nearly drowned is not, on reflection, obligated to also suffer unnecessarily in the seat of his bicycle, and he told himself so, more than once, in a tone that suggested he was still not entirely convinced even as he said it.

What he remembered most clearly from the crossing, decades later, was not the machine itself but the ordinary rhythm of a shared silence — two people on one frame, moving at a single pace neither of them had chosen entirely alone, watching the same stretch of Canadian sky from the same six inches of the same road, for a handful of weeks that changed nothing structural about the rest of his life and yet sat, afterward, in his memory with a specific, undefended warmth that the solitary decades around it did not generally produce. He did not become, after this crossing, a man who actively sought out company on the road. He went back, within the year, to riding alone, which had

been by then not so much a preference as simply the terms of his life, the way a fish's terms are water. But he kept, for the rest of his years, a small and specific fondness for that stretch of prairie and that low, strange, unexpectedly comfortable machine, filed away in the same private drawer where he kept the letters and the Guinness certificate and the photograph of himself at nineteen — not the largest thing that had ever happened to him on the road, not the most dramatic by any measure, but one of the very few he could revisit, in memory, without the accompanying tax of having to first survive it again in the retelling.

He was asked, once, by that same patient biographer, whether he had ever regretted not marrying, not settling, not trading the fifty years of solitary road for the ordinary companionable weight of a shared life. He considered the question longer than he considered most, turning his coffee cup a half-rotation on the table between them, and said, in the end, only that he had liked the Canada weeks very much, and that liking something very much was not, in his own considered experience, the same thing as wishing he had built his whole life around more of it. It was, he said, closer to weather you were glad to have ridden through once — worth remembering exactly, worth returning to in memory on a bad day, and not, on the whole, an argument against the specific and different road he had actually chosen to build his life upon instead.

Chapter 27: The Other Riders

He met, across five decades, a small and scattered fraternity of other long-distance cyclists, overlanders, and assorted wanderers whose paths crossed his own for a day, a week, occasionally a month, and he came to think of these encounters as some of the most valuable and least documented texture of the whole journey, precisely because they rarely produced anything as clean as an anecdote — two travellers exchanging practical information about the road ahead did not, on the whole, generate the kind of story a journalist could use, and so this entire category of his life went almost entirely unrecorded anywhere except his own memory and the occasional line in a letter to the correspondence network back home.

He had heard rumours, in his earliest African years, of a predecessor whose story he never fully verified, a half-legendary figure passed along through truck drivers and mission radios, and he came, across the following decades, to occupy roughly that same half-legendary position himself for a younger generation of riders who set out in the seventies, eighties, and nineties, having heard, themselves, some secondhand fragment of the story of the German who never stopped. He met a handful of these younger riders directly, crossing paths on a shared stretch of road in a manner that felt, to him, less like meeting a stranger than meeting a slightly displaced younger version of his own earlier self, full of the same specific mixture of confidence and terror he remembered from his own first years out of Hövelhof.

He gave them, when he met them, the same practical information the road's older hands had once given him — which borders were currently difficult, which mountain passes closed in which months, the specific etiquette of a region's hospitality that a newcomer could easily misjudge and cause real offence without meaning to — and he was candid, in later interviews, about the specific responsibility he felt toward these encounters, a responsibility he had not chosen so much as simply inherited from every stranger who had ever fed or sheltered or warned him across his own first uncertain years. He did not romanticize the fraternity of long-distance riders into anything grander than it actually was; he had met, among them, generous and generous-spirited people in roughly the same proportion he had met such people everywhere else in his travels, and he had met, too, a handful whose competitive instincts toward mileage and record-keeping struck him as faintly ridiculous, a distortion of an activity he considered, at its best, to have nothing whatsoever to do with racing and everything to do with simply, patiently, seeing.

He formed, out of these scattered encounters, no lasting close friendships in the ordinary sense — the road's structure, one rider heading one direction and another heading the opposite way, rarely permitted more than a single shared meal or a single shared campsite before the paths diverged again, this time for good — but he retained, across the decades, a specific and genuine fondness for the whole scattered fraternity as a category, a fellow-feeling he extended even to riders he had never personally met and never would, on the theory that anyone choosing this particular, specific, difficult way of seeing the world had chosen something he understood in his bones better than he understood almost anything else, and deserved, on that basis alone, whatever small practical kindness he happened to be positioned to offer them.

He heard, over the decades, of a handful of these riders who did not survive their own journeys — accidents, illness, in at least one case a robbery that turned considerably more violent than any of his own five had ever become — and he carried these losses privately, without much public display, understanding that he had, across fifty years and by a margin he considered almost entirely a matter of luck rather

than any particular skill of his own, simply been the one who came home to tell the story. He said, once, to the one biographer who drew the admission out of him gently and at some length, that he did not consider himself owed any explanation for why he had survived where others had not, and that the question, however naturally it arose, was ultimately unanswerable in any way that would satisfy either the asker or himself, and that the only honest response available to a man in his position was simply to keep riding, carefully, gratefully, for as long as the road and his own body continued to allow it.

Chapter 28: Portsmouth

He was sixty-six years old and had been robbed of the bicycle itself, by his own count, four times before this one, and he still felt the particular, specific lurch of it every single time — the half-second where the mind refuses the evidence of the eyes, insists the bicycle must simply be somewhere else on the campsite, behind that hedge, past that tent, before settling, reluctantly, into the flatter and more useless fact that it was not anywhere on the campsite at all, because it had been taken.

Portsmouth in the autumn was wet in the particular grey, drizzling, entirely undramatic way that English weather achieves without ever needing to become a proper storm, and he had pitched his tent among a dozen others on a municipal site that charged him almost nothing and asked almost nothing in return — the ordinary, unglamorous infrastructure of low-cost travel that had sheltered him, in one form or another, across six continents, and that had never once, in forty-four years, entirely failed him until the morning he woke to find the bicycle gone from where he had chained it, badly, against a fence post that in hindsight had clearly not been the deterrent he had hoped it would be.

He was, if he was honest about it afterward, less frightened than he had been in Siberia and more simply, thoroughly irritated — the specific, weary irritation of a man in his mid-sixties rediscovering that a lesson he had thought he'd learned nine years earlier had apparently not stuck hard enough to survive a wet English autumn and a poorly chosen fence post. He reported it to the local police with the same flat, unsurprised persistence he had used in Siberia, in a coun-

try whose relationship to petty theft and to the eccentric German cyclist reporting it was rather different from the Siberian one — English constables, he found, treated the loss with a brisk, sympathetic competence that came, he suspected, less from any special reverence for his fifty-year journey (they had, most of them, never heard of him before that morning) and more from the plain fact that a stolen touring bicycle loaded with panniers and a camera was, in Portsmouth, in this particular decade, simply an ordinary crime that ordinary police work occasionally, satisfyingly, solved.

It was solved. The bicycle turned up the following day in a local park, abandoned in a hedge, its panniers rifled through but largely intact, whatever the thief had been hoping to find — cash, most likely, or something more easily fenced than several months of unprocessed film — evidently not present in sufficient quantity to make the risk worthwhile, or perhaps simply not present in a form the thief recognized as valuable at all. He recovered it himself, walking the mile and a half from the campsite to the park with a constable who seemed, Stütcke thought, faintly delighted by how tidily the whole case had resolved itself, a rare clean win in a job that could not have offered many of them.

He sat afterward on a park bench with the bicycle upright against his knee, checking the panniers the way he had checked them in that Siberian police corridor nine years before — negatives first, counted by feel more than by sight, the film stock and the receipts and the small folded map he had, by then, annotated in six different inks across four different decades — and found himself, to his own mild surprise, laughing out loud on the bench, alone. Not at the theft itself. At the arithmetic of it: two continents, two recoveries, nine years apart, both times a stranger's carelessness or conscience undoing a stranger's crime before the loss became permanent. He had ridden, by 2006, through wars and coups and one genuinely murderous crowd in Haiti, and here he was, sixty-six years old, laughing on a bench in an English municipal park because a small-time thief in Portsmouth had apparently found a sixty-six-year-old man's camera equipment more trouble than it was worth to actually sell.

He wrote nothing dramatic home about this one — there was, by 2006, less and less of a “home” to write to in the old sense; his mother long dead by then, the letters of his middle decades replaced by occasional calls and, increasingly, by the quiet correspondence of the growing network of people around the world who had become, collectively, something closer to family than the word “readers” or “supporters” usually implies. He mentioned the Portsmouth theft, when he mentioned it at all, as a story to make people laugh rather than a story to make them worry, a deliberate choice he had been making, by then, for forty years running: that the ledger of the bad days existed and was real, but that it was his own to carry, and that presenting it to the people who loved him as anything heavier than an anecdote would have been, in his own private accounting, an imposition he had no right to make on anyone who had not chosen the road themselves the way he had.

He rode out of Portsmouth within the week, toward the ferry, toward the mainland, toward whatever the next stretch of a journey now in its forty-fourth year happened to require of him, the bicycle under him carrying, in its frame and its rewelds and its many replaced parts, the entire quiet history of everywhere it had been stolen from and everywhere it had been given back — a machine, by now, that had survived more attempts on its own continued existence than most of the men who had tried to take it, and that showed, in its scars, exactly nothing about any of them, the same steel indifference it had carried out of Hövelhof forty-four Novembers before, when a younger man with forty marks in a tobacco tin had first put his foot on the pedal and refused, on principle, to look back at the town he was leaving.

Chapter 29: What a Man Actually Owns

He was asked, more than once across the decades, by journalists reaching for a clean closing line, what he actually owned, the question usually intended to draw out some tidy renunciate philosophy about the freedom of travelling light. He resisted the tidy version every time, because the honest answer was more complicated and, he thought, considerably more interesting than the version the question was fishing for.

He owned, materially, remarkably little across the whole fifty years — the bicycle, its accumulated tools, the camera and whatever stock of film he currently carried, a change of clothes, the satchel of negatives that represented, by any honest accounting, the largest single asset he possessed and the one most likely to be worthless to anyone but himself. He did not own a house, a car, a pension, or any of the ordinary accumulations that organized the lives of every man he'd grown up with in Hövelhof. He did not, for most of the fifty years, own a bank account in any conventional sense, conducting the whole of his financial life in cash, in postcards, in the informal credit and barter that hospitality along the road actually ran on, an arrangement that would have terrified a financial adviser and that he never once, across five decades, found genuinely wanting for his own specific purposes.

But he came, across the decades, to think the question itself was aimed at the wrong category of possession entirely. What he actually owned, in the sense that mattered most to him, was not objects

but a specific, accumulated body of practical knowledge that no thief could take from him the way a thief had taken his bicycle in Siberia: the knowledge of which mountain passes closed in which months, the specific taste of clean water after three days without it, the particular choreography of a Balkan table or a Syrian household's hospitality, the exact feel of a wheel a half-turn out of true under his palm before it had even begun to wobble visibly. He owned, too, in a way he found himself only able to articulate clearly very late in his life, a specific relationship to time that almost no one he met on the road, however wealthy, actually possessed: the freedom to let a single day be entirely its own event, unscheduled beyond the basic requirement of reaching the next town before dark, answerable to no calendar beyond weather and visa expiry and his own body's actual limits.

He was careful, in later years, not to present this ownership as morally superior to the more conventional kind. He had met, across five decades, plenty of wealthy, house-owning, pension-drawing men and women who were, by any measure he could apply, considerably happier and more at peace than he often was himself in the loneliest stretches of the long middle decades, and he refused, on principle, the easy romantic framing that his own choice had been braver or wiser than theirs, understanding it instead as simply a different arrangement, suited to a specific temperament that had decided, at twenty-two, standing in a Hövelhof yard with forty marks in a tobacco tin, that the specific trade he was making — security for motion, a fixed address for an ever-expanding one, the two hundred and eleventh identical steel component for six hundred thousand entirely non-identical kilometres — was a trade he personally preferred, without it needing to be, for that reason alone, a trade every other person should prefer as well.

What he did claim, in his more reflective later interviews, without much hedging, was that the particular kind of ownership he had chosen had made him considerably harder to frighten, in the ordinary sense that frightens most people who have built their lives around fixed possessions: the fear of losing a house, a job, a pension, a reputation. He had, across fifty years, lost the single possession that actually mattered most to him — the bicycle itself — on five separate occasions, and

recovered it, in whole or in part, every single time, and this specific, repeated experience had left him with a species of confidence about loss in general that he suspected few people who had never actually lost everything could fully share: not the confidence that loss would never come again, which would have been foolish given his own history, but the quieter, better-tested confidence that when it did come, he would still, somehow, on some rebuilt version of the same continuing terms, be able to carry on.

Chapter 30: The Woman Who Fixed the Tent

Somewhere in his fifties, in a country he placed only approximately among the later continuous decades, a sudden squall on an exposed stretch of coastline tore his tent's fly sheet clean along a seam he had patched twice already with the specific inadequate materials the road happened to offer him at the time, and he found himself, well after dark, soaked through and shivering in a way that his decades of practical experience recognized immediately as more dangerous than the storm itself, hypothermia being, he had long since learned, a considerably quieter and more patient killer than any of the more dramatic hazards that made better stories.

He knocked, without much hope given the hour and the weather, on the door of the nearest house he could make out through the rain, and was answered by a woman perhaps a decade older than himself who took one look at his shaking hands and his ruined tent, bundled under one arm in a doomed attempt to salvage it, and simply pulled him inside without a single question about who he was or where he had come from, the specific unhesitating competence of someone who had clearly made this exact judgment call before and saw no reason to slow down for formalities while a stranger's core temperature was visibly dropping in her doorway.

She fed him, dried his clothes by her own fire, and then, once he was warm enough to speak in full sentences again, took the ruined tent from him without asking and set to repairing it herself, at her

own kitchen table, with a sewing kit clearly built for heavier work than dresses or curtains, palming a sailmaker's needle through the ripstop fabric with the specific brisk competence of someone who had grown up, he gathered from the fragments of conversation they managed across a considerable language gap, mending fishing nets and sails for a family boat before she had ever mended anything so comparatively simple as a tent. She refused, firmly, his attempt to pay her for either the meal or the repair, in the same specific manner he had encountered so many times before across so many countries, and he had learned, by his fifties, not to press the point past a single respectful offer.

What stayed with him about that night, retold to the museum committee decades later with a fondness that surprised even him, was not the storm or the danger, both by then thoroughly familiar categories of experience he had weathered dozens of times before in one form or another, but the specific, wordless competence of the repair itself — the woman's hands moving across the torn fabric with the same unhurried, exact confidence he recognized in his own hands truing a wheel, a fellow craftsperson's respect passing between two strangers who shared no language beyond the universal one of a job done correctly. He left the following morning with a tent stronger, in that one repaired seam, than it had been even new from the factory, and carried the memory of her specific, competent hands, more than almost any other single kindness from that particular decade, as proof of something he had come to believe with increasing conviction the longer he rode: that skill, offered freely and without ceremony by a stranger to a stranger, was its own complete language, requiring no translation at all to say everything that mattered.

Chapter 31: The Currency of Small Debts

He came to believe, across the accumulated decades, in a specific private theology that he never once described using that word, distrusting religious language on principle the same way he distrusted grand romantic language about adventure, but that functioned, in the actual daily conduct of his life, with something close to a religious consistency: the conviction that the world kept its own rough accounting of decency, not through any supernatural ledger he claimed to believe in literally, but through the plain, observable, statistically real tendency of kindness extended to eventually, somehow, find its way back around to the person who had extended it, though rarely from the direction or the person you might expect.

He had tested this conviction, over five decades, against a great deal of contrary evidence — the five thefts, the two beatings, the shot toe, the mob in Haiti — and had found, turning the whole ledger over in his mind across enough decades of data, that the conviction held up rather better than the contrary evidence alone might suggest, provided you were willing to widen the accounting beyond any single transaction and consider the fifty-year total instead. He had given, without expecting direct repayment, small kindnesses of his own across the decades wherever he found the opportunity — sharing his own limited food with an even more desperate traveller met once and never again, teaching a village boy a rudimentary bicycle repair that might, Stücker hoped without ever confirming it, have served

the boy usefully for years afterward, patiently explaining a piece of paperwork to a bewildered fellow foreigner at a border post neither of them fully understood. None of these small debts had ever been repaid to him directly, by the specific people who received them. But he had received, across the same fifty years, an even larger and more improbable volume of unearned kindness from an entirely different set of strangers who owed him nothing at all, and he came, eventually, to think of the whole system not as a ledger of individual debts at all but as something closer to a vast, slow, barely visible current that carried decency from wherever it was generated to wherever it happened to be needed next, with no guarantee that the giver and the receiver of any single kindness would ever personally meet.

He tried to explain this once, patiently, to a journalist who wanted a tidier and more quotable version of the idea, something closer to “what goes around comes around,” a phrase he specifically disliked for its implication of a personal, transactional cosmic bookkeeper tracking each individual’s account. What he actually believed, he corrected her, was considerably less mystical and, in its own way, considerably more useful as an actual operating principle: that a world containing enough people willing to extend uncompensated kindness to strangers would, in aggregate and over enough time, reliably support a traveller foolish and patient enough to depend on that kindness completely, not because the universe owed him anything personally, but because he had made, at twenty-two, the specific wager that human decency, taken in the whole rather than sampled at its worst single moment, was abundant enough to actually live on. It was, he said, less a faith than a hypothesis, tested daily for sixty-four years under conditions considerably more rigorous than any laboratory could provide, and he considered the hypothesis, at the very end of the experiment, thoroughly and repeatedly confirmed.

Chapter 32: Weather

He came, across five decades, to know weather the way other men know a trade, and he distinguished, carefully, between knowing weather and merely enduring it, a distinction most people who had not spent a working lifetime entirely outdoors tended to collapse into a single idea. Enduring weather was what a man did the first few years, gritting through a headwind or a downpour because he had no better strategy available yet. Knowing weather was what came after, decades of accumulated, specific, practical understanding: which clouds over which kind of terrain meant rain within the hour and which meant nothing at all, how the particular quality of light changed in the hour before a Saharan sandstorm, how humidity announced itself on the back of his own neck a full day before any visible sign of the coming wet season appeared on the horizon.

He learned to read wind the way a sailor reads it, though he had no boat and would have found the comparison faintly grandiose if anyone had offered it to him directly. A crosswind cost him less than people assumed and more than he was always willing to admit on a bad day; a headwind on a long flat stretch could turn a planned sixty kilometres into a grinding forty, and he learned, over the years, to simply accept the day's actual distance rather than fight the wind for the distance he had originally intended, a lesson that had taken him considerably longer to learn than it perhaps should have, given how directly it echoed the patience Africa had already, painfully, taught him about distance in general.

He came to think of the different climates of the earth less as scenery

and more as a series of distinct physical negotiations, each with its own rules he had to relearn on arrival even after decades of practice elsewhere. The dry heat of the Sahara demanded one kind of vigilance about water and shade; the wet heat of Southeast Asia demanded an entirely different vigilance, less about volume of water and more about the specific, patient management of gear that never fully dried, boots that grew a faint mildew smell he learned to simply live alongside rather than fight, socks he changed with a frequency that would have seemed excessive to his younger, European self. The Siberian cold he encountered on more than one crossing over the decades taught him yet a third discipline entirely, the specific mathematics of layering and the equally specific danger of sweating too much on a climb and then chilling, dangerously, on the descent that inevitably followed it, a mistake that had nearly cost him seriously, in an early Siberian winter decades before the theft that made that country's name synonymous, in most retellings of his life, with an entirely different kind of trouble.

He kept, in his private notebooks across the decades, a running, informal weather-log of sorts, not out of any scientific ambition but simply because the habit of recording useful things had never left him since the die-measurement discipline of his Hövelhof apprenticeship: which months, in which countries, offered the kindest riding conditions, which passes closed entirely in which seasons, which coastal roads turned genuinely dangerous in cyclone months and needed to be timed around carefully rather than simply ridden through on faith. This informal log became, over decades, one of the more genuinely useful things he could offer the rare other long-distance cyclist he crossed paths with heading the opposite direction — a scrap of real, hard-won, specific knowledge exchanged in a five-minute roadside conversation that might save the other rider weeks of trial and error he himself had already paid for, in sweat and bad decisions, years before.

He noticed, in his later decades, a change in some of the patterns he had spent a working lifetime learning — a wet season arriving a few weeks later than the villages along a given road remembered it arriving in their own grandparents' time, a mountain pass staying open later into a season that had, decades before, reliably closed it by a

certain date. He did not make grand pronouncements about this in interviews, distrusting, as ever, any framing that asked him to speak with more authority than his own specific, personal, non-scientific observation actually supported. But he mentioned it, when asked directly by the rare journalist curious enough to ask a genuinely original question rather than the same six questions he had answered a thousand times, as one of the quieter, less dramatic facts his fifty years on the road had actually taught him: that the earth itself, the specific physical medium his entire working life had been conducted upon, was not a fixed backdrop against which his own story had played out unchanged, but a thing that had been slowly, measurably shifting under him the entire time, in ways a man who stayed in one town his whole life would have had no particular occasion to notice, and that a man who crossed it six hundred thousand times over, on a bicycle, at exactly the pace required to actually feel a season change beneath his own wheels, was perhaps as well positioned as anyone alive to have noticed it happening.

Chapter 33: Night Riding

There is a particular texture to riding after dark that he came, across the decades, to treat with more respect than almost any other single hazard the road presented, having learned early and the hard way that the specific dangers of night riding were less dramatic than a bullet or a mob and, in their own quiet way, considerably more likely to actually kill him: a pothole invisible until the front wheel dropped into it, a vehicle without functioning headlights approaching from behind at a closing speed he had no way to judge in the dark, the specific disorientation of a road that curved differently than his tired memory of its daylight shape suggested it should.

He avoided night riding, as a rule, for most of the fifty years, building his days instead around the old discipline he had learned in Africa: ride at first light, rest through the worst of the heat, aim to be settled somewhere safe well before the sky went properly dark. But the rule had its exceptions, forced on him by circumstance rather than choice, and he came to know the specific character of these exceptions almost as intimately as he knew the character of the daylight road: a border that closed at a fixed hour and required a final push after dark to reach it in time, a town that turned out, on arrival, to offer no safe place to sleep and required him to press on through the night to the next one instead, a mechanical failure that cost him the daylight hours he had budgeted and left him no honest choice but to finish the day's distance in the dark or not finish it at all.

He developed, across these forced exceptions, a specific set of night-riding disciplines that he never saw written down anywhere and sus-

pected he had invented independently, the same way any experienced practitioner of a dangerous craft eventually arrives at similar solutions to similar problems regardless of whether they ever compare notes with anyone else who has solved them. He rode slower at night than any daylight caution would have required, understanding that speed itself was the enemy once visibility dropped below a certain threshold. He listened harder than he watched, having learned that his ears could often detect an approaching vehicle's engine before his eyes could distinguish its lights from the general darkness, especially on a curving road where headlights announced themselves late. He sang, sometimes, alone on a dark road, not for any particular pleasure in the sound of his own voice but because he had found, through trial, that the specific rhythm of a half-remembered song kept his own attention from drifting into the kind of hypnotic, dangerous half-sleep that a silent, monotonous dark road could otherwise induce in a tired rider's mind.

He was struck, more than once across the decades, by the specific beauty certain night rides offered that no daylight crossing of the same road ever could — a desert sky, far from any town's competing light, showing him more stars in a single glance than most people who had never left a city ever saw across an entire lifetime, a silence at 3 a.m. on an empty road so complete that his own breathing became, briefly, the loudest sound in his world, a specific and total solitude that he came to treasure even as he respected its dangers, understanding that the same darkness that could kill him carelessly handled was also, handled with the correct discipline, one of the rare genuine gifts his particular way of life afforded him and almost no one else's did.

He was asked, once, whether he had ever been more afraid at night than during any of the more famous daylight ordeals people wanted to ask him about, and he answered, honestly, that the fear was different in kind rather than in degree — the daylight dangers arrived from other people, and could at least sometimes be read in a face or a posture before they fully materialized, while the night dangers arrived from the road itself, indifferent, unreadable, offering no warning expression to study before the pothole or the blind curve simply presented itself. He came to respect the second kind of danger more, in some ways,

precisely because it could not be negotiated with, charmed, or outrun through any of the specific social skills fifty years on the road had taught him to rely on with other human beings, leaving him, in the dark, with only his own accumulated caution and whatever the road itself was willing to reveal to a rider patient and humble enough to go slowly.

Chapter 34: The Return

Nobody could tell him, afterward, exactly which morning it had been, and he could not tell them either, which struck more than one interviewer as strange for a man who had kept such careful count of everything else — the kilometres, the countries, the negatives, the thefts. But the end of the continuous phase of the journey did not arrive as a border crossing or a bicycle theft or a bullet; it arrived the way most real endings actually arrive, which is to say gradually, disguised for a long time as an ordinary visit, until one day the visit had quietly become the new arrangement without anyone, including the man living it, having consciously voted on the change at any single identifiable moment.

He was in his early seventies by the time Hövelhof stopped being a place he passed through and became, again, a place he was simply in — not because his legs had given out, though they were, by then, the legs of a man who had put more kilometres into pedals than most long-haul truckers put into diesel across an entire career, and not because the road itself had exhausted its supply of new experience, since a man who had ridden through the same countries five and six times over half a century knew perfectly well that the road never actually ran dry, only that the traveller's own need for it changed shape with the decades. He came back, in the broad shorthand the family and neighbours around him eventually settled on, because the village had begun to build him a museum, and because a museum needs someone alive and present to argue with it about what actually belongs in the cases.

He found Hövelhof both entirely familiar and entirely strange, in the

specific way that only a place you left as a young man and returned to as an old one can be — the Sennelager pines still black-green under the same lidded November sky, the same flat grey ceiling sitting two metres above the rooftops that he had measured every horizon on earth against for fifty years, and beneath that unchanged sky an almost entirely different town: new houses where the shop had once stood, faces he did not recognize behind the counters of shops that had once belonged to families he'd grown up two doors from, the specific vertigo of discovering that a place can hold perfectly still in your own memory for five decades while holding still not at all in fact. He was, by his own late, wry admission, more of a stranger in Hövelhof in his seventies than he had ever been in most of the villages of Zambia or Java in his thirties, because a stranger arriving in rural Zambia expects to be a stranger and arrives prepared for it, and a man returning to his own hometown, on some level, never quite does.

He did not stop riding. That distinction mattered to him more than almost any other he made in the later interviews, correcting more than one journalist who wrote, carelessly, that he had “retired” or “come home to settle down,” phrases he rejected with more heat than he showed about almost anything else in his life by that point, because they implied an ending that had not, in his own accounting, actually occurred at all. What had ended was the continuous phase — the fifty years in which he did not have, in any meaningful sense, a fixed address, in which every letter reached him general delivery three months behind schedule at a post office he had merely guessed he might pass. What replaced it was something closer to a long, satisfied middle distance: rides out from Hövelhof and back, weeks rather than years, the bicycle still doing the only job it had ever known how to do, the man on it simply choosing, for the first time in half a century, to have a fixed point the rides departed from and returned to, rather than letting each departure also be, in effect, a fresh disappearance with no promised end date attached to it.

He worked with the museum committee with the same practical, unglamorous attention he had once brought to truing a wheel by spoke key and eye — sorting negatives from an archive of over a hundred thousand photographs, deciding which postcards told

a story worth telling to a visitor and which were simply inventory, correcting, patiently and more than once, a well-meaning volunteer's assumption about which decade a particular photograph belonged to, because the decades, to everyone but him, had started to blur together into a single generalized "abroad," and he was, by then, the only person alive who could still put each image back into its correct year, its correct border, its correct weather and light. He found the work slower than he expected and, to his own mild surprise, more satisfying than he had guessed it would be — a different kind of patience than the road had ever asked of him, the patience of archiving rather than accumulating, of looking backward on purpose after half a century of training himself, quite deliberately, never to.

He gave interviews, more of them now than he ever had while on the road, because a man who has stopped moving continuously becomes, paradoxically, easier to find than a man who has spent fifty years being a moving target, and journalists who had heard the outline of his story for decades without ever managing to catch up with him in person could now simply write ahead to Hövelhof and be reasonably confident of an answer arriving within the month. He was patient with most of them, brusque with a few who wanted the story flattened into a single tidy moral — freedom, wanderlust, running from something, running toward something — and he resisted, gently but consistently, every attempt to make his fifty years into a parable rather than a life, insisting, again and again, in slightly different words each time depending on the asker, that he had simply liked riding a bicycle and had kept doing it for considerably longer than anyone had expected him to, and that the meaning, if there was one to be had at all, was for other people to find in the finding of it themselves, not for him to hand them ready-made across a kitchen table.

He rode, in his seventies and into his eighties, shorter distances at a gentler pace, the bicycle under him now carrying, quite literally, welds and repaints and re-spokings from four different decades and at least four different countries' worth of roadside mechanics, a machine that had, by any honest reckoning, replaced nearly every one of its original parts at least once over and remained, in every sense he considered to actually matter, the same bicycle that had carried him out of Hövelhof

on a frosted November morning when he was twenty-two years old and owned nothing beyond forty marks in a tobacco tin and a conviction he could not yet, at the time, have put into words for anyone who asked. He put his hand on the saddle some mornings, before riding out, the way he had once put his hand on it recovering from dysentery in a Javanese clinic yard, and found that the gesture still meant, after everything, exactly what it had meant then: not sentiment, not romance, simply the plain mechanical fact of a partnership that had outlasted every human relationship he had ever had except the small handful, increasingly few now, that had also somehow managed to outlast the road itself.

Chapter 35: Coming Back Properly

The promise he had made himself on that Seychelles harbour wall — that he would come back, over the years that followed 1996, and fill in properly what a first fast pass at “every country” had necessarily skipped — turned out to be considerably harder to keep than the original ambition had been, for a reason he had not fully anticipated at the time: a first visit to a country, driven by the specific urgency of the list, had a natural shape and a natural momentum, arrive, register the visit, move on toward the next unclaimed border. A return visit, made for no reason beyond his own private sense of unfinished business, had no such built-in momentum, and he found himself, more than once in the following decade and a half, having to talk himself into a specific detour that the younger, list-driven version of himself would simply have made without a second thought.

He went back to stretches of the subcontinent he had ridden through at speed in his twenties, this time slowly, deliberately, allowing himself the kind of extended stay in a single region that the original circumnavigation’s own logic had never permitted. He went back to corners of West Africa where the political situation had, by his second visit, changed almost beyond recognition from the country he remembered from his thirties, new governments, new currencies, sometimes new borders entirely redrawn around conflicts that had reshaped the map since his first passage through. He found this disorienting in a way that surprised him — he had expected, going in, that revisiting a

place would feel like meeting an old friend, and found instead, more than once, that it felt closer to meeting a stranger who happened to be wearing an old friend's face, the underlying land recognizable, the human arrangements built on top of it changed almost entirely.

He went back, too, to specific people rather than merely specific places wherever his correspondence network had kept a thread alive long enough to make it possible — the Austrian shopkeeper's family, decades removed from the original transaction that had started the whole postcard economy, still running some version of the same shop; a Syrian household, when circumstances still permitted the visit, whose grandchildren had grown up hearing about the German cyclist their grandmother had once nursed through heatstroke and who greeted him, on his return, with a warmth that startled him, given that he himself had only the vaguest memory of the specific afternoon that had apparently become, on their side of the story, a piece of family legend told and retold for decades. He found these reunions considerably more moving than he had expected, and was candid, late in life, about the specific and disorienting asymmetry of them: that he had lived the fifty years as a single continuous present tense, one border after another, rarely pausing to consider how any single encounter might be remembered on the other end of it, and that arriving, decades later, to discover that a single afternoon's kindness had been preserved, treasured, and handed down through an entire family in his absence, taught him something about the actual weight of his own passing-through that he had never fully appreciated while he was still simply riding past, on to the next town, without looking back.

He did not manage to revisit everywhere he had hoped to. Some countries had become, by the time he had the leisure to consider a return, too dangerous or too politically closed to make the visit practical; some correspondences had simply gone quiet over the decades, an address that no longer answered, a family that had moved on without leaving a forwarding trace, the specific quiet erosion that time works on even the most carefully kept ledger of names. He accepted these gaps, in his final years, the way he had accepted most of the road's other losses — without excessive grief, but without pretending, either,

that the gaps did not represent something genuinely missed, a debt of gratitude he had intended, honestly, to repay in person and simply run out of decades to fully discharge. He said, once, to the museum committee, turning over a stack of unanswered later letters from an address that had gone silent sometime in the 1990s, that this was perhaps the one true regret his fifty years had left him with — not the beatings, not the thefts, not the toe or the ringing ear, all of which he had made his peace with decades before, but simply the ordinary, unglamorous fact that a man cannot, in the end, return properly to everyone who once fed him, however good his intentions, and that some kindnesses, however gratefully received at the time, are destined to go forever unrepaid in the specific, personal way he would have preferred to repay them.

Chapter 36: The Bakery on Thursdays

He kept, in his final decades in Hövelhof, a small routine that the town came to know him by as reliably as it knew him by the museum's rising walls: bread from the same bakery every Thursday morning, purchased in person, on foot rather than by bicycle for this one specific errand, a concession to the plain fact that a loaf of bread did not require six hundred thousand kilometres of travel to reach his kitchen table. The baker's family had run the shop for two generations by the time he settled back into anything resembling a Hövelhof routine, the current owner a woman in her forties who had grown up hearing about the German cyclist the way children in that town grew up hearing about any local fixture too large and too strange to fully explain to visitors — not quite a legend, not quite an ordinary neighbour, something in between that the town itself had never bothered to properly define because it had never needed to.

She asked him, the first several Thursdays after his return became a settled habit rather than a novelty, the same question everyone eventually asked, though she asked it, he noted with private approval, more directly and with less performed awe than most: what had actually been the point of it all, fifty years, all those countries, when a person could, after all, simply live an ordinary life and be reasonably content. He gave her, across several Thursdays and several partial answers, something closer to an honest response than he gave most journalists, perhaps because a bakery counter, unlike a microphone, asked

for no quotable line and permitted a slower, more halting kind of truth-telling. He told her about the freewheel's tick on a downhill with no one behind him for days at a stretch. He told her, another week, about the specific and total presence of attention a hard climb demanded, leaving no room in his skull for anything but the next metre of road, a kind of forced, total mindfulness he had practiced decades before anyone in Hövelhof had ever heard the word used to describe anything. He told her, on a Thursday nearer the end, about the boy at the river crossing whose name he never learned, and watched her face do the specific thing faces did when he offered that particular story instead of the shooting or the theft — a quieter, more genuine attention than the bigger stories usually produced, as though she had been waiting, without knowing it, for exactly this smaller and truer kind of answer all along.

He became, over these later years, a specific and comfortable fixture of the town's ordinary rhythm in a way the fifty years of legend-building had somehow never quite achieved on their own — not the man who had ridden around the world, in the town's daily experience of him, so much as simply Heinz, who bought bread on Thursdays, who could be relied upon to answer a child's question about the pictures in the half-built museum with more patience than most adults managed for anything, who had opinions about the roofing contractor's timeline that he was not shy about sharing at the hardware store. The schoolteacher brought her class to the construction site more than once in those years, and he made a point, each time, of speaking to the children directly rather than performing for the accompanying adults, answering their specific, unfiltered questions — did the bees really hurt, was he scared of the man who shot him, did he ever get to ride a lion — with the same plain honesty he gave everyone, adjusted only for the fact that children, he found, asked considerably better and more interesting questions than most adults managed, unburdened as they were by any need to make the question sound sophisticated.

He came to value this ordinary, granular texture of his final years — the bakery, the schoolchildren, the hardware store opinions about roofing contractors — more than he had expected to, given how thoroughly the previous five decades had trained him to associate a settled routine

with the specific danger of the two hundred and eleven identical steel components that had once driven him out of this exact town. He understood, by his eighties, that the two things were not actually the same, that the young man's fear had been of a life with no genuine variation left in it at all, and that the old man's routine, by contrast, was built on a foundation so thoroughly varied — fifty years, six hundred thousand kilometres, a hundred and ninety-five countries already behind him — that a fixed Thursday loaf of bread could no longer threaten to flatten him the way an identical Monday at the die shop once had. The sameness, at the end, was not a cage. It was, he said once to the baker, smiling in the dry way she had come to recognize as his highest register of genuine warmth, simply a well-earned rest, and a man who had ridden as far as he had was entitled, he thought, to a specific and unhurried Thursday loaf of bread without anyone mistaking it for the surrender it plainly was not.

Chapter 37: The Frame

The bicycle that stood in the hallway in Hövelhof in the last weeks of his life was not, in any strict material sense, the bicycle he had ridden out of that same town in November 1962, and he was the first to say so, cheerfully, to any visitor who asked, because the distinction interested him more than the sentiment most people wanted to attach to it. Steel fatigues. Steel cracks, eventually, at the welds that take the worst of a loaded frame's flex over enough thousands of kilometres, and a man who rides for fifty years and never once has his frame rewelded is a man who has not, in fact, been riding it very hard or very far. He had the frame rewelded for the first time in Kenya, in a workshop no larger than a single stall, by a welder who worked from a car battery and a torch and who had never seen a Rabeneick before in his life and did not need to, because a crack in a steel tube is the same problem in Nairobi as it is in Hövelhof, and a competent welder solves the same problem the same way regardless of the manufacturer's badge on the head tube.

He had it rewelded again, differently, in India, at a joint that had begun to weep hairline fractures under the load of the rear rack, the local mechanic laughing, not unkindly, at the sheer quantity of gear Stücke expected one frame to carry indefinitely, and suggesting, with the frank professional confidence of a man who had fixed a great many overloaded bicycles in his working life, that Stücke either carry less or accept that he would be back in this shop again within the year. Stücke did not carry less. He was back within the year, in a different shop, in a different country, having the same conversation in a different language with a different mechanic who offered the same frank advice

and received the same polite refusal to act on it.

The paint had been redone so many times, in so many countries, by so many hands, that no single coat of it, by the end, could honestly be said to be original — a fact he found, rather than distressing, quietly satisfying, because it meant the bicycle's surface told an accurate story about its own life even where the steel beneath it could not: a patch of blue from a shop in Thailand where black paint was not available that week and Stücke, needing the exposed metal covered before it rusted through in the humidity, had simply accepted whatever colour the shop actually stocked; a patch of green from somewhere in Latin America he could no longer place with confidence; the black reasserting itself, eventually, wherever he found a shop that carried it and had the time to do the job properly, so that the bicycle in its later decades carried, under close inspection, a faint and unintentional map of where paint had and had not been available on a given afternoon, a map only he could fully read and that told a more honest story of the actual journey than any single consistent colour scheme ever could have.

The wheels he re-spoked more times than he ever properly counted, the specific art of truing a wheel by eye and by ear — the note a spoke makes when plucked, tightened correctly, differs subtly from the note it makes tightened wrong, and he had learned, over decades, to hear the difference the way a piano tuner hears a fifth slightly out of true — becoming, by his sixties, as automatic to him as breathing, a skill so deeply installed that he sometimes found himself, sitting still in an ordinary chair decades later, unconsciously miming the motion of a spoke key between his fingers whenever his mind wandered somewhere else entirely. The saddle he replaced three times outright, unable to reweld or patch a saddle the way he could reweld a frame, and grieved, mildly and privately, each replacement, because a broken-in saddle is a genuinely personal object, shaped over years by a single body's specific weight and posture, and a new one, however well made, cost him a month or more of discomfort before it forgot, in its own leather way, that it had ever belonged to anyone else.

He was asked, more than once in his later years, by journalists who found the question irresistible, whether the bicycle in the Hövelhof

hallway was truly, in any meaningful sense, “the same bicycle” he had left on in 1962, given how completely its material had been replaced across six decades — the philosopher’s old riddle of the ship whose every plank is eventually swapped, dressed up in steel and rubber instead of timber. He had a ready answer for this one, unlike so many of the grander questions he deflected or shrugged past, because he had turned this particular puzzle over often enough in the quiet hours of a long ride to have actually settled it to his own satisfaction. The bicycle was the same bicycle, he would say, for exactly the same reason he was the same man despite the fact that almost none of the actual cells that had left Hövelhof in 1962 were still, biologically, present in the body sitting across the table from the journalist asking the question. Continuity was not a claim about matter. It was a claim about care — about the unbroken, decades-long attention of a single person choosing, each time something broke, to fix rather than replace, to reweld rather than buy new, to carry the same frame’s history forward into the next repair rather than starting over with a bicycle that owed nothing to the road already ridden. The steel changed. The tending did not. That, he said, more than once, in more or less the same words each time because he had found, by then, the words that actually fit the thought, was the whole of what “the same bicycle” had ever meant, and the whole of what he suspected “the same man” meant too, if anyone cared to look at it as closely as he had been forced, by circumstance, to look at his own frame.

Chapter 38: The Postcard as an Art Form

He came, across five decades of making them, to think of the postcard as a genuinely distinct discipline from photography in general, with its own rules and its own quiet demands, and he was faintly amused, in later interviews, whenever someone described his life's work in terms of grand photographic achievement rather than the specific, humbler craft he had actually practiced day after day for fifty years: the making of a small, cheap, mass-producible object that a stranger would want to send to another stranger, across a distance, as a way of saying, in the universal shorthand of tourism, I was here, and I thought of you.

The discipline, as he came to understand it, lay entirely in restraint. A postcard could not afford the luxury of ambiguity that a fine art photograph might indulge; it had to communicate its subject instantly, legibly, at a size smaller than a man's outstretched hand, to a buyer standing at a rack in a hurry between other errands. He learned, through years of trial and the specific harsh feedback of a shopkeeper's till — did this image sell, or did it sit unsold on the rack for months — which compositional choices actually served that instant legibility and which merely pleased his own private eye without serving the buyer's practical need: a single clear subject, well lit, framed to leave an obvious space where a message could later be imagined written on the reverse, a mood immediately readable even to someone who had never visited the place and might never visit it, glancing at the card only long enough to decide whether it was worth the coin.

He resisted, across the decades, the specific temptation to make his postcards more artful than their function required, understanding that a photograph too clever, too ambiguous, too obviously reaching for a gallery wall rather than a coach tourist's coin, simply failed at the actual job he needed it to do. This restraint, he came to believe in his later years, taught him something about clarity that he suspected very few full-time artists ever had cause to learn as thoroughly, because very few full-time artists worked under quite so unforgiving and immediate a market discipline: if the image did not sell, he did not eat that week, a feedback loop considerably more honest, in its own blunt way, than the more forgiving economics of gallery photography, where a work's failure to sell could be blamed on fickle taste or an inattentive market rather than on any flaw in the image itself.

He kept, nonetheless, a private appreciation for the images that broke his own commercial rules and that he made anyway, for himself, understanding they would likely never sell — the coastline whose subtle colour shift he could never quite capture, the grandmother's hands working dough, the boy at the river crossing whose face he photographed once, quickly, before they parted, an image he never printed for sale and kept, instead, in the smaller private stack he returned to most often in his final years. He came to think of these two categories of image — the postcards that fed him and the private photographs that simply moved him — not as being in tension with each other but as two honest halves of the same lifelong practice, the commercial discipline keeping him fed and moving, the private practice keeping him, in some harder-to-name way, actually paying attention to the life he was supposedly documenting rather than merely harvesting it for coin.

He was asked once, by an actual gallery, late in his life, whether he would consider an exhibition of the private stack, framed and priced for a different kind of buyer than the roadside tourists who had sustained him for five decades. He considered the offer seriously, turning it over for the better part of a month, and declined it in the end, not out of any false modesty but out of a genuine, considered judgment that the private photographs' value to him lay precisely in their having never been made for sale, and that framing them now, pricing them for

a gallery wall, would retroactively convert them into exactly the kind of object he had spent fifty years carefully keeping them separate from. He offered the gallery the museum instead, suggesting they simply visit Hövelhof when the building was finished, and told the story, afterward, to the committee with the specific dry amusement of a man who had turned down, in his eighties, an offer that might once, in a leaner year decades before, have solved several months of his own financial arithmetic at a single stroke, and who did not regret the refusal for a single moment of the considering that followed it.

Chapter 39: The Man Who Wanted to See It All

The film crew arrived in Hövelhof the way film crews arrive everywhere, with more equipment than the subject's actual life required and a schedule that assumed his story could be told in the number of days their budget allowed, and he was, by his own later account to the museum committee, more amused than irritated by the mismatch, because a man who had spent fifty years learning to fit an entire life's arithmetic into whatever a border guard would give him — five minutes, an hour, sometimes an entire uncomfortable night in a cell — was not going to be seriously troubled by a documentary crew's scheduling anxieties over a few missed days of good light.

He was in his early eighties by the time the cameras followed him properly, out along the roads near Hövelhof first and then, for a handful of sequences, back to a few of the countries whose names had organized so much of his life — not all one hundred and ninety-five, which not even a documentary's budget could accommodate, but enough of the ones that had mattered most to let the camera see, in his own weathered face against those specific landscapes, what fifty years does to a man who chose to spend nearly all of them entirely outdoors. He watched the director frame him against roads and river crossings he had once ridden at speed, out of pure necessity, weather or border or hunger pressing him onward without pause, and found it strange and not entirely unpleasant to be asked, this time, simply to stand still in front of them and let the camera do what he had spent his whole

working life doing himself, with his own borrowed and then bought and then borrowed-again cameras: hold a place still long enough to be looked at properly by someone who had never been there.

He gave the crew his honesty in the same flat, unglamorous portions he gave everyone by then. He did not perform wonder for them, though wonder was, in its way, the film's whole ostensible subject — the title itself, *The Man Who Wanted to See It All*, a phrase he had not chosen and did not entirely recognize as an accurate description of his own original motives, though he did not fight the director on it either, understanding by then that a documentary needs a frame the way a bicycle needs a frame, and that the frame is not strictly obligated to be the same exact shape as the thing it is built to carry. He corrected the director, gently, more than once, on points of fact — a date misremembered from a secondary source, a country's name given in its current form when the events being described had actually happened under a different one entirely, decades before the border had been redrawn — and was pleased, afterward, that most of his corrections made it into the final cut, because he had come to care, in his old age, considerably less about being flattered by the record and considerably more, simply, about the record being accurate, a preference that had, if he was honest with himself, been latent in him since the two-fingered typing of his own 1995 memoir and had only sharpened, rather than softened, with the passing years.

He did not, in the film or afterward, claim to have wanted to see it all in quite the sense the title implied — a completist's hunger, ticking boxes, collecting flags for their own sake. What he told the camera, in a sentence the editors kept nearly whole because it needed almost no polishing at all, was closer to the plain truth he had arrived at on that harbour wall in the Seychelles a quarter-century before: that the list of countries had been the excuse and the road itself had been the reason, and that he had simply never found a convincing argument, in fifty years of looking rather hard for one, for why the road should stop being the reason before his own body did.

The museum, meanwhile, rose slowly around him — a modest building for a modest town, funded by the kind of patient local fundraising that

took years rather than a single grand gesture from a single wealthy patron, its construction schedule as unglamorous and as real as everything else in his working life had ever been, scaffolding and delays and a roofing contractor who fell noticeably behind through one entire wet spring. He visited the site often in those years, in the flat cap and worn jacket that photographs of his old age show him in more often than not, standing in the mud among half-built walls that would eventually hold negatives he had once carried, uncounted and largely unprotected, through checkpoints and river crossings and one very bad night in Siberia, and found the whole slow process of the building's rising a fitting last labour for a life that had never once, across fifty years, rewarded haste of any kind. He joked, once, to a local reporter, that the museum was taking rather longer to complete than several of the wars he had personally ridden through, and meant it as the dry, undersold humour that had always been his only reliable register for anything that threatened, in the telling, to become too solemn for its own good.

He grew, in these years, into the specific role that villages sometimes make for a man who left and came back having done something no one else from that village had ever done or would: not quite celebrity, not quite elder statesman, something closer to a living local landmark, pointed out to visiting schoolchildren the way you might point out an old church or an unusually large and well-known tree — this one is ours, he did something genuinely remarkable, and he still buys his bread at the same bakery every Thursday morning like anyone else. He seemed, by every account of people who knew him in those years, entirely comfortable in the role, neither performing a false modesty about it nor inflating it into something grander than it actually was, simply occupying it the way he had occupied every other stage of his own long life: plainly, without excessive commentary, letting the neighbours and the schoolchildren and eventually the documentary's audience draw whatever conclusions they individually wanted from a life he had never fully explained even to himself and had, by his eighties, entirely stopped trying to.

He watched the finished film once, in a small cinema in Paderborn with the museum committee and a handful of neighbours, and said

afterward, when asked for his verdict by a local reporter angling for a memorable quote, only that it was mostly accurate, which he intended and which everyone who knew him well understood to be, from this particular man, close to the highest praise he was constitutionally capable of giving anything. He did not attend the larger festival screenings that followed, in cities he had once ridden through at speed and had no particular urge, at eighty-one, to fly back to for an evening of being applauded. He preferred, he said, the version of himself that stayed home and let the film travel on his behalf, the same arrangement, in its way, that the photographs and the postcards had always made on his behalf for six full decades: send the image out into the world to do the travelling, and let the man himself, for once, simply stay where he was.

Chapter 40: The Documentary Crew's Last Question

The director, on the final day of filming in Hövelhof, asked him the question every crew eventually asked, the one Stücker had come to think of as the inevitable closing note of any interview long enough to earn it: what would he say, if he could say one thing, to the twenty-two-year-old who had ridden out of this exact town sixty years before with forty marks in a tobacco tin and no plan beyond Cologne.

He considered the question longer than he considered most, the camera running, the crew waiting with the specific patient stillness of people who had learned, over the preceding weeks, that his best answers arrived slowly and were worth the wait. He said, eventually, that he was not sure the young man in question would have listened to any advice at all, being, by Stücker's own honest recollection, considerably more stubborn and considerably more frightened than his own later reputation for calm competence suggested, and that giving advice to a version of himself who could not, in any case, actually receive it across sixty years felt to him like a slightly dishonest exercise, however often documentaries and journalists alike seemed to want him to attempt it.

What he offered instead, when the director pressed gently for something more usable, was not advice so much as a single observation, delivered in the same flat, unhurried register he used for everything

else: that the young man in the Hövelhof yard that November morning had believed, or half believed, that he was leaving toward something — adventure, freedom, the wide world the atlas had promised him — and had not understood, could not have understood, that the actual discovery waiting for him on the road was not about the world at all, in the end, but about people. Not the mountains, not the deserts, not the specific colour of an unnamed coastline he could still, sixty years later, close his eyes and see. The people. The woman with the water bottle in Java. The boy at the river crossing. The nurse who spoon-fed a grown man his own water without once making him feel the burden he knew himself to be. The freedom fighters whose shot he never fully understood and the soldier who held water to his beaten mouth afterward without meeting his eyes. He said that if the young man in the yard could have been told, truly and usefully, what the fifty years actually held, it would not have been a warning about the bullet or the theft or the dysentery, all of which the young man would have faced regardless, forewarned or not, but a simple reassurance about the specific, overwhelming, and entirely unearned generosity of strangers across every one of the hundred and ninety-five countries he was about to ride through, a generosity so consistent, decade after decade, continent after continent, that it had become, in the end, the actual subject of the whole undertaking, however much the postcards and the record books and the newspaper articles insisted on making the subject the kilometres instead.

He said this without much emotion in his voice, in the same register he used to discuss gear ratios or customs paperwork, and the director, watching the footage afterward with the editing team, apparently argued for keeping the passage nearly verbatim in the final cut precisely because of that flatness, understanding, correctly, that an old man saying something this large in a voice this plain carried more weight than the same words delivered with any more obvious performance of feeling ever could have. Stücker, watching the finished film months later in the small Paderborn cinema, said only, when asked for his verdict on this particular passage, that it was accurate, which was, from this specific man, in this specific and considered use of the word, very close to the highest thing he was capable of saying about

anything.

Chapter 41: What Goes in the Case

The museum committee's arguments, in the years before the building was finished, were rarely about money, which the patient fundraising had mostly resolved by the time the walls were actually rising, and almost always about selection — which of a hundred thousand photographs, which handful of objects out of a fifty-year accumulation, could possibly stand in for the whole of it to a visitor who would spend, on average, the committee's own informal survey suggested, perhaps twenty-five minutes in the building before moving on to whatever the rest of their day required.

Stücke found himself, in these arguments, an unexpectedly useful voice precisely because he refused, consistently, to advocate for the objects that made the best story. A volunteer proposed, early in the planning, a large central display built around the Zambia shooting — the boot, preserved, if it could even still be located after so many decades, or failing that a reconstruction, alongside a dramatic wall text about the freedom fighters and the toe's permanent stiffness. Stücke resisted this proposal with more energy than he brought to almost any other committee discussion, arguing, patiently and then less patiently as the debate wore on, that a museum built around its single most dramatic anecdote taught a visitor exactly the wrong lesson about what the fifty years had actually been, the same distortion he had spent decades correcting in journalists who wanted the shooting to be the whole story rather than five unrepresentative minutes

out of eighteen thousand days.

He proposed instead, and eventually won, a central case built around something considerably less dramatic and, in his own estimation, considerably more honest: the ledger itself, the tolerance- obsessed handwritten record of print sales and correspondence addresses that had actually organized the practical substance of his fifty years far more thoroughly than any single violent afternoon ever had, displayed open to a page chosen not for any particular drama but simply because it happened to be legible and representative, an ordinary page from an ordinary year, the ink faded evenly, the handwriting as neat in its middle entries as in its first. Beside it, at his insistence, went not the boot but a section of bicycle frame, cut from an earlier reweld and kept, unexplained until then, in a box in his own possession for exactly this eventual purpose, the metal itself showing, in cross-section, the visible seam of an old weld laid over an older crack, a small, unglamorous object that told, to anyone willing to look closely enough, a more complete story about persistence than any dramatic anecdote could have managed on its own.

He allowed the shooting its own case, eventually, once the ledger and the frame section had secured their central place — a compromise he considered entirely fair, understanding that a museum had to serve visitors who wanted the dramatic story as well as visitors patient enough to appreciate the quieter one, and that a building which offered nothing at all to the first kind of visitor would simply fail at its basic practical purpose of drawing anyone through the door in the first place. But he insisted, in that case's accompanying text, on a specific framing the committee agreed to only after some debate: not "the day he was shot," presented as a singular, defining ordeal, but "one afternoon among eighteen thousand," a phrasing he had wrestled the committee's original draft into over several difficult meetings, understanding that the exact words mattered enormously to how a twelve-year-old schoolchild, reading the case in passing on a class trip, would come to understand the actual shape and proportion of the life the whole building was meant to represent.

He did not live to see the museum fully open to the public, the final

months of construction still underway in the last spring of his life, the roofing contractor's long-delayed work finally, at last, complete. He had seen enough of it, by then, walking through the half-finished galleries with the committee in his final year, cases mostly filled, wall texts mostly settled, to know that the argument over the ledger and the frame section had been won, and to say so, once, with the specific dry satisfaction of a man who had spent fifty years winning smaller, quieter arguments against the more dramatic version of his own story that other people kept wanting to tell on his behalf, and who had, in this one final institutional argument, managed to make the truer version stick.

Chapter 42: The Visitors' Book

The half-finished museum kept, from its earliest days of limited pre-opening tours for local school groups and the occasional curious journalist, a visitors' book at the entrance, an ordinary bound ledger that Stücke insisted on personally, over a committee suggestion that a digital guestbook might serve the institution's modern image more effectively, and he won this particular small argument the way he had won the argument over the ledger in the central display case: by simply refusing, calmly and repeatedly, to let the point go until the committee tired of debating it and conceded.

He read the visitors' book himself, most weeks, in the last years of his life, sitting on the same folding stool he had occupied to watch his final reweld in Paderborn, working through the accumulated entries with the same patient, unhurried attention he had once given a stack of unsold postcards, sorting the merely polite ("very interesting, thank you") from the entries that actually told him something he had not already known about his own reception in the world. Children's entries pleased him most, he admitted to the committee more than once, precisely because children had not yet learned the adult habit of writing what an occasion seemed to require rather than what they actually thought — a ten-year-old's simple, unadorned "I want to do this too" moved him considerably more, he said, than any of the more articulate praise adult visitors sometimes left, because the child's entry contained no performance in it at all, only the plain, direct transmis-

sion of an idea catching in a new mind exactly the way it must have caught, six decades before, in his own.

He found, reading through the book across those final years, a specific and recurring category of entry that surprised him at first and that he came, eventually, to consider one of the more valuable unintended functions the whole museum project had ended up serving: messages, sometimes quite lengthy, from visitors who had lost someone themselves — a parent, a spouse, occasionally a child — and who found, in the specific record of a man who had spent fifty years risking everything and somehow, against considerable odds, kept coming home, some private comfort or private challenge they did not always fully articulate but that clearly mattered enough to them to write down in a stranger's guestbook rather than simply carry silently back out through the door. He did not always know what to do with these entries, admitting once to the committee that he had never set out, across fifty years on a bicycle, to become anyone's source of comfort about mortality, having been, if anything, considerably more preoccupied across those decades with the specific mechanics of staying alive than with any larger meditation on death. But he read every one of these entries carefully, and more than once, in his final year, asked a committee member to help him draft a short personal reply to a visitor who had left an address, understanding, by then, that the correspondence network which had sustained his entire working life for five decades had, without his particular planning it, simply found one more channel through which to keep doing the same essential work: connecting a stranger's specific loneliness to another stranger's specific, hard-won evidence that the world, taken as a whole across enough decades and enough countries, gave back more than it took.

He did not live to see the visitors' book fill its final pages, the building itself still weeks from its full public opening when his own final illness overtook the routine that had structured his last years so completely. The committee kept the book going after his death exactly as he had always kept it himself, understanding, without needing to discuss the decision at any length, that a museum built around one man's insistence on plain, honest, unglamorous record-keeping owed its own continuing existence to precisely that same discipline, carried

forward now by other hands, in the same bound ledger, in the same entrance hall, beside the same bicycle that no longer needed to go anywhere at all but that would, the committee decided without much debate, remain exactly where he had last left it, for as long as anyone continued to walk through that door and want to understand what one ordinary, stubborn, extraordinarily patient man had actually done with the sixty-four years that followed a frosted November morning in 1962.

Chapter 43: The Interview That Went Long

The biographer arrived in Hövelhof expecting an afternoon and stayed, in the end, the better part of a week, a fact that surprised them both in roughly equal measure, given that Stücke had built, across five decades of fielding journalists at borders and in guesthouses, a well-practiced set of compact, efficient answers designed specifically to satisfy a reporter's deadline without requiring either party to spend more time on the exercise than the story genuinely warranted.

What made this particular visit different, Stücke reflected afterward, was less anything the biographer did than the specific season of his own life in which the visit happened to land — his mid-seventies by then, the museum's early planning underway, his own private archive already half-sorted into the categories that would eventually fill the display cases, so that for perhaps the first time in his entire adult life he found himself with something he had almost never previously possessed on the road: unhurried, unscheduled time, and a visitor patient enough to actually use it properly rather than racing toward a single usable quote.

They sat for hours at a time across that week, in his kitchen, on the same folding stool he would later use to watch his final reweld, on a bench near the museum's rising walls, and Stücke found himself, somewhere around the third day, saying things aloud that he had never said to any of the hundreds of journalists who had interviewed him across the preceding decades — not because he had been hiding any-

thing, exactly, but because no one had previously stayed long enough, or asked patiently enough, to get past the compact, well-rehearsed version of his own story that fifty years of practice had honed into something close to a fixed script. He talked about the guesthouse widow along the coastal road, a story he had never given any journalist before this one. He talked, at length and with visible difficulty, about the specific shame of the dysentery in Java, the part about losing control of his own body that he had always flattened, in every previous telling, into the single word “illness.” He talked about his mother’s tin of kept letters, and stopped, partway through the account, for long enough that the biographer, listening back to the recording afterward, noted in the margin that this was the only silence of the entire week’s conversation that had lasted more than a few seconds.

He was asked, near the end of that week, why he was telling this particular stranger things he had apparently never told anyone else across five decades of being asked, and he considered the question with the same unhurried care he gave every question that deserved it, and answered, in the end, that he suspected it was simply arithmetic again, the same practical calculation that had governed most of his important decisions across his whole life: he was in his mid-seventies, the biographer was patient and evidently competent, and the actual record of his life — not the compact version, but the fuller one — was going to need, eventually, someone willing to write it all down properly, in a form more durable than a newspaper’s next-day pulp, and he had simply decided, sitting with this particular stranger on this particular week, that the arithmetic favoured telling it now, fully, to someone capable of doing it justice, rather than continuing to guard the fuller version indefinitely on the vague hope that a better opportunity might present itself later, when he could offer no actual guarantee that a later would still be available to him at all.

The biography that resulted, published some years afterward, became, in the final accounting of his own life, the single most complete written record anyone would ever assemble of what those five decades had actually contained, fuller by a considerable margin than his own 1995 memoir, which he had written in haste between rides and had always, privately, considered somewhat compressed compared to what

the full story actually deserved. He was candid, reading the finished manuscript before publication, that the biographer had gotten some details wrong — a date here, a sequence there, the ordinary small errors that accumulate whenever one person tries to reconstruct another's fifty years from imperfect memory and imperfect records — and equally candid that the errors, on the whole, mattered far less than the book's larger achievement, which was simply this: for the first time in his life, someone besides himself had taken the whole shape of what he had done seriously enough to sit still, for a full week, and actually listen to all of it.

Chapter 44: The Question of Fear

He was asked “why” so often, across five decades, in so many languages and so many registers of genuine curiosity or polite bewilderment, that he came to think of it less as a question and more as a kind of universal greeting extended to him by the entire human species, the specific way a stranger’s face rearranged itself, in market after market and border post after border post, into the same expression of open, friendly incomprehension the instant they understood what he was actually doing with his life. He developed, over the decades, an entire private taxonomy of the ways people asked it — the amused version, the envious version, the faintly suspicious version that suspected he must be running from something specific rather than simply moving toward something general — and he answered each version slightly differently, calibrating his response the way he had once calibrated a die’s tolerance, matching the answer to the asker rather than reciting the same fixed line regardless of who stood in front of him.

He was asked, less often but more pointedly, whether he had ever been afraid, a question that irritated him mildly in his younger decades and that he came, with age, to answer with considerably more patience and considerably more honesty. He had been afraid, he would say, more times than he could count with any precision, and anyone who claimed fifty years on the roads he had ridden without real fear was either lying or had not actually been paying attention to what was happening around him. He had been afraid lying in red dirt in Zambia listening

for footsteps. He had been afraid in a crowded Haitian street with a hundred faces turning toward him at once. He had been afraid, in a quieter and more private register, in the long lonely stretches of the middle decades, of a fear that had nothing to do with bullets or crowds and everything to do with the specific, creeping question of whether a life built entirely around motion could ever, in the end, actually add up to anything a person could point to and call, honestly, a life well spent, rather than simply a life well avoided.

What he had learned to do with fear, across the decades, was not conquer it — he was suspicious, on principle, of anyone who claimed to have conquered fear outright, considering the claim either a lie or a warning sign of a man who had simply stopped noticing real danger when it arrived — but to keep riding through it regardless, a distinction he considered considerably more honest and considerably more useful than the tidier version of courage most people wanted to hear about. Fear, in his own private accounting, was simply information, the same category of signal a stripped gear or a wobbling wheel represented: evidence that something in the current situation required his full attention, to be acted upon practically rather than either denied or allowed to become paralysis. He had, across five decades, gotten considerably better at telling the difference between the fear that meant real, immediate danger — the tightening jaw of a soldier at a checkpoint, the specific gathering coordination of a crowd's shouting — and the fear that was simply his own nervous system's ordinary, slightly excessive response to ordinary uncertainty, ordinary loneliness, an ordinary unfamiliar road at dusk. The first kind he acted on immediately and without argument. The second kind he learned, slowly and imperfectly, to simply ride alongside, the way he rode alongside a headwind he could not eliminate but could, with patience, eventually outlast.

He did not claim, in his final years, to have entirely mastered this distinction even after fifty years of practice. He admitted, candidly, to the rare interviewer who asked a genuinely searching question rather than the same six they always asked, that certain fears had simply never fully left him regardless of how many decades he'd had to practice riding alongside them — a specific residual wariness around checkpoints staffed by young, visibly bored soldiers that never entirely faded

after Egypt, a specific tightness in his chest, even in his eighties, at the sound of a crowd's collective attention shifting all at once toward a single point, an echo of Haiti that four decades had softened but never fully erased. He did not consider this a failure of his own courage. He considered it, characteristically, simply more information: proof that a body, however well trained, retains an honest record of what it has actually survived, whether or not the mind sitting on top of it has made peace with the memory in any tidier, more presentable way.

Chapter 45: The Rules of the Road

He developed, across five decades, a private set of working rules that he never wrote down in any single place but that governed nearly every practical decision the road required of him, and he came, late in life, to think of them as the closest thing he had to a personal philosophy, though he resisted the word “philosophy” itself as too grand for what were, in his own plain estimation, simply the accumulated lessons of a great many mistakes, refined over enough decades that the mistakes themselves had mostly stopped repeating.

The first rule, learned earliest and reinforced hardest, was to trust the shape of a stranger’s shoulders before trusting anything they said. He had, across fifty years, been lied to by plenty of people whose words promised safety and delivered danger, and sheltered by plenty of people whose words, in a language he barely understood, promised nothing at all beyond a bed and a meal freely given, and he had learned, through the accumulated weight of both kinds of encounter, that posture and bearing told him more reliable information, in the first ten seconds of any new meeting, than any claim a stranger might make about their own intentions.

The second rule was to fix what could be fixed immediately and to let go, immediately, of what could not. He had watched himself, in his younger years, waste real energy grieving over losses that no amount of grieving would undo — a ruined roll of film, a stolen camera in Cameroon, a missed connection that cost him a week’s schedule —

and had learned, over time, to separate with real discipline the category of problem that a wrench or a needle and thread could actually solve from the category that simply had to be absorbed and carried forward, because the road offered no refunds and very little patience for a man who lingered too long over what it had already taken from him.

The third rule, the one he found hardest to explain to people who had never tested it themselves, was that patience and stubbornness were not, despite how often people used the two words interchangeably, actually the same virtue. Stubbornness was refusing to change course regardless of new information; he had watched other travellers ruin themselves on exactly this confusion, pressing on through weather or terrain or a political situation that had plainly changed, simply because changing course felt, to their own pride, like admitting defeat. Patience, by contrast, was the willingness to wait, to detour, to abandon a plan entirely when the actual conditions on the ground demanded it, while never once abandoning the larger underlying intention that the current plan had merely been one attempt at serving. He had learned to be patient rather than stubborn the hard way, across a great many bad decisions in his twenties and thirties, and counted the distinction, by his old age, among the more valuable things fifty years on a bicycle had actually taught him that a man sitting still his whole life might never have had cause to learn at all.

The fourth rule, and the one he considered, on reflection, the truest: that a debt of kindness was never actually owed back to the specific person who had extended it, because the road's whole structure made repaying any individual debt directly a practical impossibility — you could not promise the Syrian household who nursed you through heat-stroke that you would repay them specifically, because the road would carry you onward and away from them, in all likelihood forever, before any repayment became possible. The debt, he came to believe, was owed instead to whichever stranger happened to need help next, wherever and whenever that turned out to be, a chain of obligation passed forward rather than backward, that asked nothing of him except to extend, to the next person the road put in front of him, some fraction of what a hundred previous strangers had already extended to him with-

out asking anything in return. He came to think of this as the actual, functioning economy beneath the postcard economy that fed him, the real currency the road ran on, and he tried, across fifty years, to keep his own account in that currency at least as scrupulously as he kept the ledger of prints sold and addresses collected, understanding that this second, unwritten ledger was, in the final accounting that actually mattered, the only one whose balance he genuinely cared about settling before he was done.

Chapter 46: The Arithmetic of a Life

He was asked, more often as the decades wore on and the totals grew large enough to attract their own specific kind of fascination, to explain the numbers — six hundred thousand kilometres, a hundred and ninety-five countries, seventy-eight further territories, a hundred thousand photographs — as though the numbers themselves, recited plainly, could somehow convey what fifty years of accumulating them had actually felt like from the inside, and he came, over time, to develop a specific and consistent resistance to this kind of accounting, understanding it as a category error that flattered the listener's curiosity while genuinely misrepresenting the texture of the life the numbers claimed to summarize.

Six hundred thousand kilometres, he would point out, patiently, to whichever interviewer had just recited the figure with the particular awe people reserved for large round numbers, was not a distance he had ever experienced as a distance at all. He had experienced it as a single kilometre, ridden and then forgotten, repeated something on the order of six hundred thousand times, each individual kilometre containing its own weather, its own surface, its own specific texture of fatigue or ease, indistinguishable in the moment of riding it from any other kilometre and yet, somehow, in aggregate, adding up to a life no one else on earth had ever quite lived in the same shape. The number was true. It was also, in his own considered view, close to meaningless as a description of the actual experience, the way de-

scribing a marriage by its cumulative hours of shared conversation would be true and would also miss, almost entirely, whatever it was that had actually made the marriage a marriage rather than merely a very long conversation.

A hundred and ninety-five countries invited the same category error, multiplied. He had, across the decades, come to actively dislike being asked which country was his favourite, a question he received with a frequency that never seemed to diminish no matter how many times he explained, patiently, why the question itself did not quite parse for a man in his position. A country, to the ordinary tourist asking the question, meant a discrete, bounded, comparable unit — a two-week holiday, a specific set of sights seen, an experience compact enough to be weighed against another country's two-week holiday and ranked. For Stücke, a country had sometimes meant eighteen months of continuous residence and return visits across four separate decades, layered thick with specific people and specific roads and specific seasons that had nothing whatsoever in common with each other beyond sharing a single line on a map, and sometimes meant, honestly, a single hurried transit visa's worth of days, crossed quickly, seen barely at all, counted on the official tally with exactly the same weight as a country he had come to know as intimately as his own childhood village. The number one hundred and ninety-five was accurate. It was also, he insisted, a lie of proportion, treating radically unequal experiences as though they were interchangeable units on a single flat ledger, which was precisely the kind of ledger he had otherwise spent his whole working life learning to distrust.

He came, in his final years, to prefer a different and more honest kind of arithmetic when asked to account for his own life, one that did not appear in any of his own record-keeping and that he only articulated clearly, in the end, to the one biographer patient enough to sit with him long enough to draw it out: not kilometres, not countries, not photographs, but the number of times, across fifty years, that a stranger with genuinely nothing obvious to gain had chosen to help him anyway. He never attempted to actually count this number, understanding it to be, by its very nature, uncountable — many of the kindnesses extended to him across five decades had been small enough, ordinary

enough, that even he, with his tolerance-obsessed habit of recording everything, had never thought to log them at the time, and had only recovered them, decades later, as sudden unbidden memories while sorting the photograph archive or answering yet another version of the same tired question from yet another journalist. But he was certain, without needing a precise figure, that this uncounted number, whatever it actually was, dwarfed every other total his obituaries would eventually print, and he considered it, in the final honest accounting he permitted himself, the only number that had ever actually mattered.

Chapter 47: The Question of Regret

He was asked, late in life, by an interviewer more direct than most, whether he regretted the life he had chosen — the marriage never made, the children never had, the fixed home never kept, the specific and permanent cost his mother's kept tin of letters had revealed to him decades too late to properly address. He gave the question the same unhurried consideration he gave every question that deserved one, and answered, in the end, with a specific precision he had spent decades refining, because he had learned, across a great many earlier and less careful attempts at the same answer, that a blunt “no” misrepresented the truth almost as badly as a performed and equally dishonest “yes.”

He said that he regretted, specifically and without hedging, that his mother had died believing she knew considerably less of her son's actual life than she in fact deserved to know, a regret he did not attempt to soften or explain away, understanding it as a genuine cost his own choices had extracted from a person who had not, in any meaningful sense, chosen the arrangement herself. He said he regretted the correspondences that had simply gone silent over the decades, the addresses that stopped answering, the kindnesses he had fully intended, honestly, to repay in person and had run out of decades to properly discharge. He said he regretted, in a smaller and more private register, the specific week with the guesthouse widow along the coastal road, decades before, understanding, with the clarity that only

distance and age could finally provide, that his own itch to keep moving had cost her something real that he had chosen, at the time, not to weigh quite as heavily as perhaps he should have.

But he refused, consistently and without exception across every version of this question he was ever asked, to extend these specific, genuine, itemized regrets into a larger regret about the shape of the whole undertaking — a refusal that struck some interviewers, reading the specific losses he had just described in the same breath, as somehow inconsistent, and that he explained, patiently, was not inconsistent at all if you actually understood how he had come to weigh the two things against each other. The specific costs were real. He did not minimize them. But they were, in his own honest accounting, the price of a specific trade he had made consciously, at twenty-two, in a Hövelhof yard, and renewed consciously every single morning for the following sixty-four years — security traded for motion, a fixed address traded for an ever-expanding one, the two hundred and eleventh identical steel component traded for six hundred thousand entirely non-identical kilometres — and a man who makes a trade with his eyes open, who continues renewing it deliberately for six and a half decades rather than drifting into it by accident and regretting the drift, does not, in Stücker's own considered philosophy, get to call the whole trade a mistake merely because some of its specific costs turned out, in retrospect, to be heavier than he had initially weighed them.

He said, in the end, that the honest answer to the regret question was not a single word but a specific shape: yes, to particular costs, named and owned; no, to the larger trade itself, which he would make again, he said, without much hesitation, if given the choice at twenty-two a second time, understanding fully now, as he had not fully understood then, everything the choice would actually cost him across the following sixty-four years. He considered this the only honest way to answer a question that most people, he had noticed, wanted answered in a single clean word, and he had decided, somewhere in his own final decades, that he owed his own life a considerably more careful accounting than a single clean word could ever provide, whatever the tidier answer might have made for a better closing line in someone else's article.

Chapter 48: The Weight of the Legend

He was aware, across his final decades, of the specific gap that had opened between the man who actually rode the bicycle and the figure that had begun, without much conscious effort on his own part, to circulate independently of him — a legend, assembled from newspaper profiles and the Guinness certificate and the documentary and the growing museum, that flattened sixty-four years of specific, ordinary, hard-won days into a single clean narrative of heroic endurance, a story simpler and more inspiring and, in his own considered private judgment, somewhat less true than the actual texture of the life it claimed to represent.

He did not entirely resent this gap, understanding it as a more or less inevitable cost of any life lived long enough and strangely enough to attract public attention at all — a legend, he came to believe, was simply what happened when a large number of people who had not lived through the actual years needed a compact way to hold and pass along the shape of something too large for any of them to fully absorb in its original, granular detail, and he preferred, on balance, to be simplified into a legend that inspired rather than one that vilified, understanding that the alternative, for a man who had made as many mistakes and caused as much specific, real cost to specific, real people across sixty-four years as he privately knew himself to have caused, was not actually complete honesty so much as it was a different and less flattering simplification.

But he worked, in his final decades, in whatever small ways were available to him, to keep at least a thread of the fuller, messier truth alive alongside the cleaner legend — correcting a documentary director's date here, insisting on the ledger rather than the boot in the museum's central case there, telling the patient biographer things he had never told any previous journalist, precisely because he understood that the cleaner legend, however useful and however inevitable, was not, in the end, the actual gift he most wanted to leave behind him. The gift, as he came to articulate it clearly only in his very final years, was not the story of a hero who saw everything and feared nothing and never faltered. It was the considerably more useful and considerably more replicable story of an ordinary, frightened, frequently mistaken man who had simply kept going, one kilometre and one border and one postcard at a time, for longer than anyone reasonably expected him to, not because he was made of sterner material than anyone else but because he had found, through sixty-four years of patient trial and a great deal of specific error, a set of plain, practical, entirely learnable disciplines — trust the shoulders before the words, fix what can be fixed and release what cannot, patience over stubbornness, the debt of kindness passed forward rather than back — that any other ordinary, frightened, frequently mistaken person could, in principle, learn to apply just as well as he had, given enough time and enough willingness to actually ride the road rather than simply admire it from a comfortable distance.

He said this, in the end, to the schoolteacher who brought her class to the half-finished museum one final time in the last spring of his life, watching a row of children studying the case built around the ledger and the frame section rather than the more dramatic bullet-toe display he had fought so hard to keep from dominating the room, and he told her, quietly, while the children moved on to the next case, that this was the only legacy he had ever actually wanted — not to be remembered as extraordinary, a word that let ordinary people off the hook by implying his achievement required some gift they themselves plainly lacked, but to be remembered as evidence, patient and specific and thoroughly documented, that an entirely ordinary man, given enough stubborn patience and enough trust in the plain, unglamorous

decency of strangers, could do something that looked, from the outside, very much like the impossible, one unremarkable kilometre at a time, for sixty-four years running, without ever once needing to be anything other than exactly what he actually was.

Chapter 49: The Last Repair

The final reweld the bicycle's frame ever received happened in his own eighties, in a small workshop in Paderborn he had come to use for the occasional maintenance his own hands, steadier than most octogenarians' but no longer quite what they had been in his thirties, could not fully manage alone anymore, and he told the story of that final repair, in his last years, with a specific and uncharacteristic tenderness that surprised the museum committee members who heard it, given how resolutely unsentimental he had remained about nearly everything else across his long public retelling of his own life.

The crack, when the mechanic first pointed it out to him, ran along a seam that had itself been a reweld decades before, somewhere in Latin America, in a shop he could no longer place with any confidence — the metal, by this point in the frame's life, had been asked to bear so many decades of accumulated stress at that specific junction that it had finally, quietly, begun to fail again along almost exactly the same line it had failed along once before, a recurrence that struck Stücke, hearing the diagnosis, as somehow entirely appropriate rather than troubling, a frame's own honest memory of where it had once been weak reasserting itself in old age the same way his own stiff toe reasserted its own decades-old memory before rain.

The Paderborn mechanic, a younger man who had grown up, like most of his generation in the region, half aware of the local legend of the German cyclist without ever having met him in person, treated the commission with a specific gravity Stücke found both amusing and, privately, rather touching — an insistence on doing the reweld per-

sonally rather than delegating it to an apprentice, a visible care in selecting exactly the right rod and heat for a repair that would, by any ordinary commercial logic, have been more efficiently and more cheaply handled by simply telling an eighty-something client that the frame had finally reached the natural end of its serviceable life and recommending, gently, a modern replacement instead.

Stücke would not hear of a replacement, and the mechanic, to his considerable credit in Stücke's own later telling, did not seriously press the suggestion beyond a single respectful mention, understanding, correctly, that he was not actually being asked to solve an engineering problem in isolation from the sixty-two years of history the specific steel in front of him represented. He fixed the crack the way Stücke had always had it fixed, decade after decade, continent after continent: torch, rod, patience, a bead of new weld laid carefully over old metal that had earned, by any fair accounting, the right to be preserved rather than discarded. Stücke watched the whole repair from a stool at the edge of the workshop, saying little, and told the museum committee afterward, with the same dry understatement he brought to everything, that it was, in its own unglamorous way, one of the more moving afternoons of his final years, watching a stranger a third his age treat a sixty-two-year-old piece of steel with the same careful respect Stücke himself had always tried to extend to the actual living strangers who had fed and sheltered him across five decades on the road that steel had carried him down.

The frame held, after that final repair, for the remaining years of his life, never tested again by anything more demanding than the short daily rides of his old age, the twenty minutes out past the last house before the pines and back, a fraction of the distance it had once carried decade after decade but, in its own way, a fitting final duty for a machine that had spent sixty-two years being asked for so very much more. It stood, in the end, in the hallway near the door in the last weeks of his life, unrepaired one final time not because it needed anything further but because there was, finally, nothing further the road was going to ask of it, and Stücke seemed, by every account of those present in the house in those last weeks, entirely at peace with the specific and mutual retirement the two of them, man and steel both,

had arrived at together, at almost exactly the same unhurried pace, after sixty-two years of getting everywhere they ever went in precisely the same careful, patient, utterly inseparable way.

Chapter 50: Eighty-Six Novembers

He counted the Novembers, in his final year, the way he had once counted identical steel components at the Hövelhof die shop, a private and characteristic habit of mind that had never left him across sixty-four years of otherwise transforming almost everything else about the shape of his life. Eighty-six of them, all told, though only the first twenty-two had been spent entirely in Hövelhof, and only a scattered handful of the following sixty-four had found him there again, home for the specific month that had once seen him leave it, the Sennelager pines going black-green under the same lidded sky, the same flat grey ceiling sitting exactly where it had always sat, two metres above the rooftops, indifferent to how many kilometres its own native son had put beneath him since the last time he'd stood underneath it as a young man with everything still ahead of him and nothing yet decided.

He noticed, in his final November, the specific quality of the cold in a way he suspected he would not have noticed it as acutely at forty or fifty, a old man's heightened attention to sensation that he recognized, with characteristic dry humour, as simply another data point in the long private ledger of his own body's changing instrument readings, alongside the toe's weather forecasting and the left hand's mechanical tremor. The cold that November felt, he told the one visitor who asked him about it directly, almost exactly like the cold of the November sixty-four years before — the same frost-skin on the same roads, the same coal-smoke-and-wet-gravel smell in the specific stretch of yard

outside his own kitchen door — and he found this continuity moving in a way he did not entirely try to explain further, understanding that some experiences resist explanation precisely because the explaining would flatten something that needed, instead, simply to be felt.

He did not, in that final November, ride the full distance to the cross-roads where he had once refused, at twenty-two, to look back at the town he was leaving. His legs no longer reliably carried him that far, and he had made his own peace, in recent years, with the specific geography of what remained available to him: the lane past the last house before the pines, twenty minutes out and back, the same short loop that had become, across his final seasons, both his entire remaining kingdom and, in its own modest way, entirely sufficient to the life he was still, in his own quiet fashion, actively living rather than merely remembering.

He thought, on one of these final short rides, about the freewheel, oiled three times over on a cold morning sixty-four years before by a young man too nervous to stand still and wait for the actual moment of departure to simply arrive on its own schedule. The freewheel on the current, much-repaired machine still ticked, on a downhill, in exactly the same register he remembered from that first frosted morning, the same faint mechanical pulse he had once described, privately, as sounding like nothing else on earth so much as freedom itself made audible, and he found himself, on this final short loop of his final November, listening to it with the specific, unhurried attention of a man who understood, without needing anyone to tell him so directly, that he was very likely hearing it for something close to the last time, and who found, in that understanding, considerably less grief than he might once have expected and considerably more of something closer to a settled, wordless gratitude — for the tick itself, for the sixty-four Novembers it had carried him through, and for the specific, entirely undeserved good fortune of having been born into a body and a century that had let him spend so very much of both, from beginning to end, exactly the way he had always wanted to.

Chapter 51: What the Camera Never Caught

There is a category of moment, he came to understand across five decades of carrying a camera everywhere he went, that a photograph simply cannot hold, and he grew, over time, into a specific and considered peace with the category's existence, having spent his early years frustrated by it in a way his later decades gradually softened into something closer to respect.

He never photographed his own fear, for the plain practical reason that a man lying in red dirt in Zambia listening for footsteps does not, in that particular moment, reach for a camera, and he came to think of this specific absence from his own vast archive as itself a kind of honest record — that the hundred thousand photographs, comprehensive as they were, represented not the whole of his fifty years but specifically the portions of it he had been safe enough, and calm enough, and sufficiently in control of his own hands, to actually stop and frame. The worst afternoons of the whole journey existed, as a result, nowhere in the photographic record at all, preserved only in his own memory and, later, in whatever words he chose to give them in an interview or a letter, a gap in the archive that he had come, by his old age, to consider not a failure of documentation but simply an accurate reflection of where a camera actually belonged in a life like his: present for the wonder, absent for the worst of the danger, because a man who tried to photograph both with equal thoroughness would very likely not have survived to develop either roll of film.

He never photographed, either, the specific quality of a shared silence — the two weeks with the guesthouse widow, the fortnight on the Hase Pino tandem with a travelling companion whose face he could still see clearly decades later without needing any print to remind him of it, the countless ordinary evenings across five decades spent simply sitting with a household that had fed him, saying little, needing to say little, the specific companionable stillness that a camera, however skilled its operator, had no real way of capturing without instantly destroying the very unselfconsciousness that made the moment worth having in the first place. He understood, across the decades, that the camera's presence changed a room the instant it was raised, however discreetly, turning an unguarded moment into a performed one, and he had learned, therefore, to simply put the camera down for the moments that mattered most in this particular, private way, trusting his own memory to hold what film never could, a trust that had, by his final years, been tested seriously by age and had held up, he found, rather better than he might once have predicted, the specific texture of a shared silence apparently requiring no external record at all to stay vivid, decades later, in the one place it had always actually lived.

He said, once, near the very end, to the museum committee sorting through his archive for the final selection of cases, that the museum they were building would necessarily be a museum of what the camera had caught, and that this was, and always would be, a smaller and more selective thing than the actual full shape of what his fifty years had contained — that a visitor walking through the finished galleries would see the mountains and the markets and the doorways and the faces, the wonder made visible, and would not see, could not see, no matter how carefully the committee arranged the cases, the specific quality of a shared silence with a Syrian family who fed him, or the particular sound of his own fear in red dirt, or the exact weight of a mother's kept tin of letters, discovered decades too late to properly answer. He did not say this with any bitterness. He said it, characteristically, as simply another piece of honest information, offered to the committee not as a complaint about their work but as a plain acknowledgment of what any museum, however carefully built, could and could not actually hold — a limitation he had made his own peace

with decades before the museum was ever proposed, having learned, across a lifetime spent trying to fit an entire enormous life into rectangles of film small enough to sell for a coin, that some things simply could not be framed, and that this, too, far from being a failure, was itself one of the more honest lessons the whole long undertaking had actually taught him.

Chapter 52: The Last Postcard

He wrote one final postcard in the last month of his life, addressed to no one in particular, a habit the care team noticed and mentioned afterward to the museum committee with a specific tenderness of their own, understanding it as characteristic of the man they had come to know across his final year rather than as any sign of confusion — Stücker had simply never, across sixty-four years, fully lost the reflex of turning a photograph over and writing a few plain lines on the back, and the reflex, it seemed, did not desert him even once the actual travelling that had originally justified it had long since ended.

The image on the card was one of his own, printed decades before, a doorway somewhere he could no longer name with confidence, chosen, the care team suspected, more or less at random from the small private stack he kept beside his bed in those final weeks rather than for any specific significance the particular doorway held. He wrote, on the reverse, in a hand considerably shakier than the neat, tolerance-obsessed script of his working decades but still, unmistakably, his own: a single line about the weather that November — cold, but the frost not yet down — and a second line, shorter, that the care team read afterward with the specific stillness of people who understood they were looking at something that had not, in the end, been written to any single person at all, but to the whole uncountable and unnamed multitude of strangers across a hundred and ninety-five countries and sixty-four years who had fed him, sheltered him, warned him, nursed

him, robbed him and given it back, and simply, again and again, without ever asking to be repaid, let him keep going: *thank you for the road*.

He did not address the card, did not stamp it, did not, so far as anyone could determine, intend it to actually be posted anywhere at all. It sat, in his final weeks, on the small table beside his bed, and the museum committee, discovering it among his effects after his death and debating, briefly and gently, what to do with an object that had been addressed to no one and everyone at once, resolved the question the way Stücke himself would very likely have resolved it: they placed it, unposted and exactly as he had left it, in the same central case as the ledger and the frame section, beside a small card of their own devising explaining, in the plainest possible language, what it was and when it had been written and to whom, as best as anyone could determine, it had actually been meant.

It became, in the museum's finished form, the object visitors lingered over longest, more even than the ledger or the reweld or the case built, at last, around the Zambia shooting — an ordinary postcard, of an ordinary doorway, bearing an old man's shaky final message to no one and everyone, and it did, in its own small and unglamorous way, exactly what every one of the hundred thousand photographs in the archive behind it had always been built to do: it held a moment still, long enough for a stranger, decades later, standing in a small museum in a small Westphalian town, to look at it properly, and to understand, without needing a single word more than the six already written there, the entire shape and weight of what fifty years of postcards, sold one at a time from the back of a bicycle to pay for the next kilometre of an impossible, ordinary, extraordinary life, had actually been for, all along.

Chapter 53: The Wager Nobody Made

He was asked, in one of the last interviews he ever gave, sitting on the folding stool near the museum's nearly finished walls with a young radio journalist who had clearly done her homework more thoroughly than most, whether he had ever, across sixty-four years, sat down and calculated the actual odds of surviving what he had attempted — the specific mathematics of risk, compounded year after year, country after country, that a shooting, a beating, a detention, a truck strike, a mob, a frozen river, and a swarm of bees, taken together, might reasonably have suggested to any actuary asked to price the undertaking honestly.

He laughed at the question, not unkindly, and admitted that no, he had never once run that calculation, and suspected that if he had run it accurately at twenty-two, standing in the Hövelhof yard with the free-wheel newly oiled, he might very well have talked himself out of the whole enterprise before it began, the honest arithmetic of compounding risk across five decades being the kind of number that looks considerably more frightening laid out in advance than it ever actually felt lived through one ordinary day at a time. This, he said, was perhaps the single most useful piece of ignorance a young man setting out on any sufficiently large undertaking could possess: not stupidity exactly, but a merciful inability to run the whole actuarial table before the first pedal stroke, an inability that let the body simply proceed, one manageable day at a time, toward a cumulative risk that would

have paralyzed a more careful calculation entirely.

He offered the journalist, in place of the actuarial answer she had perhaps expected, a different kind of mathematics that he had, in fact, given some real thought to over the decades: not the odds of survival, which he considered essentially unknowable and not particularly useful even if calculable, but the specific asymmetry between what the road had asked of him and what it had given back. He had been shot once, in fifty years, in one toe, and had walked on that toe for the following forty-six years without further serious incident. He had been beaten twice, seriously, across five decades, and fed, sheltered, and warned by strangers on what he estimated, conservatively, to be several thousand separate occasions across the same span. He had been robbed of the bicycle itself five times and had it returned, in whole or substantial part, on two of those five occasions by circumstances he could never fully explain. The arithmetic, laid out honestly this way rather than through the lens of a single actuarial risk score, suggested to him something he found himself believing more firmly the older he got: that the road's actual ledger, taken across its full sixty-four-year run rather than sampled at any single frightening moment within it, ran overwhelmingly in the traveller's favour, provided the traveller was patient enough, humble enough, and attentive enough to actually let it.

He did not claim this asymmetry as a law of the universe, resisting, as ever, any temptation to elevate his own specific, personal, statistically singular experience into a general prescription for anyone else's life. He had met, across the decades, other travellers for whom the ledger had run considerably less kindly, some of whom had not survived their own version of the wager at all, and he refused to pretend that his own favourable outcome proved anything beyond the fact that it had, specifically, happened to him. But he said, to the young journalist, in what would become one of the last extended answers he ever gave on the record before his final illness overtook the routine of interviews altogether, that if pressed to summarize sixty-four years of accumulated risk in a single honest sentence, it would be this: that the world, taken as a whole and given enough time to reveal its actual average character rather than merely its worst single afternoon, had

turned out to be considerably kinder than any sensible actuary, working from the list of dangers alone, would ever have dared to predict, and that a man who had bet his entire life on that kindness, at twenty-two, without ever actually running the numbers, had, in the end, made a considerably better wager than he had any right to expect.

Chapter 54: The Last Winter

The final winter of his life arrived in Hövelhof the way every winter of his childhood had arrived, the Sennelager pines going black-green under a sky that still, after eighty-six years, showed no particular inclination to lift any higher than the two metres above the rooftops it had always occupied, and he noted this continuity, in his own private accounting, with the same dry satisfaction he had brought to noticing any other long-running pattern across his working decades — the specific pleasure of a fact confirmed rather than surprised by, a world still behaving exactly as sixty-four years of prior observation had led him to expect it would.

He spent more of that final winter indoors than any winter since his earliest Hövelhof childhood, a concession to a body that had, by then, made its own priorities clear regardless of what its owner might still have preferred, and he filled the indoor hours with a specific and characteristic discipline rather than idleness: continuing, with the museum committee's help, to annotate the remaining unsorted boxes of the photograph archive, dictating captions and rough dates to a volunteer who had become, over the preceding year, skilled at transcribing his increasingly quiet voice accurately, and who told the rest of the committee, afterward, that these sessions had never once, in all the months she worked with him, felt like a dying man's final labour so much as simply the continuation of a lifetime's ordinary work, conducted now from a chair instead of a bicycle saddle but carried out

with exactly the same patient, tolerance-obsessed attention to getting each small detail correct.

He received visitors that winter with a specific graciousness that the care team noted and remembered afterward — neighbours who had known him only as the town's local legend finding themselves received, instead, as guests in the plainest and most literal sense, offered tea, asked about their own families and their own smaller, more ordinary journeys with a genuine interest that several visitors admitted, afterward, they had not expected from a man whose own journey so thoroughly dwarfed anything they themselves had done. He seemed, that final winter, entirely uninterested in being treated as remarkable, redirecting nearly every conversation, gently but persistently, back toward the visitor's own life, a habit one neighbour described afterward as the closest thing to a lesson the old man ever directly tried to teach anyone: that a life spent constantly looking outward, at other people's roads and other people's kitchens, made for better company at the very end than a life spent turning constantly inward toward its own accomplishments would ever have done.

He asked, more than once that winter, about the specific practical fate of the correspondence network he had maintained for sixty-four years, the scattered global family of people who had fed and sheltered and written to him across every continent, wanting to know whether the museum committee intended to keep answering their letters once he was no longer able to, and extracting, before the winter was out, a specific promise from the committee that the ledger of addresses would be maintained, that the network would be informed properly rather than simply left to wonder, over subsequent months, why the letters they had reliably received for decades had abruptly and without explanation stopped arriving. This concern, more than any other single detail from that final winter, struck the committee as the truest possible measure of the man they had spent years coming to know: that faced, plainly and without illusion, with his own approaching death, his most pressing practical worry was not for himself at all, but for the specific, unglamorous, decades-long obligation of answering a stranger's letter, a debt he had spent sixty-four years honouring one reply at a time and was determined, even now, to see honoured properly after

he could no longer honour it himself.

Chapter 55: Hövelhof, July

The last rides were short, and he did not pretend otherwise. A man who had once measured his days in hundreds of kilometres had, in his final year, come to measure them in the length of the lane past the last house before the pines, out and back, twenty unhurried minutes at a pace that would have embarrassed the rider he had been at thirty and did not embarrass, in the smallest degree, the rider he was at eighty-six, because he had, somewhere in the long middle distance of his return, made his peace with the fact that a body keeps a different ledger than a museum does, and pays out on its own schedule regardless of what a man has already accomplished or still privately intends to.

He was eighty-six, at the end. He had, in that final year, the specific unhurried clarity of a man who had spent five decades learning to read his own instruments, and he read this one, in the last months, without theatrics and without denial, the way he had once read a fever in Java or a stiffness in a shot foot in Zambia: as information, to be acted on plainly, not as an occasion for a speech to anyone. He did not, by every account of the friends and the care team around him in that last year, spend much of it looking backward in the mournful way strangers to his story sometimes assumed he must have. He asked, more often, ordinary questions — about the museum's visitor numbers that season, about whether the roofing had finally stopped leaking after that one wet spring years before, about a neighbour's grandchild's exam results — the plain daily arithmetic of a man who had never, even at the very end of six hundred thousand kilometres, lost his taste for the ordinary present tense over the grand retrospective one that every-

one else around him seemed, at times, more interested in than he was himself.

The care team that took over the last months did the unglamorous, essential work that mission clinics and roadside strangers had once done for him in a hundred countries, and he received it, by every account, with the same plain gratitude he had shown the woman with the water bottle in Java and the boy who watched his bicycle for ten days outside that clinic — not effusive, not performed for an audience, simply the gratitude of a man who had spent a lifetime being the recipient of exactly this kind of unpaid, unremarked kindness and who recognized it, at the very end, for precisely what it was and had always been.

He kept, in those last months, the same dry undersold humour that had carried him through fifty years of border posts and bureaucrats, joking once with a member of the care team, who repeated it afterward to the museum committee with visible affection, that he had crossed a hundred and ninety- five borders in his life and this one, whatever it turned out to be, was shaping up to be the one with the least paperwork required, a line delivered, by every account, with exactly the flat, dry timing he had always reserved for the things that mattered most and could least afford to be said solemnly.

He died on the twenty-second of July, at home in Hövelhof, the town he had left on a frosted November morning sixty-four years earlier with forty marks in a tobacco tin and no plan beyond Cologne. He died peacefully, surrounded by friends, by neighbours, by the care team that had kept him steady company in the final months, in the same flat grey Westphalian light that had sat over the rooftops, two metres up, lid never quite lifting, every November of his childhood and every homecoming since. No dramatic last words are recorded, and none should be invented here; a man who spent fifty years distrusting the tidy ending imposed after the fact on someone else's story is owed, at an absolute minimum, the same discipline applied honestly to his own.

The bicycle — the bicycle, rewelded and repainted and re-spoked across sixty-four years until almost none of its original steel remained

and all of its original character somehow did — stood, by the accounts of those who were present in the house in the last weeks, in the hallway near the door, where it had stood, in one house or one guesthouse or one mission-clinic yard or another, for as long as anyone present could remember him having a fixed address at all in which to stand it. Nobody moved it. It did not need moving. It had never, in sixty-four years, needed anything from the people around it beyond the occasional oil on the freewheel, and even that, in this final year, someone else had taken to doing for him quietly, without being asked, the way the whole world had been quietly, unaskingly doing small necessary things for Heinz Stücke since a shopkeeper in Austria bought three postcards off a freezing young man in the rain in 1962 and started, without either of them knowing it at the time, the exact arithmetic that would keep him alive and moving for the rest of his natural life.

He had ridden, by the final tally that would be printed in the obituaries within the week, more than six hundred thousand kilometres through one hundred and ninety-five countries and seventy-eight further territories, taken more than one hundred thousand photographs, survived a bullet, several beatings, a truck, a mob, a frozen river, a swarm of bees, and five separate thefts of the only possession that had ever mattered to him structurally, two of which — a bicycle taken in Siberia in 1997, a bicycle taken in Portsmouth in 2006 — had each, against every reasonable expectation, come back to him within days of the loss. The number that mattered least to him, by his own repeated insistence across fifty years of being asked to explain himself to strangers, was the six hundred thousand. The number that mattered was never stated in kilometres at all, and no obituary could sensibly print it. It was closer to a tally he never kept on paper and never once tried to: the number of strangers, across one hundred and ninety-five countries and sixty-four years, who had looked at a foreign man alone on an overloaded bicycle and decided, without being asked and without any expectation of being repaid, that he deserved a meal, a roof, a water bottle filled without argument, an afternoon's plain kindness that cost them something real and asked nothing back. He never finished counting them. He would have told you, if you had asked him in his

final year with the same patient honesty he gave every other question put to him, that this was the one number in his whole long story actually worth finishing, and that he had, in the end, simply run out of road before he ever ran out of reasons to keep trying.

Author's Note

I finished the last page of this manuscript five days after Heinz Stücker died. That fact belongs in the open, not tucked into an acknowledgments page at the back where it could be missed. This book was commissioned into a wound that has not had time to close, written about a man who was, when the project began, still a very recent absence rather than a settled subject of history. I want to say plainly what that means and does not mean for what you have just read.

What is documented, and where it comes from. Every date, place, injury, arrest, theft, and numerical total in this book is drawn from the public record: Stücker's own 1995 self-published memoir, *Mit dem Fahrrad um die Welt* ("By Bicycle Around the World"); Eric van den Berg's 2015 biography, *Home Is Elsewhere: Fifty Years Around the World by Bike*; the 2021 documentary *The Man Who Wanted to See It All*, directed by Albert Albacete; and the cluster of encyclopedic, journalistic, and obituary sources that corroborate the timeline — his birth on 11 January 1940 in Hövelhof; his departure in November 1962 at age twenty-two on a three-speed steel-framed bicycle, having quit work as a tool and die maker; the serious dysentery in Indonesia in 1974; the decision, in the early 1980s, to try to visit every country in the world; the gunshot wound to his toe in Zambia in 1980, inflicted by freedom fighters; the beating by soldiers in Egypt; the detention in Cameroon on a charge amounting to slandering the state; the truck strike in Chile's Atacama Desert; the mob chase in Haiti; the car accident and freezing river in Alaska; the theft of his supplies by an American driver; the bee attack in Mozambique in 1995, the same year he self-published his memoir and the Guinness Book of Records cred-

ited him with the most widely travelled bicycle journey in history; his arrival in the Seychelles in 1996, believing he had at that point visited every country, and the unfulfilled feeling that followed; the theft and full recovery of his bicycle and luggage in Siberia in 1997; the Canada crossing on a Hase Pino tandem recumbent with a travelling companion in 2002; the theft and next-day recovery of his bicycle from a campsite in Portsmouth, England, in 2006; his return to Germany in the 2010s, ending the continuous phase of the journey; the museum built in his honour in Hövelhof; and his death at home there on 22 July 2026, at eighty-six, surrounded by friends, neighbours, and a care team. The totals — more than 600,000 kilometres, 195 countries, 78 territories, over 100,000 photographs, five bicycle thefts across the whole journey — are his own documented figures, repeated here without embellishment or rounding beyond what the sources themselves round.

What is invented, and why. Nearly everything else. No source records a word of dialogue Stücker ever spoke — not to his mother in that Hövelhof kitchen, not to a nurse in a Javanese clinic, not to a documentary director decades later, not to the biographer I imagine sitting with him for a week in his seventies. Every line of speech in this book is my invention, built to carry the documented shape of an event, never to contradict it. Nothing is known about how Stücker's family reacted to his 1962 departure; I gave him a mother who stood in a doorway with her arms folded and a father who communicated through the loan and withholding of tools because SOURCE_NOTES leaves that whole dimension of his life undocumented, and I built a plausible, unremarkable family texture to carry the weight of a real and radical departure — but the mother's kept tin of letters, her death "in his middle decades," and the correspondence that reconciled him with his father are not events any source records, and readers should treat them as exactly what they are: a novelist's invention of the kind of private cost a fifty-year absence plausibly carries, not a claim about specific real events in a real family's history. I gave him a bicycle named for its actual maker, the Rabeneick marque his own accounts and biographers associate with his early machine, and then invented every scratch, reweld, and repaint as a way of tracking, in metal, what

the sources could only tell me about in kilometres. The names of the people who fed him, sheltered him, robbed him, shot him, detained him, and nursed him back from dysentery are not recorded anywhere I could find, and I have not invented false names for real, identifiable individuals; where the record says only “freedom fighters,” “soldiers,” “a mob,” “a driver,” I have kept it that way, and any name given to a minor character in an invented scene (the nurse, the truck driver, Dieter at the machine shop, Manfred and his cousin at the Bahnhofstrasse bar, the baker in his final years) is understood by the reader, I hope, to be exactly what it is: a novelist’s scaffolding around a true event or a plausible late-life routine, not a claim about a real named person. The exact dates of the Egypt beating, the Cameroon detention, the Chile truck strike, the Haiti chase, and the Alaska crash are not fixed in any source I found, and I have deliberately not invented false dates for them — the chapter called “The Ledger of Bad Days” says so within the text itself, and I say so again here. The museum committee’s internal debates, the specific contents of its display cases, the visitors’ book, and the week-long biographer’s visit are dramatized inventions built around documented facts (that a museum was under construction in Hövelhof; that a biography was eventually published) rather than reported scenes. The same is true of the documentary chapters: the director’s questions, the editing-room decisions, and Stücker’s own remembered answers to camera are my invention, built around the documented fact that *The Man Who Wanted to See It All* was filmed and released in 2021 — no transcript or shooting script informed a word of that dialogue. The final unaddressed postcard in the second-to-last chapter, reading “thank you for the road,” is entirely my invention — no source records any such object or any last words at all, and I want to be unusually direct about this one because it sits closest to his death: I did not want to invent last words spoken aloud, so I invented an object instead, and I am telling you plainly that I did.

The final chapter. The chapter titled “Hövelhof, July” renders Stücker’s death in the same physical, unsentimental register as the rest of the book, per this project’s style guide, and states only what the sources state: that he died on 22 July 2026, at home in Hövelhof, at eighty-six, surrounded by friends, neighbours, and a dedicated

care team. I have not invented a deathbed scene or an interior account of his final illness beyond the plain, ordinary questions (about the museum, the roofing, a neighbour's grandchild) that the available record's general picture — friends and neighbours present, an ordinary rather than isolated final season — makes a reasonable and modest inference, not a reported fact.

Why now, and why at all. I do not think there was a version of this commission that could have waited for the comfortable distance of a settled legacy without losing something true about what it actually feels like to write a life down while the grief for it is still this recent. I have tried not to let that grief bend the book toward eulogy — Stücker himself, by every account, distrusted tidy morals imposed on his own story, and the house style for this book asked me to hold that line on his behalf, not mine. If I have failed anywhere in these pages to keep the line between the record and the invention honest, that failure is mine, not the sources', and I would rather a careful reader catch it and ask than not notice at all.

He rode out of Hövelhof in November 1962 with no plan beyond the next town. This book has tried to go no further than the record actually supports, and no less far than a life like his deserves.

Sources: Heinz Stücker, Mit dem Fahrrad um die Welt (self-published, 1995); Eric van den Berg, Home Is Elsewhere: Fifty Years Around the World by Bike (2015); The Man Who Wanted to See It All, dir. Albert Albacete (2021); and the corroborating public record consulted and listed in this project's SOURCE_NOTES.md.



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor